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LOCAL BODY POLLS

NDA heads for landslide win in Andhra Pradesh

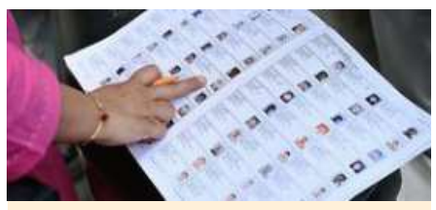
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'BRISK EARNINGS'

Movements create 'protest economy', SC tells traders

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MAHADEVAPURA MYSTERY

803 voter IDs linked to 397 names after SIR

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ARUNACHAL PRADESH FRONTIER

Silence is not a strategy

India's stand on Chinese intrusions risks emboldening Beijing

EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



NEW CHALLENGE

New Zealand, India lock horns in ODIs

SPORT » PAGE 17

INSIDE



Jantar Mantar a road, not protest site: Delhi Police

NEW DELHI

Delhi Police Commissioner submitted in the Supreme Court on Tuesday that Jantar Mantar is not a "site" but a "public road". He said no one can insist on a fundamental right to protest at a particular place and the State can shift venues. » PAGE 4

ECI clears use of Form 6 by voters for re-enrolment

NEW DELHI

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Tuesday said no action would be taken against voters who had been included on a previous electoral roll and submitted Form 6 during SIR, given they were not enrolled in other Lok Sabha or Assembly constituency. » PAGE 5

Tata-Iveco deal: 'global ambition turns into reality'

MUMBAI

Iveco products are set to enter India and Tata vehicles in global markets, with the €3.8-bn acquisition of Iveco Group NV. "The ambition to become a global company has become reality today," said Tata Sons Chairman N. Chandrasekaran. » PAGE 12

Voter IDs will be used for welfare schemes: Minister

NEW DELHI

Voter identity cards, along with biometric authentication, will be the basis for identifying beneficiaries and processing payments for welfare schemes within the ambit of the Panchayati Raj Ministry, Union Panchayati Raj Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh said. » PAGE 6

2 dead as cyclone ravages 3 districts of A.P.

- Over 12,000 evacuated; 52,459 hectares of crops destroyed, 312 homes and power lines damaged
- Storm system weakens after landfall near Ongole on Tuesday morning and moves further inland
- Guntur, Bapatla, and Palnadu are worst-affected districts; 200 mm of rain recorded on Tuesday

Nellore Sravani
VIJAYAWADA

At least two persons were killed on Tuesday after severe cyclonic storm Murasu hit south coastal Andhra Pradesh, destroying standing crops spread over 52,459 hectares and damaging 312 houses and power transmission lines.

The State Disaster Management Authority managing director Prakhar Jain confirmed the deaths and said 12,230 people are currently in rehabilitation centres in the worst-affected districts of Guntur, Bapatla, and Palnadu.

Mr. Jain told *The Hindu* that the two rain-related deaths took place in Bapatla district. "A 25-year-old man in Chinnaganjam and a 65-year-old woman in Karamchedu lost their lives after buildings collapsed on them," the SDMA managing director said.

Trail of destruction

Murasu, which crossed the coast near Ongole in Prakasam district between 3.30 a.m. and 8.30 a.m. brought heavy rain to the parched districts of Prakasam and Palnadu while leaving a trail of destruction. Over 30 trees fell on roads and another 300 were uprooted across eight villages in Prakasam district; more than 200 mobile towers were affected.

The inclement weather disrupted transport and left commuters stranded at several locations. More than 35 trains were cancelled, 14 were diverted, and eight were rescheduled. A number of flights were also cancelled.

Mr. Jain said preliminary reports estimated losses of ₹344 crore and added that the damage was less severe than that caused by Cyclone Arnab last week.



Storm havoc: A building that collapsed in Prakasam district in Andhra Pradesh in rain triggered by Cyclone Murasu on Tuesday. KOMMURI SRINIVAS

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the observed maximum sustained wind speed during Murasu's landfall was 110-120 kmph. Prakasam and Bapatla districts received very heavy rainfall of around 200 mm between 12 a.m. and 6 a.m. on Tuesday.

After landfall, the system moved northwestwards and weakened into a cyclonic storm by noon. It was expected to further weaken into a deep depression by Tuesday night, while moving towards Telangana, the IMD said.

The Budameru rivulet in NTR district, which triggered floods in Vijayawada in 2024, is expected to receive copious inflow, forcing officials to shift people living in low-lying areas to rehabilitation centres.

Highest rainfall

Between 8.30 a.m. and 9 p.m., Marripalem in Palnadu district recorded the day's highest rainfall of 263.75 mm, followed by Ganapavaram at 246.7 mm; Konanki in Bapatla district recorded 213.25 mm of rainfall. Five weather stations, four in Palnadu and one in Bapatla, recorded extremely heavy rainfall above 204.5 mm, while 21 stations in Guntur, Prakasam, and West Godavari districts recorded rainfall above 100 mm.

Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu said the government had effectively dealt with Arnab and Murasu, which hit the Andhra coast in a span of a week. The response was centred on saving lives and limiting property damage, the Chief Minister said, thanking the Centre and the governments of Telangana, Karnataka, and Tamil Nadu for offering help.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah spoke with Mr. Naidu and said the Centre "stands with the people of Andhra Pradesh with a firm resolve to face any kind of situation". "Already, NDRF and SDRF teams are on the ground, undertaking relief measures and standing as a support for the people in the cyclone-affected areas," he wrote on *X*.

Golden slope



Hills of bounty: Terrace fields lie ready for harvesting at Yingkon village in Upper Siang, Arunachal Pradesh on Tuesday. RITU RAJ KONWAR

Russia trying to foment 'instability' in Poland: Tusk

Reuters
WARSAW

Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk accused Russia on Tuesday of seeking to fuel "instability" in Poland by meddling in a dispute between his government and the country's President over appointments of judges to the Constitutional Tribunal.

A crisis over matter over the weekend has pushed a conflict between President Karol Nawrocki, a nationalist, and Mr. Tusk's pro-European government into open confrontation.

Russian politicians described the Tusk government's moves in the dispute over the tribunal as "a coup".

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 15



Americans fill out ballots for the midterms at a polling station in Washington on Tuesday. AFP

U.S. votes in midterm elections; control of Congress at stake

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

Americans voted on Tuesday in pivotal midterm elections with the Democrats hoping to seize control of Congress and shatter President Donald Trump's grip on Washington for the remainder of his term. As opinion polls pointed to a setback for the President, Mr. Trump made a final pitch to voters, saying he had rebuilt U.S. through his immigration crackdown, war on Iran, and tariff policy.

Polls predict the Democrats will win a majority in the House of Representatives and possibly seize the Senate on the back of voter resentment at a deeply unpopular President. All 435 House seats and 35 of the 100 Senate seats are at stake, along with Governorships in 36 States. Democrats need only three House gains and a net four seats in the Senate to wrest the chambers from Republican hands.

Democrats' upperhand

Republicans losing the House would give Democrats the power to stall the President's legislative agenda and launch sweeping investigations of his administration. A Senate defeat would threaten the President's ability to appoint Supreme Court justices and senior officials.

"We have to keep America great. We're great now. We were terrible two years ago," the U.S. President told "Fox & Friends" ahead of the polls on Tuesday.

Mr. Trump returned to office last year promising to bring down prices, but inflation, tariffs, and fuel costs inflated by the West Asia conflict have squeezed Americans.

Mr. Trump's approval rating has hovered near the low 30s.Republicans insist that Mr. Trump's tax cuts and anti-migrant stance will benefit Americans, and they are portraying Democratic candidates as left-wing radicals.

While Republicans hold a 53-47 Senate majority, the political battlefield is extending into conservative states like Kansas, Texas, Iowa, Ohio, and Alaska.

Democrats must also defend competitive seats, including in Michigan, where a bitter internal dispute saw congresswoman Haley Stevens endorse Republican Mike Rogers rather than the Democratic nominee, Abdul El-Sayed.

'WILL STOP AID TO ISRAEL' » PAGE 14

Drone strike on vessel off Oman leaves Indian dead

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

An Indian national was killed in a drone strike on an Indian commercial vessel off the Coast of Oman on Tuesday, after which New Delhi made an appeal for "dialogue and diplomacy" and for freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz.

The death of Gandhar Nahim Ajij from Gujarat took the number of Indian seafarers killed since the conflict in West Asia began in February this year to 23.

"The continuing incidents of attacks on commercial shipping in the region are deeply concerning," the External Affairs Ministry said in a statement, reiterating its call for de-escalation of tensions and a diplomatic solution.

"The targeting of commercial shipping and civilian infrastructure in the region must end, and free and unimpeded navigation and commerce through the international waterways in the region, in keeping with international law, must be restored at the earliest," it added.



Caught in the crossfire: The vessel that was hit by a drone off the coast of Oman. @MARINETRAFFIC.COM

The drone strike came on a day when the United States carried out airstrikes on the Iranian island of Qeshm, according to officials.

The developments indicated the volatility of the situation in the Indian Ocean and the Strait of Hormuz. The situation has been particularly tense over threats issued by U.S. President Donald Trump that if peace talks fail, there would be more penetrating attacks on Iran once the U.S. mid-term elections are over.

'Heavy toll'

The U.S. strikes on Qeshm Island at the mouth of the Hormuz Strait sent oil prices up on Tuesday. Asked about the U.S. action, which is believed to be retaliation for Iranian strikes on a U.S. fighter jet over the island a few days ago, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said India is keeping a close watch on the developments. "The conflict has already taken a very heavy toll in terms of casualties and has been disrupting people's lives across the world. It has had a debilitating impact on global food, fuel, fertilizer, and financial flows, and we urge cessation of hostility so that normalcy can be restored," Mr. Jaiswal said in response to a question from *The Hindu*.

The Indian seafarer died after a weaponised drone of unidentified origin attacked the vessel, *MSV AL JUSUFI*. Thirteen Indians aboard the vessel were rescued by Omani naval personnel.

Meanwhile, the Indian Embassy in Tehran announced that in an operation on Monday, the Indian Navy, supported by the Indian Air Force, rescued 20 Iranian crew members of the fishing vessel, *Azini*, about 3,000 km from Mumbai, where they had been held by pirates. The statement said the operation "highlighted the commitment of the Indian Navy to thwart the resurgence of piracy in the region", and India's role as first responder in the Indian Ocean.

WAR BENEFITS NONE: IRAN » PAGE 14

INBRIEF



Chirag warns of legal hurdles if Independent MLCs join BJP

Union Minister Chirag Paswan on Tuesday asserted that "legal hurdles" and "questions of morality" will arise if legislators elected as Independents join the BJP. The Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) president was responding to queries about Members of Legislative Councils (MLCs) Bansidhar Brajwasi and Rahul Raj, who have declared that they have joined the BJP, the senior alliance partner of his party in Bihar. The BJP has sought to clarify that the two MLCs had merely "extended their support" to the party. PTI

Akhilesh targets BJP over stray dogs mauling stillborn's body

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Tuesday slammed the BJP-led Uttar Pradesh government over the incident in which stray dogs mauled the body of a stillborn baby at a government medical college in Banda, questioning whether the State's Health Ministry was "on sick leave" amid what he termed "medical anarchy". Government Rani Durgavati Medical College principal Sunil Kaushal said the incident took place on Sunday when Gudiya, wife of Ganesh, delivered a stillborn baby. The body was handed over to the family, who stayed overnight on the hospital premises. After the relatives fell asleep, stray dogs dragged the body away, he said. PTI

'This is my *azaadi*': Ruhullah resigns from NC, quits LS seat; he failed as MP, retorts party

The 48-year-old Shia cleric hits out at Abdullahs for 'betraying promises made to people', hints at floating own outfit; party terms his speech 'manifestation of mental and moral bankruptcy'

Peerzada Ashiq
BUDGAM



Addressing supporters, Aga Ruhullah hit out at the NC brass, saying it settled 'for a vague promise of so-called Statehood'. IMRAN NISSAR

Ruling National Conference (NC) leader and Srinagar MP Aga Syed Ruhullah resigned from the party and his Lok Sabha seat on Tuesday at a public event in the Valley, where he hit out at party president Farooq Abdullah as well as vice-president and Chief Minister Omar Abdullah for "betraying the promises made to people" and "misusing" him for electoral gains.

"I set myself free from NC. This is my *azaadi*," the 48-year-old Shia cleric told his supporters in Budgam's Behishti Zehra Park.

Hinting at plans of floating a new party, Mr. Ruhullah announced a district-wise campaign from Kathua in Jammu to Kupwara in Kashmir.

He said his resignation letter would be sent to the party through Muhammad Ashraf Mattoo, father of Tufail Mattoo, a teenager who was killed in 2010 during street protests in alleged police firing during Mr. Omar's tenure as the CM.

'Assault on rights'

In his resignation letter, Mr. Ruhullah termed the abrogation of Article 35A and the dilution of Article 370 in 2019 a "brazen assault on our rights", which he said called for "struggle and sacrifice".

"My assumption then was that the NC, the grand old party of Kashmir, was the natural candidate for the struggle that the situation demanded," he said.

He went on to accuse the NC of betraying the public's expectations "for a vain and vague promise of so-called restoration of Statehood".

'Moral bankruptcy'

Hitting back, the ruling party called his speech a "manifestation of his mental and moral bankruptcy, and an example of his self-obsession".

"Wasn't he elected to the Parliament to represent the sentiment of people and garner support of secular parties and MPs? Did he even try to move a resolution or Bill in Parliament? Did he speak even once that the elected government is not allowed to function and the Lieutenant-Governor continues to run it through remote control?" said an NC spokesperson.

He added that while the government knows its limitations given the present scheme of things, the party has chosen its road map based on the issues that are "directly linked to our existence and identity".

"Our thrust on restoration of Statehood is not and will never be at the expense of the special status," said the party official.

He added, "It is astonishing that someone who owes his whole political existence to NC, who started his politics with the party, remained an MLA for three terms, a Minister in the government and MP of the party is so brazenly showing his narcissistic conduct and finding all faults in the party after 25 years."

Reinstate our voting rights: AMU women students to Minister

A.M. Jigeesh
NEW DELHI

University denies disenfranchisement of any student of women's college

A group of students of the Aligarh Muslim University (AMU) Women's College have approached Union Education Minister Pralhad Joshi and requested his intervention so that they can vote in the students' union election scheduled on November 5.

The Hindu had reported on Monday that over 4,000 students in the Women's College did not have voting rights in the Aligarh Muslim University Students' Union (AMUSU) elections.

The AMU, in a statement to *The Hindu*, has denied any disenfranchisement. The students mentioned in the report were students of the AMU Women's College, they had taken admission in the Women's College and were enrolled there.

"Some of them have only been allowed to attend classes in departments on the main campus; this does not make them students of those departments. They will vote in the election of their own Students' Union at the Women's College, which is being held on November 5, the same day as the AMUSU election," the AMU's Public Relations Officer said, adding that no woman student had been denied her vote.

The group of students of the Women's College, meanwhile, sent a letter to Mr. Joshi, Minister of State for Education Jayant Chowdhury, Union Higher Education Secretary Deepti Gaur Mukerjee, and Additional Secretary Anandrao V. Patil that they had submitted their concerns to the National Task Force chaired by Justice (Retired) S. Ravindra Bhat that studied mental health problems and issues of alleged discrimination in higher education institutions.

'A pressing matter'

"The disenfranchisement of Women's College students from the AMU Students' Union (AMUSU), coupled with the restriction of their voting rights to the college level, has made the matter all the more pressing and calls for immediate attention," they said in the letter.

Women protest over pending dues under Ladki Bahin scheme

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI



Women participating in the protest led by the All India Democratic Women's Association in Mumbai on Tuesday. VINAYA DESHPANDE PANDIT

Women from different parts of Maharashtra protested in Mumbai on Tuesday seeking disbursal of pending instalments under the Mahayuti government's flagship Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana. They also demanded streamlining of the e-KYC process.

"Why have you stopped our instalments? During elections, you gave us the money. Now that there is no election, you have stopped the funds. How was our e-KYC done earlier? Why is the portal shut now? Why are there no answers? You promised us ₹2,100 when you were running for elections. Now, you have stopped even the ₹1,500," said Vaishali Chorge from Chandiwali.

She was among the several women who participated in the protest led by the All India Democratic Women's Association (AIDWA) in Azad Maidan.

'Not a freebie'

CPI(M) leader and AIDWA's founding member Brinda Karat told *The Hindu*, "It is about the principle of accountability. In our democracy, when you make a promise, what happens when you don't remain answerable? You take the vote. And then, who is accountable? You have betrayed these women whom you had promised ₹2,100 a month. This is not a freebie. Women's work in India is identified as the social community, gender which does the most work."

A delegation of AIDWA leaders led by Mariam Dhawale met Maharashtra government officials and Minister Chhagan Bhujbal with the demands.

Voter list anomalies in U.P.: police to add Section 198 to FIR

Press Trust of India
PILIBHIT

The Uttar Pradesh police has initiated the process to add Section 198 of the BNS, which deals with public servants disobeying the law, to an FIR against two electoral registration officers and a computer operator over alleged irregularities in the voter list of the Pilibhit Sadar Assembly constituency, an officer said on Tuesday.

Pilibhit SP Sukirti Madhav said necessary instructions were issued to the investigating officer late on Monday night, and the process of adding the section was underway.

Section 198 of the BNS deals with public servants knowingly disobeying a direction of the law with the intent or knowledge to cause injury to any person.

On Sunday, the Election Commission suspended the two EROs, Mayank Goswami and Hemant Chaudhary, who were posted in Pilibhit as Sub-Divisional Magistrates. They were earlier transferred by the State government and put on the waitlist.

The irregularities came to light during an inquiry into the disposal of offline forms received as part of the special summary revision (SSR) of electoral rolls.

'No documents'

According to the inquiry report, 13,779 offline forms were received between May 31 and August 28. Of these, 10,470 were approved while 3,309 were rejected. However, no application forms or supporting documents related to the entries were found in the office.

BJP leadership continues to hit out at Mamata-Cong. bonhomie

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA



CM Suvendu Adhikari and Union Minister Sukanta Majumdar at the 'Loktantra Bachao, Arajakata Hatao' rally in Siliguri on Tuesday. ANI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leadership continued to raise questions on the bonhomie between the Mamata Banerjee-led faction of the Trinamool Congress and the Congress party for the second consecutive day on Tuesday and accused the former Chief Minister of joining forces in Delhi to create anarchy in the country.

BJP president Nitin Nabin had made a similar charge against Ms. Banerjee during a procession in Kolkata on Monday.

On Tuesday, Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari and BJP leader and former Union Minister Smriti Irani criticised the coming together of the Mamata Banerjee and the Congress.

Mr. Adhikari, who participated in a 'Save Democracy, Remove Anarchy' march at Siliguri in North Bengal, said while the former Chief Minister was not invited to inaugurate a single Durga Puja in Kolkata, she is going to Delhi to ally with anarchists.

Call for Oppn. unity

The remarks by the BJP leadership come at a time when speculations are rife in the political circles about a larger Opposition unity taking place in the State. West Bengal Congress president Subhankar Sarkar on Tuesday called all Opposition parties to come together keeping their flags aside and instead use "white flags". Only a few weeks ago Ms. Banerjee had decided to support Congress candidate at Nandigram bypoll after her party's nominee withdrew candidature at the last moment.

West Bengal brings back female tiger that crossed into Assam

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

A three-year-old female tiger, recently relocated in West Bengal's Buxa Tiger Reserve from Bihar weeks before it crossed into Assam, was captured and brought back to West Bengal's territory on Tuesday.

The tiger, Dooars Rani (BTR-TF-1/ T-138), was released in Buxa on October 2 from Bihar's Valmiki Tiger Reserve as part of the State's first tiger relocation project. However, the tiger crossed into Assam's Raimona National Park on Sunday in search of a suitable habitat.

"On Tuesday, we have tranquilised the tiger, caged, and brought back to Buxa. Initially, we let it move around and explore the surroundings. But we captured it today only when it came close to localities of humans. However, there is nothing to panic now. The tiger is also safe and healthy," said the Forest Minister Manoj Oraon.

Mr. Oraon has been present in Assam for the last four days to monitor the tiger. According to the officials, the tiger crossed the Sankosh River and a road in Gosaigaon in Assam to enter Raimona, mostly in search of suitable habitat. Her movement area has been traced 25 km away from the Bengal border.

Intense monitoring

Buxa was declared a tiger reserve in 1983, and over the past few years there have been no reports of tiger presence in the region.

Forest officials say this new tiger from Bihar will be subjected to intensive post-release monitoring.

'No political will': experts say poll promises to end drug menace in Punjab are hard to keep

Vikas Vasudeva
CHANDIGARH

In the run-up to the upcoming Assembly election, all major parties in Punjab, including the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), have made the battle against drug menace their central poll plank.

While AAP has asserted that eradicating drugs is its biggest priority, Opposition parties such as the Congress, Shiromani Akali Dal and Bharatiya Janata Party have accused the government of failing to curb the crisis and patronising the drug trade instead.

Experts say eliminating the problem, which has persisted for decades, is extremely difficult, given the profitability of the trade, the established network of smugglers and the alleged involvement of police and the political patronage behind it.



An ex-DGP, Punjab, said curbing the menace is impossible due to the 'nexus' between police and politicians. FILE PHOTO

Former Director General of Punjab Police Shashi Kant, known for his fight against the narcotics trade, said, "It is impossible to stop the drug menace and the trade because of the strong nexus between sections of police officers, other institutions of democracy and politicians."

"Punjab has seen two kinds of drug abuse: *chitta* (heroin) and pharmaceutical drugs. Syndicates involved in the latter already follow the clearing-and-forwarding agent mechanism to move drugs. The same mechanism is now being followed in *chitta* trade as well," said Mr. Kant.

Lack of consistency

Speaking on condition of anonymity, a senior serving officer said anti-drug programmes suffer from a lack of consistency.

"Governments tend to focus more on publicity. Any good initiative should be carried forward, not dropped after regime change. What is needed is a sound plan, consistency and execution. Besides, the trust of the people has to be won," the officer said.

Ranjit Singh Ghuman, Professor of Eminence (Economics) at Guru Nanak Dev University in Amritsar, said drug addiction is prevalent in several northern States.

'Powerful nexus'

"We have studied five States – Punjab, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Rajasthan and Jammu and Kashmir. National Crime Records Bureau data show that Punjab is the worst affected among the five. There is a nexus between police, smugglers and political leaders. Besides, during elections, political parties distribute intoxicants, and because of this, their moral authority gets eroded in the public's eyes," he said. "There's no political will to eradicate it," the academic added.

"Political parties are hardly interested in addressing the issue. It is a very complex problem. A lot of quick money is involved, which gets pumped into elections as well," said Mr. Ghuman.

Students forced to sell blood for coaching fees in U.P., Cong. tells NHRC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A Congress delegation led by Rajendra Pal Gautam, the All India Congress Committee (AICC) incharge for Uttar Pradesh, on Tuesday moved the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) seeking intervention into the alleged sale of blood by economically disadvantaged students in Prayagraj and other cities of the State to meet the costs of coaching and hostels facilities.

Mr. Gautam, who also heads the party's Schedule Castes (SCs) department, told reporters that the NHRC Chairperson had assured him the matter would be probed by the rights' body.

In a memorandum, Mr. Gautam cited an investigative report published by a leading Hindi daily between October 25 and 27. According to the complaint, a large number of NEET (National Eligibility cum Entrance Test) and SSC (Staff Selection Commission) aspirants, mostly from rural, low-income farming families, were selling blood to pay coaching fees ranging from ₹1.20 lakh to ₹1.80 lakh per year, often demanded as lump sum, besides hostel and mess charges of ₹3,500 to ₹5,000 per month.

'Serious health risk'

The report found that agents and brokers operating near blood banks approached students.

Some students admitted to donating blood two to four times a month, posing serious health risks, including anaemia and weakness, the Congress leader said.

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Shut 87 illegal resorts in tiger reserve, says Madras HC

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court has ordered the immediate closure of 87 illegal resorts in the Sathyamangalam Tiger Reserve in Erode district of Tamil Nadu.

These resorts had been functioning without planning permission/building approval from the Directorate of Town and Country Planning (DTCP). The court directed the Erode Collector to act against other illegal resorts too.

A special Division Bench of Justices N. Sathish Kumar and G.K. Muthukumaar, constituted to hear forest and environment-related cases, issued the interim direction on a public interest litigation (PIL) petition filed by R. Karpagam, through her counsel S.P. Chockalingam, seeking stringent action against the illegal establishments.

In a status report filed in response to the PIL petition, the Collector told the court that the 87 resorts had not obtained DTCP approval. The judges found that those resorts had also not obtained the Hill Area Conservation Authority's (HACA) permission for conversion of land use from residential to commercial. "Action has to be taken to immediately close down all the illegal buildings. Further action has to be taken for demolition of those buildings also," the judges said.

The Bench called for a fresh status report from the Collector by November 27.

PACs ensure efficient use of public money: Om Birla

LS Speaker flags long-pending reports of Public Accounts Committees; urges use of technology to analyse data; Keralam CM calls for discussion on how the committees should treat CAG reports

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla said on Tuesday that the Public Accounts Committees (PAC) in Parliament and State legislatures ensure that public money was used efficiently and for the right purposes.

He was speaking at the inaugural ceremony of a two-day conference of PAC chairpersons from 25 States being hosted by the Keralam Assembly.

Highlighting the distinctive democratic convention of appointing a Member of the Opposition as the Chairperson of the PAC, Mr. Birla said that this practice reflects the maturity, inclusiveness and strength of India's parliamentary democracy.

"The representation of all political parties in the Committee ensures that different perspectives are brought to the examination of public expenditure. This is a shining example of the ability of democratic institutions to rise above political considerations in pursuit of a common national objective," he added.

Calling for the use of technology to break down data, he said, "....the PACs are sometimes beset with delays, with reports sometimes pending for 15-20 years. This has to be addressed. Technology, data analytics and artificial intelligence can play an important role in analysing large volumes of expenditure data, identifying emerging trends, detecting potential financial irregularities and improving the monitoring of audit observations," he said.



Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla with Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Harivansh, Keralam Chief Minister V. D. Satheesan, PAC chairman K.C. Venugopal and others in Thiruvananthapuram on Tuesday. ANI

Venugopal flags absence of top officials

Press Trust of India
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Public Accounts Committee Chairman K.C. Venugopal voiced concern over the absence of chief secretaries of six States at its recent meeting.

The officers had been called to tender oral evidence on scholarships for Scheduled Caste students.

"The absence of the chief secretaries denied the committee the opportunity to examine the shortcomings and secure corrective action," he said.

He urged Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla to intervene in such cases.

On CAG reports

Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan called for a serious discussion on how the PACs should treat the findings in Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) reports.

He said that legislature has no power to exclude a report tabled by the CAG from the scrutiny of the PAC, calling such a move an "unhealthy parliamentary practice".

The Keralam Chief Minister also criticised the methodology the CAG uses to calculate amounts, saying it often defeats the purpose of an audit.

"The 2010 CAG audit reports on the 2G spectrum calculated an estimated loss of ₹1.76 lakh crore by extrapolating revenue based on later benchmarks than actual market conditions," he said.

Senior Congress leader and the Chairperson of the Public Accounts Committees K. C. Venugopal said that the CAG needs to increase the number of audits and focus more on the flagship schemes, including the Jal Jeevan mission and the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana.

(With inputs from PTI)

South India has grown wetter over 70 years: study

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Southern India has become wetter over the past seven decades as the area classified as having a hot semi-arid climate has nearly halved from about 30% to 16% of the peninsula between 1951-1980 and 1991-2020, according to a study by scientists from the India Meteorological Department (IMD) and the Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology (IITM), Pune.

Published in *MAUSAM*, the IMD's peer-reviewed journal, the study found that much of the peninsula's hot semi-arid regions had transitioned into the tropical savannah climate zone, which receives more rainfall and has a prolonged dry season. This zone now covers nearly three-fourths of peninsular India, compared with about three-fifths in the 1950s.

The study, titled 'Identifying the climate zones shifts of Indian meteorological subdivisions: insights from historical records', uses the Köppen-Geiger climate classification system to assess changes across India's meteorological subdivisions.

The researchers mapped India's climate zones across successive 30-year periods, using the IMD's rainfall and temperature observations from 1951 to 2020.

The researchers said changes in climate zones could have implications for agriculture.


Clear lead: NDA's mayoral candidate Mukka Sravani at a counting centre in Visakhapatnam on Tuesday. V. RAJU

NDA all set for a landslide victory in A.P. local body polls

V. Raghavendra
VIJAYAWADA

The TDP-Jana Sena Party (JSP)-BJP alliance in Andhra Pradesh is poised to hand a crushing defeat to the YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) in the local body elections by winning a majority of 13 municipal corporations and 79 municipalities and nagar panchayats that went to the polls on November 1.

The YSRCP failed to withstand the might of the ruling coalition in Pulivendula, a traditional stronghold of Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy family, and which is currently represented in the Legislative Assembly by his son Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy, the former Chief Minister and YSRCP president.

The Opposition party also failed to stem the NDA tide in the Kadapa Municipal Corporation.

In Greater Visakhapatnam Municipal Corporation (GVMC), the State's largest municipal corporation, TDP candidate Mukka Sravani is likely to defeat YSRCP's Varudu Kalyani.

JSP candidate Vangaveeti Radhakrishna, son of slain Congress leader Vangaveeti Mohan Ranga, is set to register an impressive victory against YSRCP's Rayana Bhagya Lakshmi in the mayoral election in Vijayawada, where former IPS officer A.B. Venkateswara Rao tried his luck as an Independent candidate with the backing of the Congress and Left parties.

NDA candidates are leading in other corporations – Chittoor, Eluru, Guntur, Kurnool, Machilipatnam, Nellore, Ongole, Tirupati and Vizianagaram.

Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu said people reposed their faith in the TDP-led coalition due to its welfare-oriented politics.

Mocking the victory secured by the TDP and its allies, Mr. Jagan Mohan Reddy said in a social media post that Mr. Naidu showed how to win an election spectacularly by robbing the Opposition of its chance to compete.

Karnataka court initiates contempt proceedings after ruckus by advocates

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Karnataka High Court on Tuesday began *suo motu* contempt proceedings against unidentified individuals amongst a group of advocates, who barged into the Chief Justice's court hall and disrupted proceedings by creating ruckus.

The group compelled lawyers present in the court hall to leave, objecting to their participation in the court proceedings despite a call to boycott court proceedings across the State given by bar associations, including Advocates' Association, Bengaluru (AAB) to protest against the recent incidents of murders, attempt to murder of advocates. A Division Bench comprising Chief Justice Vibhu Bakhru and Justice K.S. Hemalekha that was conducting the proceedings in the court hall, took serious exception to the conduct of the group of advocates and ordered registration of a contempt of court case in this regard.


A group had barged into the Chief Justice's court and disrupted proceedings.

The Bench also ordered issue of notice to the AAB.

"*Prima facie*, we are of the view that this conduct amounts to contemptuous behaviour," the Bench observed in its order.

The petition will be taken up for hearing on November 19.

Fruit of labour


Stocks ready: A farmer spreading paddy for drying at a procurement centre near Nalgonda of Telangana on Tuesday. With Kharif harvesting on, farmers are bringing their produce to market yards where paddy is dried and stacked before procurement. NAGARA GOPAL

UDF poised to recast LDF's 'permissive' liquor policy

G. Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) government's subcommittee formulating the liquor policy for the 2026-27 fiscal year was reportedly poised to recast the arguably 'permissive' State Excise rules framed by the previous Left Democratic Front (LDF) dispensation.

Excise Minister M. Liju told *The Hindu* that the UDF would "dismantle the rules and amendments" that gave deputy excise commissioners the power to grant bar licences. Instead, he said, the framers of the new liquor policy would vest such authority with the political executive.

Essence of the policy

Mr. Liju refused to hazard a guess on whether the essence of the UDF's upcoming liquor policy, which the government is scheduled to announce on November 30, would be restrictive, or a whittled-down hark back to the Oommen Chandy government's 2014 decision to close over 700 bars, supposedly to curb the easy availability of liquor.

Instead, Mr. Liju merely noted that the previous LDF government reinstated 488 bar licences cancelled by the Oommen Chandy government by "watering down" the vetting process and empowering the Excise department bureaucracy to infringe on or bypass policy matters, which are the political executive's sole preserve.

Mr. Liju said the government would decide whether to issue more licences only after it promulgates the UDF's Excise policy.

'Sting video' case: aide at JD(S) leader's office appears before police

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Prajwal Prasad, a media consultant associated with Union Minister for Heavy Industries and Steel H.D. Kumaraswamy's office, appeared before the Bengaluru Central Crime Branch on Tuesday for questioning in connection with the alleged fabrication and circulation of a 'sting video' targeting former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah.

Mr. Prasad appeared at the CCB headquarters in response to a notice issued by investigators. He had earlier reportedly been absconding and later secured interim anticipatory bail.

According to the police, Ritesh Pandey, arrested by the CCB on the charge of uploading the video on the internet, stated during interrogation that Mr. Prasad had instructed him to purchase a specific mobile phone allegedly used in the operation. He also claimed that the handset was handed over to Mr. Prasad at the JD(S) leader's official residence in New Delhi.

The police have described the video, in which allegations were purportedly levelled against Mr. Siddaramaiah, as an orchestrated and fabricated narrative. Statements recorded from individuals featured in the videos reportedly failed to substantiate the allegations.

Ahead of annual pilgrimage season, Sabarimala visitors get new digital portal for key services

Hiran Unnikrishnan
PATHANAMTHITTA

A bus schedule, the nearest medical centre, a complaint against an overpriced purchase or help tracing a missing person will soon be just a few clicks away for Sabarimala pilgrims.

Ahead of the annual pilgrimage season beginning on November 17, the Pathanamthitta District Disaster Management Authority has expanded its Sabari Portal and WhatsApp-based chatbot to a range of services onto a single digital platform.

To locate facilities

Accessible at sabariportaldcpta.in, the portal works on mobile phones and computers without requiring a separate app. Its Sabari Map acts as a digital guide to Pampa, Nilackal and the Sannidhanam, helping pilgrims locate drinking water points, medical centres, hospitals, police services, parking facilities, rest centres and ATMs. It can identify the nearest facility based on the user's location and provide directions through Google Maps.


Tech support: Pilgrims can check train, bus schedules, challenge overcharging at shops and file complaints using the platform. PTI

According to officials, the portal brings travel information together in one place. Pilgrims can check train schedules from Chengannur, Thiruvalla and Kottayam, find KSRTC services, including Nilackal-Pampa chain buses and long-distance buses from Pampa, and access links for virtual queue and bus ticket bookings.

It also gives pilgrims a way to challenge overcharging at shops. The multilingual 'Check My Bill' facility allows them to compare bills with officially notified prices of goods sold at the Sannidhanam, Pampa and Nilackal, and report overcharging or refusal to issue bills.

Complaints about sanitation, public toilets, KSRTC and the Travancore Devaswom Board are routed to the departments concerned. A 'Lost and Found' facility is also being developed.

The portal also doubles as a digital command centre for officials, bringing departmental coordination and field-level monitoring under one system.

At the Sannidhanam, sanitation work is monitored across 15 zones, covering 300 to 400 workers. Supervisors receive automated alerts every three hours and update the status of cleaning work. The dashboard also tracks hospital admissions, referrals and follow-up treatment.

Weather, reservoir levels, road accidents, wildlife incidents, bus services and price-control inspections are also tracked.

"The system would help make the pilgrimage safer and more convenient," said District Collector A. Nizamudeen.

No breakthrough in search for 10 villagers trapped in Odisha

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR


A videograb shows sniffer dogs brought in to assist rescue in the landslide-hit village . ANI

Multi-agency efforts to rescue around 10 villagers trapped beneath a mound of earth and debris following a landslide in the remote Gidipabali village under the Bhanjanagar block of Odisha's Ganjam district remained unsuccessful on Tuesday, despite three controlled blasts carried out in an attempt to dislodge massive boulders obstructing the operation.

For the past five days, personnel from the National Disaster Response Force, the Odisha Disaster Rapid Action Force, other agencies local residents, have been working relentlessly to clear the debris and trace the missing villagers. The disaster response teams have also deployed sniffer dogs to assist in the search operation.

While landslide struck Gidipabali on October 28, it was only on October 30 that villagers who had escaped the disaster informed the administration. Of the 25 residents of Gidipabali, 13 survived, while the remaining 12 were buried under the debris.

So far, the bodies of two victims have been recovered.

"Gidipabali village is extremely remote, without any access road. This has been a stumbling block in our efforts to take heavy machinery, including crane and earth movers to the site for clearing the debris," said Sudhansu Sarangi, Director General of Police (Fire Services).

Asked whether there was any consideration of abandoning the rescue operation, the Fire Service DG said, "we have already informed the State government about limitations in undertaking the rescue operation. It is up to the government at the highest level to take a call."

Mechanism in place to deal with Ganga treaty: India

Bilateral treaty signed between India, Bangladesh in 1996 set to expire next month; no 'update' on renewal or on the dates for a visit by Bangladeshi Prime Minister, says External Affairs Ministry

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI


High level treaty: The Ganga Water Treaty is a 30-year bilateral water-sharing agreement between India and Bangladesh. FARAKKA BARRAGE PROJECT

With the Ganga Water Treaty between India and Bangladesh set to expire in December, the External Affairs Ministry on Tuesday reiterated that the two countries have a "structured mechanism" to deal with the treaty's requirements.

Addressing the bi-weekly media briefing, official spokesperson of the Ministr, Randhir Jaiswal, reiterated that India has invited Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman to visit New Delhi but that there is neither any "update" on the treaty's renewal nor on the dates for the trip. "Between India and Bangladesh, we have a Joint Rivers Commission which is the structured mechanism for discussion on all cross-boundary rivers, including the Ganga," said Mr. Jaiswal, adding that India wishes to have a "positive relationship" with Bangladesh.

The bilateral Ganga Water Treaty is set to expire on December 12. It was signed in 1996 when Sheikh Hasina of Awami League became Bangladesh's Prime Minister for the first time. The three-decade old agreement for river water sharing requires expert-level and political consultations for a renewal.

It is understood that since the treaty was signed at the level of Prime Ministers, a renewal of the agreement would happen at a meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Mr. Rahman. However, Mr. Rahman, who has visited China, Japan, Malaysia and the United States so far, has not yet responded to the invites from India.

The two sides had earlier commenced consultations for a possible visit by Mr. Rahman, however the contacts were disrupted when Ms. Hasina, who is on exile here since August 5, 2024, held a virtual press interaction in August. Mr. Jaiswal on Tuesday maintained that there is no update about the visit. "As far as India-Bangladesh relationship is concerned we want to work towards a positive, forward looking and constructive relation," said Mr. Jaiswal reiterating India's invites to Prime Minister Rahman. Diplomatic sources from the Bangladeshi side had informed earlier that they are expecting an automatic short-term renewal of the treaty after the expiry on December 12, though the Indian officials have not indicated at that till now.

Mr. Jaiswal also took note of the protests by the readymade garment industry workers in Bangladesh who have been hitting the streets demanding fair wages as the country faces high inflation and electricity crisis. "Yes, we have been following the situation in Bangladesh. There have been developments there and we will continue to follow the developments," he said in response to a question on the protests by the workers in the garments sector.

India set to simplify visa forms to match global standards

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The Union government is all set to simplify visa application forms to bring them at par with global standards, a senior government official told *The Hindu*.

Redundant fields in the bulky visa forms would be done away with and the changes were likely to be implemented from next year, the official said.

The travel and tourism industry has been seeking the government's intervention to achieve pre-COVID era foreign tourist footfall, a target which India has not been able to meet yet.

According to the Ministry of Tourism data, foreign tourist arrival in 2019, before the 2020 COVID pandemic, stood at 1.093 crore, while in 2025, the number of foreign tourists was 91.5 lakh. In 2024, around 99 lakh foreign tourists arrived in India and in 2023, the number was 95 lakh tourists.

Another official said the visa forms were being designed in a way to remove repetitive fields.

"The visa forms will be made simpler and user-friendly in the coming days. The changes will reflect in all the 22 visa categories, in accordance with global standards. The forms will be leaner and the number of fields will be reduced by approximately 70%," said the official.

The Union Ministry of Home Affairs has convened several meetings to further liberalise the visa regime.

Fields such as "district" will be done away with as there is no global equivalent and the requirement of filling in "local address" is to be liberalised. At present, an e-visa application runs into nine pages and asks if the applicant has ever been engaged in "cybercrime, terrorist activities, sabotage, espionage, genocide, political killing or any other act of violence."

A tourism industry official said they had urged the government to uniformly apply the 120-day application window to all countries. At present, India offers e-visa preceded by electronic travel authorisation (ETA) under nine subcategories to 147 countries and the application window for some countries is 30 days.

Technological sovereignty key for India's self-reliance: Rajnath

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Tuesday said military preparedness in the 21st century was intrinsically linked to technological and industrial capabilities, emphasising that India's pursuit of self-reliance must go beyond indigenous manufacturing to achieving technological sovereignty.

Addressing the third edition of the Delhi Defence Dialogue 2026 at the Manohar Parrikar Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses (MP-IDSA), Mr. Singh said true self-reliance meant possessing the knowledge to design defence platforms, the technology to manufacture them, intellectual property to upgrade them and the capability to sustain them throughout their lifecycle.

He described defence reforms, self-reliance, international collaborations and exports as four interconnected pillars of India's strategic autonomy and its ambition to become a developed nation by 2047.

Mr. Singh said recent conflicts had demonstrated how battlefields were expanding beyond land, sea and air into space, cyberspace and the digital domain. The growing use of relatively inexpensive drones and autonomous systems was challenging sophisticated and costly military platforms, making rapid innovation, large-scale manufacturing and the ability to replenish military capabilities equally important.

He said the government was encouraging greater private sector participation in advanced defence programmes, including the Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA), propulsion systems, Advanced Towed Artillery Gun System (ATAGS), artillery ammunition and shipbuilding.

The Defence Minister said production had reached a record ₹1.78 lakh crore in 2025-26, while exports rose to ₹38,424 crore. Indian defence products were now reaching more than 80 countries.

Hero and guide


Proud moment: A newly appointed Deputy Superintendent of Police salutes her father after the passing out parade at the Madhya Pradesh Police Training Academy in Bhopal on Tuesday. A.M. FARUQUI

Truck driver who ran over M.P. police officer held

The Hindu Bureau
BHOPAL

A day after allegedly mowing down a police inspector in Madhya Pradesh's Dewas district, truck driver Gajendra Rawat was arrested from Alirajpur and injured in an encounter, the police said on Tuesday.

He suffered a bullet injury in his right leg and was admitted to the Dewas district hospital.

Inspector Dilip Puri, SHO of the Khategaon police station, died in the early hours of Monday after being run over by the truck after he intercepted it on suspicion of smuggling illicit liquor.

SC to hear interim bail plea of Tejpal tomorrow

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday adjourned to November 5 the hearing on former *Tehelka* editor Tarun Tejpal's plea challenging the Bombay High Court judgment convicting him and sentencing him to 10 years' imprisonment in the 2013 sexual assault case. The court said it would also consider his interim bail plea seeking release to join his family for Deepavali festivities.

A Bench of Justices M.M. Sundresh and Prasanna B. Varale deferred the hearing after Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Goa government, sought an adjournment.

Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Mr. Tejpal, initially opposed the adjournment. He then urged the court to grant the journalist interim bail for Deepavali. Mr. Mehta opposed the request, indicating that the Goa government would contest the interim bail plea.

Demonstrations create a 'protest economy', top court tells traders

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI


The court was responding to a petition saying that protests were 'bleeding' traders dry during peak festive season. FILE PHOTO

The Supreme Court on Tuesday remarked to Delhi traders that protests are not entirely hostile to business, pointing out that there is also "protest economy" that generates brisk earnings for enterprising hawkers and vendors at demonstration sites.

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant expressed sympathy for the right to livelihood of the small traders, hawkers, and push cart vendors, noting that their right competed with the right to expression of the protesters. The court said there was a need for balance.

The court was responding to a petition filed by Kirana Committee Delhi that protests are "bleeding" the traders of Delhi dry during the two months of peak festive season.

Senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi, for the national capital's traders, said even the Ramlila Grounds, the designated protest site after Jantar Mantar, was only a mile away from the iconic shopping and commercial hub of Connaught Place (CP) in the national capital.

"We have lost thousands of crores. Nobody is able to do business in Connaught Place. Thousands of auxiliary workers connected to these businesses are without a jobs as sales is down in the middle of the festive season," Mr. Rohatgi said.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, for the Union government, referred to how the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)-linked NEET-UG paper leak protestors had sought permission for a peaceful demonstration at Jantar Mantar only for a day on June 20, but had refused to leave.

Trade concerns

"Everybody has a right to protest... But everybody must adhere to conditions of permission. You cannot occupy a protest site indefinitely. There are other protestors too... Where will they go?" Chief Justice Kant asked.

Mr. Mehta submitted that the organisers of protests or bandh calls must take responsibility for the losses caused to others.

Senior advocate N. Hariharan, appearing for CPI (M) State secretary M.A. Baby along with advocate Subhash Chandran, questioned whether the authorities were suddenly having second thoughts about designating Ramlila Grounds as a designated site now.

Justice Bagchi pointed out that essentials like food and water usually are supplied to protesters at the site by hawkers and vendors.

"There would be ample food... There is a protest economy... Like in melas, there is a lot of business done... 'Mela economy'," Justice Bagchi observed orally.

Justice Bagchi asked the traders whether they had made the protest organisers a party in their case. Mr. Rohatgi replied in the negative, while calling for a two-month ban on protests during the festive season.

The court issued notice on the plea but refused to pass any interim order without hearing the other stakeholder – the protest organisers.

Jantar Mantar is a road, not a protest site: Delhi Police to SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Delhi Police Commissioner submitted in the Supreme Court on Tuesday that Jantar Mantar is not a "site" but a "public road". He said no one can insist on a fundamental right to protest at a particular place and the State can shift venues of protest to other locations.

The Delhi Police were responding to a petition filed by Swaty Singh, represented by senior advocate Mukta Gupta and advocate Akanksha Mehra, challenging the recent de-notification of Jantar Mantar, which was at the heart of the NEET-UG paper leak and the anti-Chief Election Commissioner protests in the national capital.

Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar, in an affidavit, said the very identification of Jantar Mantar as a designated protest site was "contrary to public interest since the inception".

"The location is a stretch of public road meant for the use and free movement of the public,



and could not appropriately have been identified and designated as a permanent protest site... Being a public road, it ought not to have been declared as a designated protest site since it continues to be used (though with difficulty) as a public road," Mr. Kumar argued.

Capacity exceeded

He said the stretch of "road" witnesses nearly 1,300 protests every year. Emergency services on that stretch of road were a nightmare, and general security in the area was compromised. The July 20 NEET-UG protests showed a turnout that far exceeded capacity. This was not a solitary instance and created a constant fear of a stampede.

The police chief detailed that from August 1 to 17, the stretch of Jantar Mantar had accounted for 250 distress calls, 109 FIRs relating to theft, 10 FIRs on motor vehicle thefts, more than 250 property loss claims, and 23 FIRs relating to public order violations, rioting, and defacement.

The area around Jantar Mantar hosts 78 foreign embassies/missions, 99 Central government offices, a daily footfall of 1.46 lakh persons, and 7,017 private residences.

The right to dissent and peaceful protest should be balanced against the rights of other citizens, he said. The proximity of the new Parliament premises has further enhanced the significance of regulating activities in the area, Mr. Kumar submitted.

He highlighted that the right to publicly demonstrate dissent through protests must not stop others from carrying on their livelihood and business or arrest their right to move freely within the capital city of India of India.

Voters using Form 6 for re-enrolment will not face action: ECI

EROs must not initiate action under RPA just because a voter was present in a previous poll roll and submitted Form 6 during the SIR or afterwards

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI



The ECI says electors whose names do not appear on the draft roll must seek inclusion afresh under the SIR or afterwards. FILE PHOTO

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Tuesday said no action would be taken against voters merely because they had been included on a previous electoral roll and submitted Form 6 during the special intensive revision (SIR) process or afterwards, provided they were not already enrolled in another Lok Sabha or Assembly constituency.

In a letter to the chief electoral officers of all States and Union Territories, the ECI clarified that electors whose names do not appear on the draft roll must seek inclusion afresh under the SIR or afterwards, regardless of whether they had been enrolled previously.

Voter protection

"The submission of Form 6 in such circumstances is, therefore, for the purpose of inclusion on the electoral roll under SIR or afterwards and is not, by itself, false merely because the elector was previously enrolled," it said.

The ECI said the clarification was in line with a Delhi High Court ruling in *Nilotpal Datta & Anr. v. Election Commission of India & Ors.*, decided on October 14, 2026.

In that case, the court held that an applicant's concern that submitting Form 6 would amount to making a false declaration was misplaced. It closed the proceedings, observing that the petitioners could submit Form 6 for processing. The clarification comes amid concerns that voters re-enrolling through Form 6 could face penal provisions under electoral law because the form includes a declaration that they are first-time voters.

The ECI's letter directed that Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) should not initiate action under Section 31 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, merely because an elector had appeared on a previous electoral roll and submitted Form 6 during the SIR or afterwards. This applies provided the elector is not already enrolled in another Lok Sabha or Assembly constituency. The declaration in Form 6 stating that an applicant's name is being included on the electoral roll for the first time has been in force since August 1, 2022.

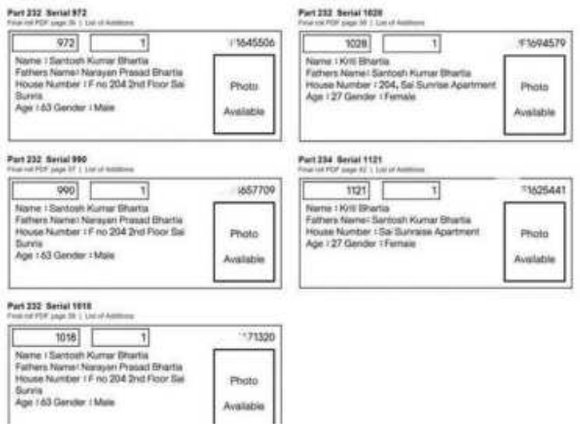
'Structural incongruity'

Meanwhile, petitioners in the Delhi SIR case wrote to the ECI seeking urgent implementation of a Supreme Court directive allowing voters deleted from the Absent/Shifted/Dead/Duplicate list to use an enumeration form and/or Form 8 to be included in the voter list.

In a letter to Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, petitioner Anjali Bharadwaj said the Supreme Court had observed during the hearing that requiring voters deleted during the SIR to submit Form 6, which contains a first-time voter declaration, was an error. The judges had described it as a "structural incongruity".

In Karnataka seat at heart of vote theft claims, 803 voter IDs linked to 397 names after SIR

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU



A father-daughter duo was found to have multiple voter IDs in Mahadevapura. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

While one of the aims of the special intensive revision (SIR) was to weed out duplicate entries from electoral rolls, *The Hindu* found that after the SIR exercise, Karnataka's Mahadevapura Assembly constituency alone had 803 voter IDs linked to just 397 people. In several cases, more than three voter IDs had been issued under one person's name.

This is the very constituency where the "vote *chori* (theft)" controversy first erupted, with the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, alleging that over one lakh fake or stolen votes had been systematically engineered in the area to manipulate the outcome of the 2024 Bengaluru Central Lok Sabha election. The seat is currently represented by the BJP.

Following the SIR, some voters were found listed on the rolls with the same elector's photo identity card (EPIC) number in two different constituencies. In some other cases, voters were issued multiple EPIC IDs. For instance, Madhumita's name appears on the final SIR rolls of both Mahadevapura (Part 180) and Hebbal (Part 62), with the same EPIC number in both places. Her father's name and age are also the same in both entries.

Similarly, Chaitra appears in Mahadevapura (Part 90) and Dasarahalli (Part 251), with the same EPIC number.

At least seven such cases were found across constituencies, with the same EPIC number appearing against two entries in each case. These seven EPIC numbers account for 14 entries on the final rolls – three cases each between Mahadevapura and Dasarahalli, and Mahadevapura and Sarvagnanagar, and one between Mahadevapura and Hebbal.

Multiple IDs

In another set of cases, individuals have been issued multiple EPIC IDs. *The Hindu* found seven cases in which people held more than three voter IDs each.

The list includes a father-daughter duo, both of whom have multiple voter IDs in Mahadevapura. Santosh Kumar, 63, has five voter IDs – three in the same polling station (Part 232) and one each in Parts 233 and 234. His age, address and relatives' names are the same across all five entries. His daughter, Kriti, 27, also has two voter IDs in Parts 232 and 234.

Besides this, *The Hindu* found more than 500 cases in Mahadevapura in which the same person had two or more voter IDs within a polling station. In 300 other cases, the same person had multiple IDs, but across different polling stations in the constituency.

For instance, in Part 2, consecutive serial numbers – 497 and 498 – are both listed under the name of Nithin, 18, with Prakash mentioned as his father. The only difference is the house number, one entry lists it as 00 and the other as 025. In another case, *The Hindu* found that 51-year-old Girija, whose name was deleted from the draft rolls, now appears twice in the final rolls. The Form 9 report, which consolidates Form 6 applications, shows that she applied for inclusion twice – on August 14 and September 18. Her name now figures in Parts 484 and 487.

The Office of the Chief Electoral Officer said it had received no formal complaints about duplicate entries. The office said it was monitoring complaints flagged on social media and by political parties, and that the cases would be verified.

Aadhaar not enough, Delhi booth-level officers asked to seek 'citizenship proof' from voters

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

A BLO was asked how he could establish that an elector was not Rohingya or Bangladeshi

Electors who submitted only Aadhaar cards in response to notices issued for "no mapping" during the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Delhi are facing another round of scrutiny, with booth-level officers (BLOs) being asked to collect additional documents as proof of citizenship.

Several BLOs told *The Hindu* that despite submitting field verification reports and undertakings confirming that the electors were eligible and had been living at their addresses for years, Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) were directing them to revisit voters and seek additional documents to establish that they were not "Bangladeshi" or "Rohingya".

The additional scrutiny comes even as more than 94% of the 33.1 lakh cases flagged for notices in the draft roll had been marked for the final rolls in data shared by the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO)'s office last week.

Electors who submitted only Aadhaar were being flagged on the ERO and Assistant ERO (AERO) system, as seen by *The Hindu*. This is despite the EROs having the option to mark an elector eligible and park the case for inclusion on the final roll if they are satisfied with the BLO's field report.

'Possess no documents'

"I know these voters for many years. They are saying they do not have other documents, not even a bank account, but I will have to revisit them," a BLO from the Northeast district said.

Another BLO said the instructions on document collection had changed repeatedly, causing confusion. He said his ERO called him on Monday after he had completed verification of all his cases and questioned how he could establish that an elector was not "Rohingya" or "Bangladeshi" on the basis of Aadhaar. "I was asked to gather citizenship proof. The voters have been living there for many years, and there are many in my area who never went to school," he said. "What is a citizenship proof in this country? I had collected Aadhaar and bank passbook copies, but I have now been asked to seek more documents. How many times are we going to ask voters for these things?" another BLO said. In one instance, a voter who had submitted a passport has also been asked to submit documents for reverification, he added.

Officials, however, denied that any such instructions had been issued, adding that no identification or records of "illegal immigrants" on the electoral roll is being carried. An ERO said officials had initially been instructed to identify foreign nationals on the rolls, but the directions had changed soon afterwards and no such list was being prepared.

Speaking order

The ECI has prescribed 11 documents, including birth certificates, educational certificates and passports, for establishing eligibility. Officials said an ERO who was not satisfied with the documents could mark an elector ineligible through a speaking order clearly recording the reasons. An initial report accessed by *The Hindu* had shown that 350 electors were marked "found ineligible". The Delhi CEO's office had subsequently warned against deletions on "flimsy grounds" and directed thorough verification.

Cong. asks Shah to ensure CEC's resignation, suspension of SIR

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Tuesday challenged Union Home Minister Amit Shah to ensure the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and suspend the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls before convening a Special Session of Parliament. Congress general secretary in-charge of communications Jairam Ramesh was responding to a challenge issued by Mr. Shah to Rahul Gandhi for a debate on SIR, EVMs, and allegations of 'infiltration'.

'Choose any stage': Rahul challenges PM to open debate

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Tuesday dared Prime Minister Narendra Modi to prove that Opposition parties were "anti-national", as he invited Mr. Modi to an open debate for the second time in two days.

Mr. Gandhi's latest challenge came within a day of his earlier call for an open debate with the Prime Minister, who had accused the Opposition of taking foreign help to destabilise the country.

The Congress leader, in turn, had accused Mr. Modi on Monday of coming to power and occupying the Prime Minister's chair with "foreign help".

In a video posted on his X handle on Tuesday, Mr. Gandhi said, "It has been 24 hours since I challenged you, Modi*ji*. You say the Opposition is anti-national. Choose any stage, any venue, and debate me on this."

Setting the stage for the proposed debate, the Opposition leader said there would be the media, the country's youth, and a table. "You can appoint whoever you want as the judge. You can even make [Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh chief] Mohan Bhagwat*ji* the judge," Mr. Gandhi said.

Mr. Gandhi said that during the proposed debate, he would raise questions about the country's financial system, the circumstances surrounding the India-U.S. deal, why it was concluded in haste, the closure of the Adani case, and the Epstein files, among other issues.

Rijiju's jibe

Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju took a swipe at Mr. Gandhi for challenging the Prime Minister to an open debate, saying the challenge was akin to "Islamic fundamentalists talking about secularism".

"Top-level debates are done between matured people," Mr. Rijiju said. "Pushing agendas of India's enemies, yet accusing others of foreign support is self-ridiculing," the Minister said, comparing the Opposition leader to separatists and anarchists.

Odisha, Andhra Pradesh police enter into tussle over Kotia villages dispute

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR



Police personnel of Odisha and Andhra Pradesh engage in a heated argument at the inter-State border point. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Police personnel from Odisha and Andhra Pradesh engaged in a scuffle on Tuesday at the inter-State border while asserting their respective jurisdictional claims over the Kotia group of villages in Odisha's Koraput district.

The latest flashpoint was the upcoming November 5 elections to Mandal Parishad Territorial Constituencies (MPTCs) and Zilla Parishad Territorial Constituencies (ZPTCs), which Andhra Pradesh wants to conduct in Kotia region.

Barricades in place

Around 10:00 a.m. on Tuesday, a group of A.P. officials, accompanied by security personnel, attempted to enter Kotia via Neredibalasa, a border village. They were stopped by Odisha police, which erected barricades. On Monday, Odisha had stopped a truck-load of rice packets at the border point. The A.P. officials argued that they had every right to conduct elections in Kotia as it belonged to their State. On the other hand, the Odisha government asserted that the Kotia group of villages was an inseparable part of the State and there was a Supreme Court status quo order in force since 2006.

Apprehending deterioration of the law and order situation, Koraput District Collector Manoj Satyawan Mahajan on Tuesday imposed prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita within the physical boundaries of all 21 villages of Kotia gram panchayat under Pottangi tehsil.

An all-party coordination meeting held on October 29 in Koraput had also resolved to block polling teams from Andhra Pradesh if they should enter upon the territory of Odisha.

"Kotia group of villages are an integral part of its territory and the State has filed a fresh contempt petition in the Supreme Court against Andhra Pradesh's election notification as it violates a 2006 order directing both States to maintain the status quo," alleged Odisha Revenue and Disaster Management Minister Suresh Pujari.

The border dispute between the States dates back to pre-independence era and even prior to the formation of Andhra Pradesh as a separate State.

Arunachal Pradesh gets new DGP days after Siang protest

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI



Rajesh Kumar

The Union Home Ministry on Tuesday replaced Arunachal Pradesh's Director General of Police (DGP). This comes amid protests in the State against the proposed Siang hydropower project and the demand by local communities for accountability against alleged police high-handedness directed at the protesters since October 23.

Rajesh Kumar, a 1995 batch Indian Police Service (IPS) officer, has been appointed the new DGP, replacing SDS Jamwal, an order said. Mr. Jamwal has been sent to Delhi.

Mr. Kumar, who has till now been posted as Special Director General of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) in Jammu and Kashmir, was repatriated to his parent cadre – the Arunachal Pradesh, Goa, Mizoram, and Union Territories (AGMUT) cadre – on Monday evening.

He helmed the CRPF in J&K when the three terrorists who carried out the 2025 Pahalgam attack were killed in "Operation Mahadev" on July 28, 2025.

On October 23 and 24, more than 30 people were detained after a violent protest in the State's Siang region against the proposed 11,200-megawatt Siang Upper Multipurpose Project (SUMP) on the Siang River.

Local people say the project would spell disaster for the land and its people, but the government claims it would minimise the impact of a 60,000-MW project China is building across the border.

On November 2, Chief Minister Pema Khandu, through an open letter, reached out to local residents protesting against the project, saying their concerns would be addressed through open dialogue, transparency and public consultation.

Indigenous capabilities in spotlight at Rajnath meet

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh chaired a meeting of the Consultative Committee of the Ministry of Defence on 'Modernisation of Indian Defence Forces' in Jaisalmer, Rajasthan, on Tuesday, with discussions focusing on emerging security challenges, future warfare, and the need to build a technologically advanced military.

According to the Ministry of Defence, the meeting deliberated on various aspects of military modernisation, including adoption of artificial intelligence (AI), autonomous systems, unmanned platforms, cyber, space and electronic warfare, and advanced communications to prepare the armed forces for future conflicts.

The Committee also emphasised the need for accelerating indigenous research, design, development and manufacturing under the Make in India and Aatmanirbhar Bharat initiatives, with greater participation from domestic industries, start-ups and academic institutions, the Ministry added.

INBRIEF



Two bodies found, six trekkers still missing in Uttarakhand

Rescuers searching for eight persons missing after an avalanche struck the Kedartal trekking route in Uttarkashi district of Uttarakhand recovered the bodies of a woman and a man on Tuesday. The identities of the deceased are not yet known. The eight persons – two from Uttar Pradesh, five from West Bengal, and one guide – went missing on October 30. Heavy snow and difficult terrain has slowed down the search for the fifth consecutive day. Meanwhile, authorities have suspended permits for treks at altitudes of 4,000 metres and above in view of the adverse weather. Another search operation is scheduled for Wednesday.

10 new import hubs for drugs, medical devices proposed

The Union Health Ministry has proposed expanding the network of entry points for drugs, medical devices and cosmetics into India to ease import operations and improve movement of healthcare products. The proposed locations include inland container depots: ICD Sonipat, Piyala and Harsaru in Haryana; ICD Dadri in Uttar Pradesh; ICD Gandhidham/Mundra in Gujarat; ICD Sanath Nagar and Thimmapur in Hyderabad; and ICD Whitefield in Bengaluru. The Ministry has also proposed including Special Economic Zone (SEZ) Bommasandra in Karnataka and Noida International Airport for the import of drugs by air.

ED attaches ₹510-cr. assets linked to Anil Ambani Group

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Enforcement Directorate has attached assets estimated at ₹510 crore linked to the Reliance Anil Ambani Group in connection with cases – involving siphoning off of public funds from banks and financial institutions – allegedly against Reliance Home Finance Ltd. (RHFL), Reliance Commercial Finance Ltd. (RCFL), and Reliance Communications Ltd. (RCom), the agency said on Tuesday.

In the RCom case, the agency has attached two chartered planes, six land parcels, and the premises of an office in Maharashtra. In the RCFL-RHFL case, two windmills in Tamil Nadu, bank balances, fixed deposits, and investments have been attached.

PMLA, FEMA provisions

"With the above attachments, the ED has cumulatively attached/seized assets worth approximately ₹23,100 crores till date in the cases under the provisions of PMLA [Prevention of Money Laundering Act] and FEMA [Foreign Exchange Management Act]," said the agency.

The ED has arrested 10 individuals in the cases.

Welfare payments will be based on voter IDs, not Aadhaar: Minister

Beneficiaries are identified and paid on the basis of Aadhaar at present; Panchayati Raj Minister says people must give EPIC number, biometrics

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI



Fraud risk: The Minister argued that an Aadhaar card can be easily made in five minutes at 'every street corner'. M.A. SRIRAM

Voter identity cards, along with biometric authentication, will be the basis for identifying beneficiaries and processing payments for welfare schemes within the ambit of the Panchayati Raj Ministry, Union Minister for Panchayati Raj and JD(U) leader Rajiv Ranjan Singh reiterated on Tuesday.

He was speaking to the media on the sidelines of an event at the Sikkim Cooperative Milk Producers' Union Ltd. in Gangtok.

He had made this remark earlier on Friday during a workshop organised by his Ministry on the "People's Plan Campaign (PPC) 2026-27" in Delhi.

His remarks come amid the Opposition campaign on "vote theft" alleging wrongful deletions from the electoral rolls.

"Aadhaar is currently the basis for payments to beneficiaries, but it will no longer be considered the primary means of identification," Mr. Singh said.

The Minister, while speaking in Delhi, had lamented the easy availability of the Aadhaar card, which he said can be made in "every street corner", implying the possibility of fraudulent beneficiaries.

"If one wants, one can get an Aadhaar card made in five minutes," he said.

He said the beneficiaries would instead have to provide biometric authentication along with their EPIC, or voter identification card, numbers to establish their identity and receive government benefits.

"Biometric authentication along with EPIC will serve as their identification credentials, and payments will be made based on that information," he said.

The proposed shift, the Minister argued in Gangtok, would ensure that welfare schemes are extended only to "eligible" beneficiaries, culling out "fraudulent entries". This would strengthen the verification process and improve transparency in the delivery of welfare benefits, he said

The Sixteenth Finance Commission has recommended total grants amounting to ₹4,35,236 crore for 2.55 lakh panchayats and traditional local bodies for 2026-31.

'Petty mindset': HC slams removal of Dia Mirza's video

Chinmay Gaikwad
MUMBAI



Dia Mirza

Emphasising that India has a secular Constitution which allows people of all backgrounds to participate in festivals, the Bombay High Court on Tuesday slammed political criticism of actor Dia Mirza's participation in a Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) campaign for an eco-friendly, firecracker-free Deepavali. The court directed the civic body to immediately re-upload Ms. Mirza's awareness video.

Though the BMC had recruited Ms. Mirza as one of several celebrities for its campaign, it had removed her video from its website after politicians from the ruling BJP and Shiv Sena objected to her participation on the grounds of religion, saying that Hindus did not need Ms. Mirza to teach them how to celebrate Deepavali, and asking why she had not made similar appeals for Muslim festivals.

A Division Bench of Justices Girish Kulkarni and Neela Gokhale reprimanded what they called a "petty mindset" and stressed that a festival is for everyone to celebrate and no person can be kept out of a festival in India. The Bench asked how anyone could object to participation by a person on the grounds of religion.

'Everyone breathes air'

The court pointed out that the video carried a message against pollution, as per the court order.

Justice Gokhale said the heart of the matter was the shared environment. Everyone breathes air, she said, adding that a bar on firecrackers does not take away anyone's right to celebrate a festival. There is no room for factionalism when the issue at stake is health and the environment, the Bench said.

It directed the BMC to re-upload the video and restore confidence among people, so that the matter ends with a sense of collective belonging in Mumbai, a city that survives on togetherness.

NHRC seeks report from three States on trafficking

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) on Tuesday took *suo motu* cognisance of media reports alleging the trafficking and sale of minor girls from the border districts of Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan to various cities in Maharashtra and issued notice to top officials in the three States to submit detailed reports within two weeks.

Parents, allegedly driven by poverty, sold their daughters to middlemen for amounts ranging from ₹3 lakh to ₹5 lakh, according to the media reports cited by NHRC.

The middlemen reportedly use forged documents to pass the girls off as their adopted children before trafficking them to Maharashtra for sex work.

Content, belonging, social realities: NBT charts Gen Z's reading habits

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

Internationally acclaimed literary fiction such as *The Silent Patient*, *Yellowface*, and *The Palace of Illusions*, translated Korean fiction such as *The Vegetarian*, and Hindi works such as poetry of Kabir and books written by Babasaheb Ambedkar are among the most popular choices for Gen Z in India, according to a National Book Trust (NBT) report based on a sample survey of visitors to the New Delhi World Book Fair, 2026.

The internal report prepared by the NBT, an autonomous body under the Union Education Ministry, was exclusively accessed by *The Hindu*.

India's youth are driving a distinct shift toward cosmopolitan tastes, the report said, citing the popularity of English titles and the emerging demand for identity-driven literature alongside the consumption of Hindi books.



College-goers show preference for best-selling global fiction, says report. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

According to the report, this year's book fair in January saw participation by 352 English publishers, followed by 156 Hindi publishers. There were only 24 Urdu publishers. Participation of regional language publishers was sparse.

Of the 20 lakh people who visited the fair, the NBT collected survey data from 3,650 who spent a total of ₹59 lakh on purchasing books.

Based on the sample size, college students made up about 40% of the attendees, the report says.

The NBT evaluation revealed that youth showed a preference for internationally acclaimed literary fiction. Psychological thrillers such as Alex Michaelides's *The Silent Patient* and Rebecca F. Kuang's *Yellowface* emerged as bestsellers.

There was also demand for translated fiction, particularly Korean works such as International Booker Prize-winning Han Kang's *The Vegetarian* and Bora Chung's *Cursed Bunny*, along with Japanese titles such as Toshikazu Kawaguchi's *Before the Coffee Gets Cold* and Satoshi Yagisawa's *Days at the Morisaki Bookshop*. The strong demand for translated Asian fiction indicates cosmopolitan tastes and a desire for diverse global perspectives, the NBT report said.

In the Hindi language segment, bestselling titles included the poetry of Kabir, the writings of B.R. Ambedkar, works by Osho, self-help literature, and translated copies of the Constitution of India.

"Purchase decisions of the youth are dependent on content addressing identity, belonging and contemporary social issues," the report said.

Vernacular constraints

"Demands for regional languages is growing but is limited to smaller segments," the report added, noting that the growing interest in regional language books is "constrained by publisher availability and discoverability".

India to push for predictable climate finance, equitable transition at key UN summit

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Predictable climate finance, technology transfer, and nationally determined approaches to climate mitigation and adaptation will be India's key demands at the UN Climate Change Conference (COP31) in Antalya, Turkiye, from November 9 to 20.

Underlining a long-standing position, India will reiterate that developed countries must fulfil their financial obligations to developing nations.

India is not inclined towards language suggesting "fossil fuel cuts or phase-out" or restrictions, as it is already on a pathway to ramp up its share of renewable energy, increasing forest cover, and improving energy efficiency.

These emerged at a press conference convened by Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav on Tuesday, outlining India's priorities ahead of the conference.



India will seek a decision to commence the Climate Finance Work Programme at COP31. AP

India will seek continuation of the Just Transition Work Programme (JWT) and "oppose attempts" to impose new, top-down mitigation targets on developing countries.

Climate finance will be a central negotiating issue, with India seeking a decision to begin a Climate Finance Work Programme.

Voluntary indicators

Mr. Yadav said finance provided by developed countries under Article 9.1 of the Paris Agreement must be "predictable, largely public and concessional", and must not add to the debt burden of developing countries.

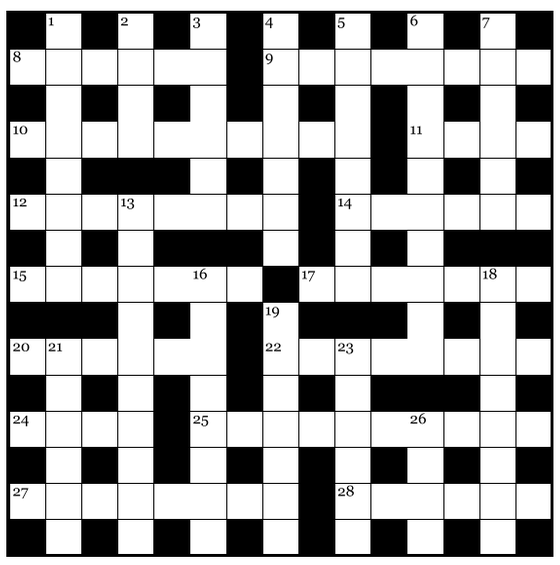
India will argue that indicators being developed under the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA) should remain voluntary and should not become conditions for accessing climate finance. "Among the successes that we have had is reducing the number of parameters down to 59 from the nearly thousand," Mr. Yadav said.

TH CROSSWORD + 14940

(set by Hypatia)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

8. Play fine part briefly — extremely iconic (6)
9. Merchants on the net using real site (8)
10. Lots of restrictions on department made redundant by outsourcing (10)
11. Basically every villain is legitimately wicked (4)
12. Cheesy style of posh folk visiting city with money (2,6)
14. Arrested and posted by leader, moving a step ahead (6)
15. Lover and acquaintance entered by porch (7)
17. Dad gathering items for hobby (7)
20. Sharply criticise one distorting opinion? (6)
22. America fighting war mostly leads to inequitable arrangement (1,3,4)
24. Beam in round cycles (4)
25. Check in and back off (7,3)
27. Stench of onion, initially eaten by guy — almost forbidding (5)
28. Dismissed former English parliamentarian close to cabinet (6)

Down

1. Hold dear darling (8)
2. Primarily slimy, like ugly garden creature (4)
3. Occasionally touch Elliott's cat (6)
4. Spooner's smelly bag charm, say (7)
5. Najeeb and Ann always wearing headscarf (8)
6. Relieved engineer in vital deal abroad(10)
7. Maverick actor's voyage (6)
13. Stern woman whose husband died bored by new movie (4,6)
16. IT record encrypted for supervisor (8)
18. My bad clue: "A map unfolds" (3,5)
19. Some retiring from the RBI lack competence (7)
21. After dusk, frequently picked up small ethnic outfits (6)
23. Jewellery taken out worn by girl ultimately (6)
26. Newcomer agitated this tree crow (4)

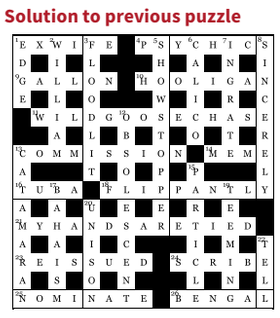
SUDOKU

				4	5	1		9
		2	6	8				
				3		4		8
7	3				2			
	8	1				6	7	
			8				9	1
6		7		9				
				6	4	2		
4		3	7	2				

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

1	4	9	5	2	7	6	3	8
6	5	8	9	1	3	4	7	2
7	2	3	8	6	4	9	5	1
2	7	4	3	5	1	8	6	9
5	8	1	4	9	6	3	2	7
3	9	6	7	8	2	1	4	5
8	6	7	2	4	9	5	1	3
4	3	5	1	7	8	2	9	6
9	1	2	6	3	5	7	8	4

FAITH

Kasi, food for soul

Kasi is often called Anna Kshetra since Goddess Annapoorani, an incarnation of Parvati, resides there permanently. Coming down to earth to undertake a penance for a playful sport with Siva leading to consequences, She chose Kasi at a time when the town was reeling under severe famine. Armed with a ladle and a pot, She brought back prosperity and stayed on, heeding the local king's request, and continued to bless devotees, said P. Swaminathan.

The town attracted saints, sages and ordinary devotees as well, especially around Deepavali. Long ago, Narayana Dikshitar, a staunch devotee who resided there, often invited holy men to his home and fed them humbly. On one occasion, after inviting a group of sadhus for a meal, he reached home only to find his wife bedridden. A harassed Dikshitar went out seeking a solution. Just outside his house he spotted a woman walking past. She looked at him kindly and the man blurted out his predicament. With a smile, she offered to help prepare the meal for the sadhus. The meal was a stupendous success and all the holy men blessed him. The woman had left the place after her duties and only then did Dikshitar realise that he had not even offered a meal to the woman who came to his aid. He had a dream wherein he apologised and asked to see her; the woman declared that she was Annapoorani. She affirmed that She would always remain with those who have a good heart and a supplicatory mind. Informing him that She had left a green turban on the eastern wall of the house, She instructed Dikshitar to install her idol there. "I will remain here forever," said Annapoorani. Visiting Kasi around Deepavali is considered efficacious.

In snails, a mother's hidden genes decide which way her baby spirals

In 2023, after poring through photos posted online by hikers, a researcher found a location in north Japan where there were both left and right-handed snails of a single species; their shells also looked similar, suggesting the snails had interbred; this new population provided important clues about how the myosin gene worked

D.P. Kasbekar

With a bit of penmanship, 'e' and '9' can be made to look like mirror images of each other. While the 'e' swings counter-clockwise, the '9' swings clockwise, written from top to bottom. Snails also can be similarly left- or right-handed depending on which way their shells coil.

But what decides which way the shell turns? Recently, scientists from the U.K. and Japan found the answer for Japanese *Euhadra* snails.

It depends on which variants of the gene for an unconventional myosin protein are present in the mother. Like us, snails possess two copies of every gene, one copy comes from the mother via the egg, and the other from the father via the sperm. When sperm and eggs are made, each receives only one copy of each gene pair.

The findings were published in *Current Biology* on October 16.



Like humans, snails also can be left or right-handed depending on which way their shells coil. KRZYSZTOF NIEWOLNY/UNSPLASH

Twisted trysts

Sex is startlingly different in snails than in, say, humans. For one, snails are hermaphrodites: an individual snail makes both sperm and eggs. For another, the outer opening of the reproductive system, called the genital pore, is located close to its head, on the right side. It is, however, almost invisible unless actively in use.

When snails mate, each partner protrudes a penis through the genital pore. Two penises of a mating pair enter each other's vaginal ducts, also in the pore. After exchanging sperm, the pair separates. Like two friends who shake hands, coupling is straightforward between same-handed snails. But if they are opposite handed, coupling becomes awkward, like one person extending their left hand and the other their right. The union can only be partly consummated as a result.

Handedness variants

Most *Euhadra* species are right-handed; four are left-handed. But only one of them, *Euhadra quaesita*, had both right- and left-handed populations. The researchers collected *E. quaesita* snails from three locations in north Japan. Each population was either fully right-handed or fully left-handed. The researchers also sampled the other *Euhadra* species, including all the four left-handed ones.

They sequenced the genomes of all the collected snails and searched for DNA sequences whose alternative versions correlated with left- and right-handedness. This is how they found the same variant of the myosin gene in all left-handed snails. They called it S (for sinistral, which is the Latin for "left-hand side"). All the right-handed snails contained the other variant of the myosin gene, which they called D (for dextral).

In 2023, one of the researchers found a location in north Japan where there were both left- and right-handed *E. quaesita* snails, after poring through photos posted online by hikers. Their shells also looked outwardly similar, suggesting the snails had interbred. This new population provided important clues about how the myosin gene worked.

The left-handed snails from this site included individuals with the myosin gene variants SS, DS, and DD, and right-handed ones included DD and DS, but not SS.

Maternal effect

There are two parts to the explanation.

First, an individual snail's handedness is determined by its mother's genes, not its own. Handedness is decided very early in the baby snail, even before its own genes begin to express themselves.

Second, if the mother has even only a single S variant (i.e. she is SD or SS), the offspring will be left-handed. Right-handedness only emerges if the mother is DD.

One right-handed snail collected from the site found in 2023 produced left-handed offspring in the laboratory. Which means it received its S variant from its father.

Likewise, the populations from the older three locations were uniformly SS or DD. Therefore, the maternal effect and dominance could not be inferred from them alone.

The myosin gene makes a protein of the same name, which helps cells make a complex with the actin protein. In our muscles, this actomyosin complex converts chemical energy into mechanical force and allows our bodies to move. In other cells, the complex drives cell division and cell movement.

'An exceptional model'

Earlier this year, researchers from Chiba University in Japan published a paper in the journal *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* reporting that filaments made of actin can be made to slide on a glass surface coated with myosin.

When the glass surface was coated with myosin from rabbit skeletal muscle, the actin filaments moved in a roughly straight path. In contrast, when the surface was coated with myosin from a green alga, the actin filaments moved in a clockwise curve. This revealed that some, but not all, myosin proteins can promote actin filament to move in a curved path.

The clockwise curve is an asymmetry at the molecular scale. It can change the axis of cell division relative that of the preceding division. The extent of change can differently impact cell-cell interactions of the daughter cells. This is asymmetry at the cellular scale.

"This paradigm offers a mechanistic basis for how motor-driven molecular asymmetry can give rise to coherent structural chirality at the cellular scale - an essential step in the emergence of cell chirality and asymmetry during development" the authors wrote. Chirality is the difference between left- and right-handedness.

What trajectories might the filament take on glass surfaces coated with *Euhadra* S- or D-myosin? The S version contains eight amino acid changes compared with the D version. One or more of them might contribute to a changed trajectory and thus trigger the change in handedness. The authors of the snail study concluded by saying "testing these ideas experimentally will provide important insight into the evolutionary plasticity of symmetry-breaking systems."

"This discovery deepens our understanding of how molecular-scale asymmetries propagate to the level of the whole body," they added, "and highlights snails as an exceptional model for dissecting the fundamental origins of left and right."

(D.P. Kasbekar is a retired scientist. kasbekardp@yahoo.co.in)

THE GIST

Like humans, snails possess two copies of every gene, one from the mother via the egg, and the other from the father via the sperm; when sperm and eggs are made, each receives only one copy of each gene pair

The reproductive system in a snail is located close to its head on the right side; thus mating between snails becomes awkward when they are opposite-handed, resulting in only partial mating

A myosin gene mutation is linked to shell handedness in *Euhadra* snails, with distinct variants found in left and right-handed populations

BIG SHOT



Climate toll: A 2025 photo of the once iconic Holiday Inn villas in Port Vila, Vanuatu, remain partially sunken and damaged by multiple cyclones and earthquake, underscoring the mounting vulnerability of Pacific island nations ahead of COP31 climate talks to be held in Turkiye next week. AP

WHAT IS IT?

Green firecrackers: an oxymoron?

Vasudevan Mukunth

Green firecrackers — like those the Supreme Court recently allowed the residents of New Delhi to burst for two days for Deepavali — are designed to pollute the air less as they burn.

According to the CSIR-National Environmental Engineering Research Institute (NEERI) team that developed them, these firecrackers emit 30% less particulate matter or, alternatively, emit 20% less particulate matter and 10% less gases — both compared to conventional firecrackers in the same category.

To this end, the team reportedly changed the proportions of fuels and oxidisers to increase how efficiently each cracker burnt, added additives to suppress dust formation, and/or reduced the quantities of certain metals.

Thus CSIR-NEERI developed three kinds of green firecrackers: Safe Water Releaser (SWAS), whose ingredients release water to suppress some of the particulate matter produced as they burn; Safe Thermite Cracker (STAR), which use a thermite-based composition to achieve higher combustion efficiency and lower emissions; and Safe Minimal Aluminium (SAFAL), which have lower aluminium content and, again, emit less.

Each of SWAS, STAR or SAFAL can be used in different types of fireworks, e.g. sparklers, flowerpots, etc.

All green firecracker products carry a CSIR-NEERI logo on their packaging and a QR code to verify the product's certificate.

While they pollute the air less, these firecrackers are still polluting — their emissions include fine particulate matter, noxious gases, and other combustion products — and harm respiratory and cardiovascular health. They are also noisy.



People buy crackers at ahead of Deepavali in Tamil Nadu on Friday. LAKSHMI NARAYANAN E

A city that bursts only green firecrackers also need not have less polluted air as that depends on the number of crackers burst, the local weather, and existing pollution levels.

For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Daily page'

Business, unusual

Engaging with the Myanmar junta is a short-sighted move

Months after a sham election that installed junta chief Min Aung Hlaing as Myanmar's civilian President, the military continues to wage war on its own people even as the world has largely looked away. More than a lakh people are estimated to have died since the 2021 coup, many in fighting between the junta and the anti-coup People's Defence Forces and ethnic armed organisations. The junta has also killed thousands of civilians in air strikes on villages in rebel-held areas to terrorise communities into giving up their resistance. With wars affecting Ukraine, Gaza, Sudan and Yemen, and Iran, the world has grown numb to such violence. The junta has exploited that indifference and a shifting geopolitical situation to act with impunity. Russia and China, its principal arms suppliers, have stood by it with the former supplying jets that were used to bomb civilians. Beijing, which tacitly allowed three ethnic armed organisations to launch an offensive in Shan and Rakhine States in late 2023, has since pressured two of them into ceasefires and returning seized territory. It also backed the January election. Since being sworn in, Min Aung Hlaing has visited India, Thailand, Vietnam and three other ASEAN member-states. ASEAN still swears by its Five-Point Consensus, which calls for an end to violence and dialogue. Yet, its members seem more than eager to do business with a regime that has flouted every point. Meanwhile, U.S. officials reportedly held secret talks with the junta in Tokyo in June and October, and a senior delegation met Min Aung Hlaing in Naypyidaw in September. Japan is reportedly pressing the Financial Action Task Force to take Myanmar off its blacklist.

The motives are not hard to understand. China wants an outlet to the Indian Ocean and security for its oil and gas pipelines. It has also played both sides, dealing with the junta and powerful rebel groups such as the Kachin Independence Organisation, whose territory is rich in rare earths and jade, and the United Wa State Army, which runs a massive tin mine. New Delhi wants to revive its stalled Act East policy, including the Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project. The U.S. eyes access to mining vital heavy rare earths such as dysprosium and terbium, for use in electric vehicles and weapons systems. What these short-sighted overtures miss is that trade thrives in a country at peace, not one where armed groups are perennially battling for control. The junta which has killed its citizens and has scuttled every move towards democracy cannot deliver that peace. Unless the generals are made to answer for their war crimes, Myanmar will remain a war zone. It will be ruinous not only for its hapless people but also for businesses seeking to trade with it.

Coming of age

Binance's reaction to the hack shows how the crypto industry has matured

The recent hack at Binance, the biggest theft ever at the world's largest cryptocurrency exchange, has lessons for India. But Indian policymakers must be careful to learn the right ones. First, it must be understood that the hack is not an indictment of the crypto space itself. Being a crypto exchange did not make Binance more vulnerable than if it were, say, a bank. Hacking is now a daily occurrence across sectors and even small pharmaceutical companies often have to fend off millions of attacks a month. Of course, Binance must look into how it was hacked and prevent a recurrence, but the cat-and-mouse game between hackers and security software developers is a perpetual one. For every million, or even billion, attacks that are stopped, one will inevitably get through. The lesson for Indian policymakers is not that crypto is unsafe in itself; this incident does not prove that. Rather, it is about how Binance prepared for and reacted to the attack. Back in 2018, Binance had set up an emergency fund called the Secure Asset Fund for Users (SAFU) to protect user assets in the event of a security breach or platform-level incident. The fund was created for exactly this kind of incident, and was financed through trading fees that Binance collects from users. Since the $6.3 billion worth of assets stolen exceeded the SAFU's resources, Binance dipped into its own resources to restore about 95% of users' assets within four days of the hack.

So, Binance used a stable source of revenue to finance an emergency fund, which it deployed when an emergency occurred. The system worked perfectly, also showing how maturely and responsibly the crypto space can be run. The Indian government and the Reserve Bank of India still view the private crypto space as the Wild West of techno-finance. This is no longer the case. Large crypto companies are employing prudential practices, safeguarding customers, and cooperating with law enforcement agencies. If the fear is that cryptocurrencies are not backed by any asset, then Indian policymakers can choose to allow only stablecoins, which do have real assets underpinning them. Indians are not at higher risk from cryptos than they are from fake stock market scams. The best defence is awareness. By refusing to regulate the crypto space in India and, indeed, taxing it at a prohibitive rate, the government is driving Indians towards either the black market, where such scams proliferate, or foreign exchanges. The government can take a leaf out of Binance's book and mandate an industry-maintained emergency fund. There is ample international legislation to emulate now. The point is, crypto risks have fallen and adoption is rising. Now is the time to regulate the industry.

On the Arunachal frontier, silence is not a strategy



Ashok K. Kantha

Subhas Chandra Bose Chair Professor of International Relations at Chanakya University, Bengaluru, and a former Ambassador of India to China

For some time, reports have circulated of transgressions by China's People's Liberation Army (PLA) in the Asaphila, Taksing and Longju areas of Arunachal Pradesh. The facts are neither clear nor officially acknowledged. Yet, there are signals that something out of the ordinary is happening along this stretch of the border. The matter warrants close attention.

The clearest signal came on October 22, 2026. Speaking at an Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) function, Director General Shatrujeet Singh Kapoor said: "In the past few days, a situation arose where face-off happened at several locations in Arunachal and it still continues." This was the first official confirmation of the scale of the problem. This daily reported, citing "government sources", that the two sides had been in a stand-off at Asaphila, near Taksing, since late July.

Following a brief face-off near Maja, close to Longju, the PLA reportedly returned in larger numbers and pitched tents about six to seven kilometres inside the Line of Actual Control (LAC), as India perceives it. The stand-off has persisted through meetings of the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China Border Affairs (WMCC), the Special Representatives and Corps Commanders, and Chinese President Xi Jinping's visit to India for the BRICS summit (September 2026).

Official responses, several questions

Official reactions are telling. Neither side has denied the face-offs. On October 23, the spokesperson for the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) referred questions about specific details to the Ministry of Defence. He added that the situation in the border areas "gets disturbed from time to time when Chinese forces diverge from established patrolling patterns". His Chinese counterpart said on October 26 that China "conducts normal border patrol and control activities to safeguard its territorial sovereignty and stability in the border areas".

The Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister Pema Khandu was more direct. "No doubt transgression has happened. It keeps happening," he said on October 29, noting that China does not recognise the McMahon Line.

Local groups have also been persistent in raising concerns. In June, the Nah Welfare Society of Taksing informed the district administration that the PLA had built roads, bridges and camps on traditional grazing and hunting grounds. In August, a fact-finding team from a regional party said that Indian patrols were being denied access to some areas. The Army described the June reports as "incorrect and without any basis". The Director General of the ITBP's remarks now lend weight to these local voices.

Some perspective is needed. Chinese transgressions in the Eastern Sector are not new. In the past, however, instances of adverse Chinese possession south of the international boundary have been confined to a few pockets: the Namkha Chu and Sumdorong Chu valleys, and Longju. Elsewhere, the Line of Actual Control (LAC) coincides with the boundary. If China has now made deeper intrusions, established a presence in new areas, expanded its presence in existing pockets or prevented Indian patrols from accessing certain areas, this is a serious, though not unexpected, development. Many of us have cautioned that China could attempt in the Eastern Sector what it did in Eastern Ladakh in 2020.

India's silence on Chinese border intrusions risks emboldening Beijing and undermining New Delhi's position

Chinese commentators have been less coy. A day after the ITBP Director General spoke, one of them argued that the "bottom line" of China's approach was to enforce the "1959 Line". China, he wrote, had "largely achieved this goal" in the Western Sector and was "very likely to implement it in the Eastern Sector in the future".

China's claims, India's rejection

The so-called LAC of November 7, 1959, has no standing with India. In the Eastern Sector, China claims that it coincides with the "illegal" McMahon Line, except at Khinzemane. However, China defines that line by transposing coordinates from the 1914 maps onto present-day maps, ignoring the highest watershed, which was the basis of the 1914 alignment. This approach is entirely unscientific, and India has never accepted it.

In the negotiations leading to the 1993 Agreement on the Maintenance of Peace and Tranquillity along the LAC, India accepted the concept of the LAC but specifically rejected the Chinese notion of a 1959 line. The LAC was the line of actual control on the ground as it exists, not a notional or historical alignment. In cases of Chinese transgressions, India pressed for the restoration of the status quo ante. The April 2005 Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for the Settlement of the India-China Boundary Question goes further. In seeking a boundary settlement, Article V requires the two sides to take into account, among other things, "the actual state of border areas".

Chinese transgressions blatantly violate several border agreements that require both sides to "strictly respect and observe" the LAC and not to "overstep" it. Both sides are also committed to refraining from unilaterally altering the status quo. Compounding the problem, China has begun defining the LAC in terms of sovereignty, as the phrasing of its Foreign Ministry statements suggests. This runs contrary to the basic concept of the LAC. When the two sides first formally agreed to use the term in the September 1993 agreement, they explicitly stated that references to the LAC "do not prejudice their respective positions on the boundary question" (Article 6).

India, on the other hand, keeps referring to "different perceptions" of the LAC. In doing so, India lends a degree of legitimacy to Chinese transgressions and weakens its own position. Why should India make such a reference unilaterally, especially when Beijing has forcefully revived its "Zangnan" (South Tibet) narrative on Arunachal Pradesh? For India, there should be one perception of the LAC, which is India's perception. The 1996 Agreement referred to "different perceptions" of the LAC, but Article X also required the two sides to arrive at a "common understanding" of the "entire alignment" of the LAC through an exchange of maps. The "Eight-Point Consensus" of the Special Representatives, announced on August 26, refers to discussions on "ways to improve understanding of the LAC in appropriate areas".

The MEA spokesperson reiterated this formulation. India would be well advised not to formalise the idea of "improved understanding". Doing so would help China achieve what it has sought for two decades: to wriggle out of a formal commitment to establish a "common understanding" of the LAC through an exchange of maps and clarification of its alignment. Ambiguity over the LAC suits a party bent on salami-slicing.

None of this means that every transgression must be publicised. If transgressions follow the pattern of earlier behaviour, it is understandable that the government would not wish to highlight them. However, if the pattern changes, intrusions spill over into new areas, or, more seriously, adverse possession or a physical presence expands, the situation becomes far more serious. This was the litmus test applied in the past.

Hiding intrusions weakens border security

Nothing suggests that keeping such transgressions under wraps helps resolve them. It is incumbent on the government to bring them into the public domain, as it has done in the past. When Chinese forces moved into Wangdung in 1986, the matter was made public and discussed in Parliament. The government also acknowledged Chinese transgressions in Eastern Ladakh in 2020, though transparency has been inadequate since then. If India falls into a pattern of denials, obfuscation or conflicting signals, it will only encourage more blatant salami-slicing.

A related question is how India should respond. Should such transgressions be raised primarily at meetings of border commanders, or should they be taken up forcefully at the diplomatic level and, if necessary, at the political level?

Experience offers a clear answer. In September 2014, Prime Minister Narendra Modi raised the Chumar transgression with Mr. Xi on the first day of his visit to India. This was a key factor in China agreeing to restore the status quo ante. In Eastern Ladakh, by contrast, the status quo ante of April 2020 has yet to be restored, even after six years. India cannot allow China to get away with its playbook of incremental gains that, taken together, create a qualitatively new situation to its advantage.

If there are indeed Chinese transgressions beyond areas of persistent intrusion, particularly if Chinese forces are present in areas on India's side of the LAC or the PLA is preventing India's border forces from patrolling regularly, India would be better served by acknowledging this publicly. Candour will strengthen New Delhi's hand in dealing with Beijing, not weaken it.

In Tehran, a search for the future of West Asian security



Kabir Taneja

The Executive Director of the Observer Research Foundation (ORF) Middle East

More than eight months after the United States and Israel launched strikes on Iran, West Asia remains on tenterhooks, as the United States, Israel, and Iran continue to flirt with a resumption of military hostilities. Elections in Israel as well as the U.S. midterm polls offered an interesting pause, even as war rhetoric remained high. Amid these tensions, an alliance of Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan, known as the "Mecca Agreement", arrived in Iran's capital in October to discuss regional security.

A large part of Iran's response since the U.S. and Israel began bombing the country in February 2026 has been to target American interests, including data centres, and military installations across the Gulf states. This forms part of Tehran's strategy of asymmetric warfare, shaped by its view of the conflict as an existential threat to the Islamic Republic, particularly following the killing of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in an airstrike.

Why now

The Tehran visit was perhaps one of the most consequential diplomatic moves initiated. From Riyadh's point of view, despite the official statement issued by its Foreign Ministry highlighting diplomatic efforts to disallow a return to military conflict in the region, the outreach had a singular aim: to prevent its conflict with the Houthis from escalating.

Riyadh's airport has been largely shut since October 10, after Houthi-launched missile strikes. A Saudi-led coalition responded with air strikes, but with limited impact. The Houthis have since gained further territorial control in the embattled country, as Saudi Arabia looked clueless on what to do next. Air campaigns against the Houthis have yielded limited results since 2015.

The delegation in Tehran was not led by diplomats but by defence and intelligence leaders from the three countries. It included Pakistan's Army chief, Asim Munir, a favoured military leader of U.S. President Donald Trump, who has also played a mediating role between Washington DC and Tehran. The main point of interest, however, was the Iranian delegation, led by Mohsen Rezaei took over the country's powerful Supreme National Security Council (SNSC) in August, succeeding Mohammad Bagher Zolghadr, who had replaced Larijani after his death in March. Rezaei's prominence in the talks also highlights where the nucleus of Iran's emerging power structure lies. The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) has taken centre stage as the country remains on a wartime footing, with multiple power centres vying for influence following the death of the Ayatollah. The IRGC's leading role is not surprising, given that it has always operated directly under the Supreme Leader's authority.

The 'Mecca Agreement' alliance's outreach to Tehran highlights competing visions for West Asian security

Conflict into leverage

Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan travelling to Iran for this exchange came as a surprise to many, given that Tehran had struck several Arab countries in response to American and Israeli aggression. However, Iran would have sought such an exchange, as it stands to benefit from it. It has made no bones about its support for newer, region-led securitisation taking precedence over those operating under American auspices. The Mecca Agreement, signed in August and tested to its limits by October, has shown little appetite for collaborative military action in the region, despite comparisons with the North Atlantic Treaty Organization. Following its signing, Iran supported the initiative, with some reports even suggesting that Islamabad might seek Tehran's official membership. For Iran, however, being part of every forum and conversation about the future of West Asian security is exactly what it seeks. Tehran believes that the events of recent months, and its response to them – including the high-risk decision to target its Gulf neighbours – have created leverage that countries such as Saudi Arabia may now seek to address through dialogue. Iran's access to the Houthis, whom it has helped strengthen, is what Riyadh hopes to mobilise for de-escalation, while Pakistan and Türkiye play supporting roles and consolidate their own positions in another iteration of the proverbial "new West Asia".

The road ahead

Ultimately, for Iran, the crevasses created by a conflict that has not delivered the intended outcomes for the Trump administration present an opportunity to consolidate its position with the Gulf states. Many of its neighbours may grudgingly accommodate its demands because they have few alternatives. However, not all may agree with or support the Mecca Agreement's outreach. This could lead to greater divisions over how to engage with Iran within the construct of a regional security architecture for the future, particularly as Tehran is now widely seen as an aggressor – a label the IRGC will not mind, as it seeks to project Iran as a regional power – and remains a geographic reality to contend with. Iran has previously said it is willing to meet its Gulf partners "anywhere" and on any platform to discuss regional security. Although this remains conjecture, the idea of hosting the talks in Tehran may well have originated with Iran itself.

The months ahead will remain tense in West Asia. Recalibrating a long-standing security order is often a chaotic process. The U.S. will not exit the region, but it may have to share space. Mr. Trump will be fine with this. Whether a U.S. accustomed to hegemonic dominance will accept it remains to be seen.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Conditional use

The Supreme Court's decision permitting green crackers for two days within prescribed timings in Delhi-NCR is welcome. However, effective implementation and enforcement during these hours remain crucial. Such directives should extend to other metropolitan and urban areas rather than serve merely as temporary damage-control measures. Environmental protection must go beyond regulatory restrictions and become a shared public responsibility, fostering a culture in which concern for the environment is integral to collective thinking and practice in India.

Rushita Avula,
Hyderabad

INDIA bloc stir

The stir in New Delhi, by almost all the major Opposition parties, has had one salutary effect — bringing them all together against the divisive tendencies of the BJP. It has made the people realise that they cannot be cheated of their rights or disenfranchised through foul means. The protests make it clear that the Chief Election Commissioner must go and that free and fair elections are essential. The voters' list of 2024 must be restored, and a fresh one prepared through a fair, lawful process. Although impeaching the CEC under the present parliamentary composition may be difficult, fresh polls based on a corrected roll are essential to restore a truly democratic Parliament.

N.G.R. Prasad,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The elephant in the classroom



Jean Drèze

Visiting Professor at the Department of Economics, Ranchi University

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) has done us all a good turn by drawing attention to the dismal state of school facilities in large parts of the country. Even the modest norms of the Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act, 2009 (better known as the Right to Education Act or the RTE Act) are yet to be met in a large number of schools. Contrary to the impression given by official statistics, such as the Unified District Information System for Education, India's schools are still rife with leaky roofs, clogged toilets, broken handpumps and missing playgrounds.

Hopefully, the audit of government schools initiated by the CJP will help to identify the underlying structural failures. It is not just a question of spending levels. More importantly perhaps, corrupt contractors have been allowed to make plenty of money from shoddy work. Further, no effective systems are in place to ensure regular repair and maintenance of school facilities. In Jharkhand, even the small school funds normally available for this purpose have been discontinued in the last two years, making it difficult to deal with the simplest of maintenance problems such as buying mops and brooms.

Having said this, it would be wrong to conclude that teaching standards cannot improve in government schools without better infrastructure. There is, in fact, vast scope for improvement, starting with more active teaching. Far too often, children are left to mill around or sit on their own for hours on end. The lack of active teaching is the main reason why so many children learn so little at school, condemning them to join the ranks of low-paid casual workers later in life.

On non-teaching duties

Teachers, for their part, complain that non-teaching duties constantly encroach on teaching time. There is, no doubt, some truth in this, but it is not the whole truth.

Section 27 of the RTE Act clearly states that no teacher is to be deployed for "any non-educational purposes" other than the population census, disaster relief and election-related duties. The loophole, of course, is that "educational purposes" is an elastic term. Under the garb of educational purposes, teachers have been assigned all sorts of non-teaching tasks such as taking digital attendance, extensive record-keeping, helping children to open Aadhaar-linked bank accounts, generating APAAR (Automated Permanent Academic Account Registry) numbers for them and so on. Record-keeping work, in particular, has ballooned with the Aadhaar-augmented double burden of physical and digital records.

The missing part of the truth is that a teacher's timetable is supposed to have substantial space for non-teaching tasks. The RTE Act prescribes a minimum of 45 hours of work per week for school teachers. It also has an implicit norm of at least four hours of classroom teaching per day in primary schools – 800 hours over 200 days, as a minimum. Thus, over a six-day week, a primary-school teacher has up to 21 hours to spare for non-teaching tasks, outside classroom hours. Even after deducting, say, one hour a day for class preparation, 15 hours would remain for other education-related tasks every week. Without denying that teachers have excessive non-teaching duties, one may question the claim that these duties generally prevent teachers from teaching for the minimum duration prescribed by the RTE Act.

The time clash arises from the fact that many teachers have a habit of completing non-teaching tasks during classroom hours. Sometimes this is forced on them, for instance when teachers are summoned to the Block Resource Centre during school hours, or when they receive WhatsApp messages asking them to submit reports "immediately". Sometimes teachers themselves perform non-teaching tasks during classroom hours to avoid long work days. Whoever is to blame, the fact is that no clear demarcation is being observed between teaching and non-teaching time in many schools, with teaching time becoming the casualty.

A new understanding is needed, where classroom hours are well-defined and sacrosanct. If non-teaching duties are excessive, that is an issue that needs to be resolved between teachers and the school education department. Children cannot be held hostage to this conflict. Most teachers are likely to support this understanding, if it goes hand in hand with better infrastructure, a reduction of non-teaching duties, and some clerical assistance.

The cart and the horse (infrastructure and work culture) will have to move together. The first step is to stop tolerating the injustice being done to millions of children who are stuck in dysfunctional schools.

If non-teaching duties are excessive, that is an issue that needs to be resolved between teachers and the school education department. Children cannot be held hostage to this conflict

Delhi needs better slum rehabilitation policy



Surbhi Sachdeva

Senior Resident Fellow at the Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy. All views are personal

The Delhi Assembly recently passed a law shifting the cut-off for recognising *jhuggi-jhopri* (unplanned slum settlements) clusters from January 1, 2006 to January 1, 2025. The Centre says the new rehabilitation push could benefit roughly four lakh families; a necessary correction to an arbitrary exclusion. However, much more is needed to guarantee a smooth relocation process.

Delhi's soon-to-be notified 2026 slum rehabilitation policy should begin with one principle: the unit of rehabilitation is not a flat, but a household's urban life – work, school, care, neighbours and commute. Indian courts have said as much for decades. In *Olga Tellis*, the Supreme Court connected shelter location to livelihood; in *Sudama Singh* and *Ajay Maken*, the Delhi High Court required meaningful engagement, surveys and proper rehabilitation rather than treating residents simply as encroachers. Delhi therefore needs an enforceable "in-situ first, relocation last" rule. Where relocation is genuinely unavoidable, no demolition should occur until a serviced home is ready within a reasonable livelihood catchment, with public transport, schools and health facilities functioning from day one.

Delhi should also learn from Mumbai's successes, and perhaps more importantly, its shortcomings. The Supreme Court's 2024 *Yash Developers* judgment identified recurring failures in Maharashtra's slum-rehabilitation regime such as disputes over eligibility, developer selection, transit accommodation, weak remedies and regulatory accountability. The Bombay High Court's 2026 'performance audit' proceedings have since confronted the same system, including developer delays, opaque selection processes and transit rent defaults. The takeaway is straightforward: a slum policy cannot become a land monetisation policy with a welfare annexure.

Where relocation is genuinely unavoidable, no demolition should occur until a serviced home is ready within a reasonable livelihood catchment, with public transport, schools and health facilities functioning from day one

Modelling the model

If Delhi uses a public-private partnership model, the State must retain control of the outcomes. Developers should face transparent pre-qualification, audited financial capacity tests, project-specific performance bonds and milestone-based deadlines. If developers are mandated to reserve a certain part of the land for existing slum dwellers and allow for the "free sale" of the remaining land, safeguards should ensure the quality of materials, infrastructure, and development in the rehabilitative area as this has emerged as a recurring issue in other cities.

Mumbai's recent experience itself points towards stronger financial-capacity scrutiny and advance protection of transit rent. Delhi should go further: transit rent should be escrowed in advance, with automatic penalties, and replacement of defaulting developers. Every project should have a public dashboard showing households surveyed, eligibility decisions, appeals, construction milestones, transit payments and expected possession. Residents should receive independent legal and technical assistance before consenting to redevelopment.

The policy should, therefore, offer three routes chosen on a settlement-by-settlement basis: incremental in-situ upgrading with secure tenure where land and safety permits; low- or mid-rise redevelopment where rebuilding is necessary; and relocation only where occupation is demonstrably untenable or when the land is required for an overriding public purpose. Odisha's Jaga Mission offers a useful counter-example; created around a statutory land-rights framework, it has combined tenure security with community-led infrastructure, upgrading slums rather than making demolition and rebuild the default.

Finally, the 2025 cluster cut-off must not become a new documentary trap. Settlement recognition should not depend on every resident being able to produce perfect documentary proof. Research on earlier Delhi schemes found that eligibility rules could exclude a substantial proportion of residents – precisely the households most likely to be displaced again.

Success should not be measured by acres "cleared", tenders issued or towers inaugurated, but by whether families are still securely housed near their livelihoods, and whether children remain in school, maintenance is affordable, and if no one has been pushed into a new informal settlement. Delhi has moved the date. Now it must move the model.

Fewer students are borrowing a lot more for education

While the number of education loan accounts has declined by 15.2%, the total amount borrowed has nearly tripled

DATA POINT

Gauri Singavarapu

Over the last 10 years, the number of students availing educational loans has shrunk while the money borrowed has sharply risen, an analysis of quarterly data published by the Reserve Bank of India on outstanding credit of scheduled commercial banks showed.

The number of student loan accounts declined by 15.2% from 25.76 lakh in June 2016 to 21.84 lakh in June 2026.

However, in the same period, the average amount of loan outstanding per education loan account increased by 178.2% from ₹2.6 lakh to ₹7.25 lakh, an indication of rising costs of education, as observed by the 372nd report of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports.

Chart 1 shows how the total number of student loan accounts have seen a decline over the 10-year period.

Although there is marginal improvement in the total number of accounts in the last three years, the increase has come from students going for bigger-sized loans over ₹2 lakh.

While such loan accounts have increased by 31.6% from 14.31 lakh in the 10-year period, the number of accounts in the smaller loans category of up to ₹2 lakh have drastically declined from 11.44 lakh to just three lakh, which is roughly one-fourth of their previous size between June 2016 and June 2026.

Less loans but bigger

Chart 2 shows the corresponding growth in the average outstanding amount per loan account. For smaller loan accounts, the size has remained fairly the same.

Driven by the increased size of loans in the above ₹2 lakh category, from ₹3.82 lakh to ₹8.25 lakh, the overall average of amount outstanding per student loan account has increased from ₹2.6 lakh to ₹7.25 lakh – an increase of 178.2% as mentioned earlier.

An analysis of education loans in different slabs shows how loans of bigger sizes have increased noticeably in the last 10 years. Loan accounts in the range of ₹25,000 to ₹2 lakh accounted for 41.2% in June 2016. This share dropped to just 13.6% in June 2026 **(Chart 3)**.

The data also showed that the share of education loans in the total amount of credit given by scheduled commercial banks have come down over the years. As per the RBI's data, education loans accounted for 0.93% of the total share in June 2016. This came down to 0.74% in June 2026. This is despite the total outstanding amount under the education loans increasing from ₹67,175 crore in June 2016 to ₹1,58,468 crore **(Chart 4)**.

While inflation would have contributed, by a small extent, to the loan amount increasing in size, the declining share of education loans along with the declining number of loan accounts indicate that fewer students are borrowing a lot more for education than they did in 2016.

Education more affordable?

Education becoming affordable or more students joining government-run institutions that offered free education or at subsidised costs are unlikely to be the factors behind the notable decline in the number of student loan accounts. This is inferred from the All India Survey of Higher Education's (AISHE) annual reports showing that the number of students entering government-run colleges has remained fairly the same over the years, with 2023-24, the latest year for which the report is available, in fact showing a decline **(Chart 5)**.

Moreover, the estimated budget of the Department of Education has also come down from being 1.46% of India's budget in 2016-17 to 0.99% in 2025-26.

Costlier affair?

The data were sourced from the Reserve Bank of India's reports on scheduled commercial banks, which include all the major public and private sector banks. Rural banks and non-banking financial companies are not included. Gauri Singavarapu was interning with The Hindu



CHART 1: While the number of small loan accounts have declined, the large loan accounts have increased

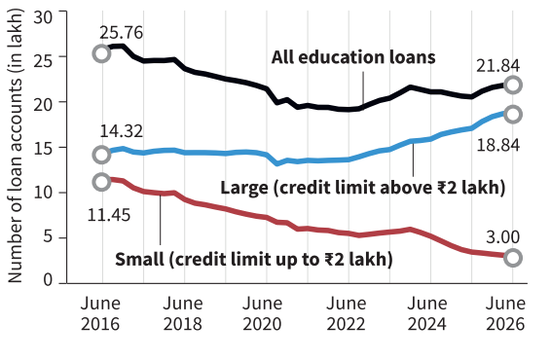


CHART 4: The share of education loans in the total credit portfolio of banks has declined

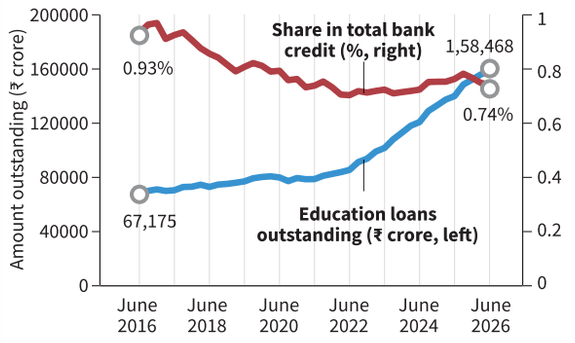


CHART 2: The average amount outstanding per loan account has sharply increased in the last 10 years

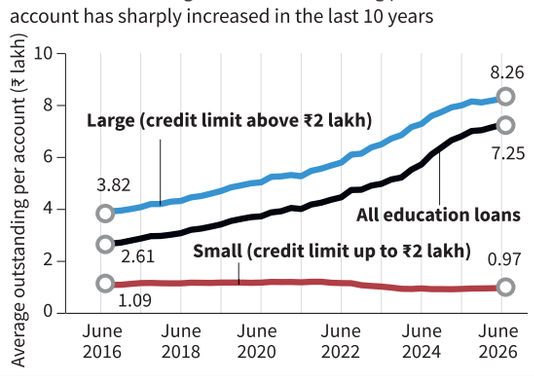


CHART 5: The number of students enrolling in government-run colleges have remained fairly the same, with 2023-24 marking a notable decline. *(Values in lakh)*

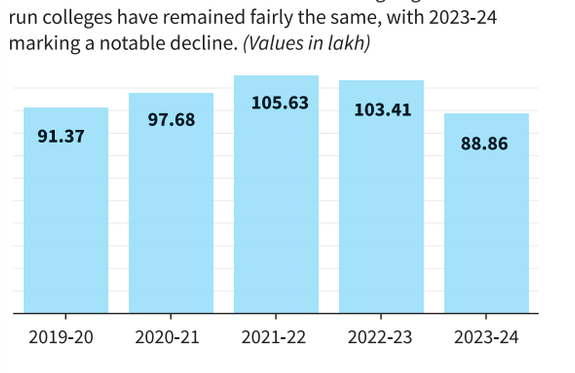
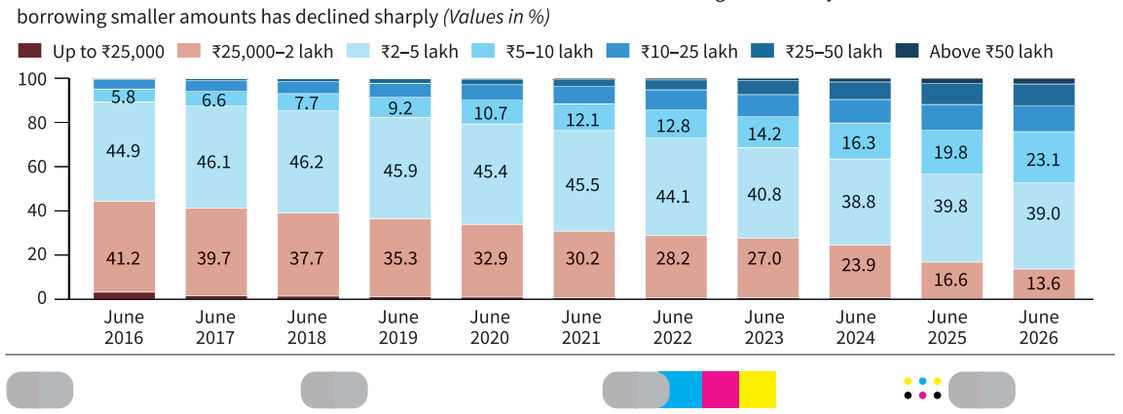


CHART 3: This shows how the share of loan accounts in each credit slab has changed over the years. The share of accounts borrowing smaller amounts has declined sharply *(Values in %)*



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO NOVEMBER 4, 1976

Carter elected President of U.S. in close contest

Washington, November 3: Mr. Jimmy Carter, the peanut farmer from Georgia, who was a political unknown until early this year was elected the 39th President of the United States after he defeated the White House incumbent, Mr. Gerald Ford, in a closely fought election held yesterday.

It was a remarkable achievement for a "rank outsider" who had started his quest for the Presidency two years ago, without much money, without a real political base and without going through the traditional corridors of power. To the loser, Mr. Ford, who was unexpectedly and accidentally elevated to the highest place in the land after Mr. Richard Nixon resigned 28 months ago, it was the end of a long but unspectacular career in politics.

By winning the Presidency, Mr. James Earl Carter became the first person from the Deep South to gain that office since Gen. Zachary Taylor in 1848. At 52, he will also be the youngest man since Mr. John Kennedy to reach the White House. On the other hand, Mr. Ford, the first man ever to become President through appointment, had also the ill-luck to be the first incumbent to be defeated in an election since Mr. Herbert Hoover, 44 years ago.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO NOVEMBER 4, 1926

U.S. general elections

As there was no issue dated November 4, 1926, from the issue dated November 3, 1926

New York, November 2: The main issues in to-day's elections are: – Firstly, will the next Congress be Republican or Democratic. Secondly, will Governor Smith be re-elected for New York State and Thirdly, will "dry" sentiment in United States reassert itself though the referenda initiated by eight states.

The Democrats need only 9 seats in the Senate and 36 in the House of Representatives to obtain control and be able to snap their fingers at the Coolidge Administration.

Governor Smith made a bid for presidential nomination at 1924 Democratic Convention and to-day's election will have considerable bearing on his chances of nomination in 1928.

An amusing sidelight on the elections, which is symptomatic, has been the eagerness of New York politicians to proclaim themselves "wet".

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Dengue and malaria cases reported by Delhi till October 31

1438 Delhi has reported 1,083 dengue and 355 malaria cases till October 31 this year, even as no deaths due to either disease have been reported, as per a Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) report. The national capital recorded 90 fresh dengue cases and 18 malaria cases during the week ending October 31, the report stated. PTI

Revised minimum fare demanded by Bengal private bus operators

18 in ₹. The Joint Council of Bus Syndicates, an apex body of private bus operators in West Bengal, has suggested a revised slab-based fare for ordinary local buses in Kolkata. Council general secretary Tapan Banerjee, in a letter to the Transport dept. suggested that passengers be charged ₹18 for four km, ₹22 for six to eight km, ₹24 for eight to 12 km, ₹26 for 12 to 16 km and so on. PTI

Drought relief sought by Karnataka from Central government

22,400 in ₹ crore. G. Parameshwara, Karnataka's Deputy Chief Minister has sought ₹22,400.58 crore in drought relief from the Centre, urging the Prime Minister to expedite the release of funds to farmers affected by crop losses. The State's drought-relief requirement has been revised upwards to ₹22,400.58 cr. PTI

Number of bar licences to be reviewed by Keralam

400 Keralam Minister M. Liju on Tuesday said the government had decided to re-examine the previous LDF government's decision to grant bar licences to more than 400 beer-and-wine parlours in the State. Mr. Liju said instructions had been issued to make amendments to the rules to plug loopholes allegedly created by the previous Left administration. PTI

Villages identified by Meghalaya to preserve indigenous heritage

11 Meghalaya Chief Minister Conrad K. Sangma on Tuesday said the State government has identified 11 villages to preserve indigenous traditions and knowledge while creating sustainable livelihood opportunities for artisans. In a post on X, Mr. Sangma said preserving cultural heritage required sustained government intervention. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Need for a unified urbanisation plan

The Union Budget, Economic Survey and Finance Commission recognise that India is urbanising across a rural-urban continuum. Yet Census 2027 will use the 2011 definitions, deepening the undercount of urban India; a National Urbanisation Policy can recognise this gap and build the institutional and fiscal mechanisms to bridge it

ECONOMIC NOTES

Sudeshna Chatterjee
Jaya Dhindaw

India's 2027 Census, happening after 16 years, will classify a settlement as urban if it is either notified by a State as a statutory town or meets three census-town criteria: a population of at least 5,000, a density of at least 400 persons per sq km, and at least 75% of male workers engaged in non-agricultural work. Everything else will be counted as rural.

This preserves comparability across Census years, but it also means the Census will measure urban India with a yardstick that our own economic and fiscal institutions have begun to move beyond.

Measuring urbanisation

In 2011, India had 377 million urban residents across ~8,000 cities and towns. Since then, States have notified another 1,000 statutory towns. The United Nations estimates that 44% of Indians live in urban areas today, projecting the urban population to cross 720 million by 2050.

The growth has been extraordinarily uneven. Greater Mumbai had close to 12 million residents in 2011, while statutory towns like Gangotri Nagar Panchayat in Uttarakhand have a population of 110.

Around 94% of India's urban settlements are small towns, while ~60% of the urban population lives in Class I cities–which includes cities with populations ranging from 1 lakh to 20 million. It lumps together megacities like Mumbai and Delhi with non-metropolitan cities like Mangaluru and Amravati, obscuring radically different needs and capacities. Meanwhile, the fastest growth is unfolding beyond cities: peri-urban areas are expanding at ~4.15% a year, compared to 2.9% growth occurring within administrative boundaries.

The Economic Survey 2026 stated that India is far more urban in functional terms than its definitions admit, citing satellite data that placed the country at 63% urban in 2015. The 2026 Union Budget allocated ₹5,000 crore each to City Economic Regions, shifting the focus from individual cities to wider economic geographies. The 16th Finance Commission raised the share of local grants earmarked for urban local bodies to 45%. It also created a ₹10,000-crore 'urbanisation premium' to encourage States to merge peri-urban villages into adjoining municipal areas and develop rural-to-urban transition policies.

These measures signal a critical shift, but they do not constitute a coherent framework for recognising transitioning settlements, planning across administrative boundaries or aligning fiscal incentives across India's system of cities. That is the missing link which a National Urbanisation Policy could bridge.

Rethinking the rural-urban binary

Firstly, why does a classification carry so much weight? In India, classification is a gateway. Master plans, municipal finance, Finance Commission grants, building regulation, environmental clearance thresholds and scheme eligibility all depend, in different ways, on how a settlement is classified. This classification is also politically reversible. Article 243Q(2) leaves the notification of an area as urban to the discretion of States, with no standard criteria or requirement to publish reasoning behind the decision.

The law treats rural and urban as mutually exclusive and not a continuum. Consider Bhiwandi region near Mumbai that spans 60 villages and nine census towns. Here, 91.8% of employment is non-agricultural, yet it is still governed as rural, leaving Panchayats responsible for land use, waste, water and air quality, without a mandate or technical capacity.

The planning consequences are stark. Around 52% of statutory towns and 76% of census towns have no master plan. Nine States have not updated their planning legislation since the 74th Constitutional Amendment in 1992. Meanwhile, the model law most States rely on dates from 1985, and says nothing about the rural-urban continuum, the 74th Amendment, the 2013 Land Acquisition Law, and the emergence of climate adaptation as a planning imperative.

The necessity of national guidance

National guidance on urbanisation already exists, although unacknowledged. Census classification rules, Finance Commission formulae and scheme eligibility criteria, collectively determine which settlements count as urban and what they receive. Because these were not designed as a coherent policy framework, no single institution is answerable for their combined effects.

A National Urbanisation Policy would not prescribe a one-size-fits-all blueprint or a parallel delivery system. Grounded in subsidiarity, it could establish shared principles to build coherence across existing institutions, letting the Centre channel funds, build capacity and coordinate across tiers of government.

The need for a National Urbanisation Policy

WRI India's report '*Equitable, Productive, Low-carbon and Resilient System of Cities in India - Recommendations for a National Urbanisation Policy*' proposes seven systems transformations:

Standardise the definition and classification of statutory urban settlements; modernise spatial and regional planning; reorient public and private finance flows into urbanisation; embed a tiered coordination architecture, anchored by a National Urbanisation Council; build sectoral reforms on functional foundations; align urban politics with reform incentives; and support knowledge exchange and local innovation.

The first three are foundational and their sequence matters. Article 243W makes devolution permissive rather than mandatory, so notification does not automatically transfer all 18 municipal functions listed in the Twelfth Schedule, to newly notified urban areas. A settlement that has not been classified as urban cannot even begin the transition towards receiving critical municipal services. Therefore, settlement status should be reviewed at fixed intervals against set criteria, not only during the Census, using satellite and geospatial data on built-up growth and economic activity, as the Economic Survey recommends.

Spatial planning comes second because every other reform, from housing and infrastructure to climate adaptation and finance, must ultimately be located somewhere. Yet for most Indian settlements, the plans that should guide these decisions do not exist.

The institutional foundations for better coordination do exist. Metropolitan and District Planning Committees have existed under Articles 243ZE and 243ZD of the Constitution for over three decades. Guidance must acquire statutory force to drive change: regional planning must extend below the million-plus threshold as most of the growth is unfolding there. In such areas, peri-urban zoning cannot be optional.

Finance comes third because implementation requires monetary resources. India's municipal revenue is ~1% of GDP, compared with 7.4% in Brazil and 6% in South Africa, while property tax yields only 0.15% of GDP. Piecemeal, scheme-specific transfers leave cities unable to predict cash flow. India has developed a sophisticated set of blended financing instruments, but access is limited. Own-source revenue and formula-based transfers should become the fiscal pillars of urban governance, besides project preparation capacity.

Coordination comes next. The Inter-State Council dates from 1990 and the Central Council of Local Government from 1954. While NITI Aayog routinely brings States together, a National Urbanisation Council could better connect institutions and mechanisms.

The fifth transformation is about jurisdictional fit. Sectoral reforms are generally designed around administrative jurisdictions that do not match the geography of the problem. For instance, 65% of Delhi's PM 2.5 originates outside the city, so a municipal air quality plan cannot succeed, however well-funded. Reforms should be built on functional units – the airshed, the basin, the city region – with institutions empowered at that scale.

The final two transformations concern incentives and learning. Untied grants should reach municipalities directly through a published formula, paired with the knowledge and innovation support that cities need to meet benchmarks.

In most cases, the institution, criterion or instrument already exists. What is missing is regularity, enforceability, reach and accountability for non-performance. India cannot wait for every transitioning settlement to be formally recognised as urban before extending planning, services and infrastructure. A National Urbanisation Policy addresses this by shifting the unit of planning from administrative boundaries to functional areas.

(Sudeshna Chatterjee is Director of Research and Jaya Dhindaw is Executive Director of WRI India's Sustainable Cities Program.)

THE URBAN PICTURE

The Economic Survey 2026 stated that India is far more urban in functional terms than its definitions admit, **citing satellite data that placed the country at 63% urban in 2015**

Comparison of peri-urbanisation reported by the 2011 Census, Agglomeration Index, and DEGURBA

Measure of population in administratively and demographically different urban units

Total population of urban areas

CENSUS TOWN

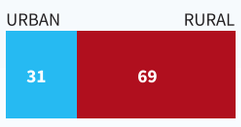
- ≥5,000 population
- ≥400 persons/km² population density
- 75% or more of the male working population is engaged in nonagricultural pursuits

OUTGROWTHS

- Villages or parts of villages contiguous with a Statutory Town possessing urban-like infrastructure and amenities

STATUTORY TOWN

- Classified by State governments based on criteria for urban areas in State legislation



Census 2011

Urban agglomeration, as defined by the Census, uses strict criteria of contiguity to the core of an ST and fails to include proximal urbanising areas separated by non-urban areas

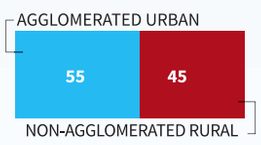
Measure of functional connectivity underpinning urban agglomerations

- Population density >150 persons/km²
- Minimum city population ≥50,000
- Within 60 minutes' travel time of a large city

1 The United Nations estimates that 44% of Indians live in urban areas today and projects the urban population to cross 720 million by 2050

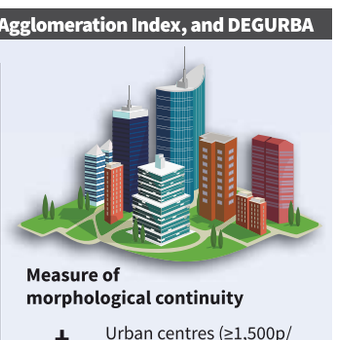
2 A National Urbanisation Policy could establish shared principles to bring coherence to existing institutions, enabling the Centre to channel funds and coordinate across tiers of government

3 India cannot wait for every settlement undergoing transition to be formally recognised as urban before extending planning, services and infrastructure



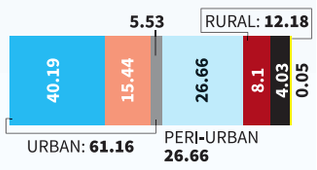
Agglomeration Index 2010

Gives the "Agglomerated Urban" category capturing people functionally connected to urban centres through commuting and market linkages



Measure of morphological continuity

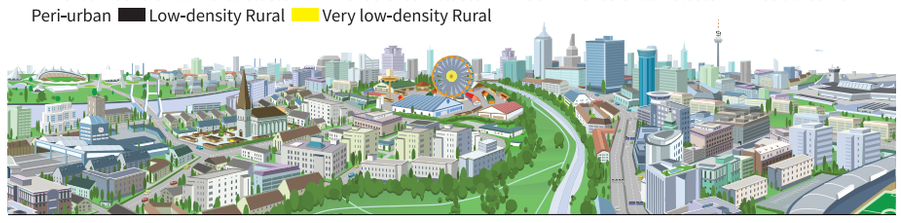
- Urban centres (≥1,500p/km²;≥50,000) City cores and main agglomerations
- Dense urban clusters (≥1,500p/km²;≥5,000) Large compact towns adjacent to or near big cities
- Semi-dense clusters (≥300p/km²;≥5,000) Medium to small towns serve as intermediate urban settlements
- Peri-urban (50–300p/km²) Residential or mixed-use sprawl, transitional between urban clusters and rural hinterlands
- Rural (<300p/km²) Dispersed settlements or agricultural hinterlands



DEGURBA (Level 2) 2025

Captures morphological gradations of settlement form and built-up density across the rural-urban continuum with intermediary classes for measuring peri-urban growth

Urban Centre · Rural Cluster · Dense Urban Cluster · Semi-Dense Urban Cluster · Suburban or Peri-urban · Low-density Rural · Very low-density Rural



Note: DEGURBA = Degree of Urbanisation. ST = Statutory Town. Source: Conceptualised by the WRI India Cities Research, Knowledge and Engagement (RKE) Team based on ORGI (2011c, 2011e); Schiavina et al. 2023; European Commission 2020

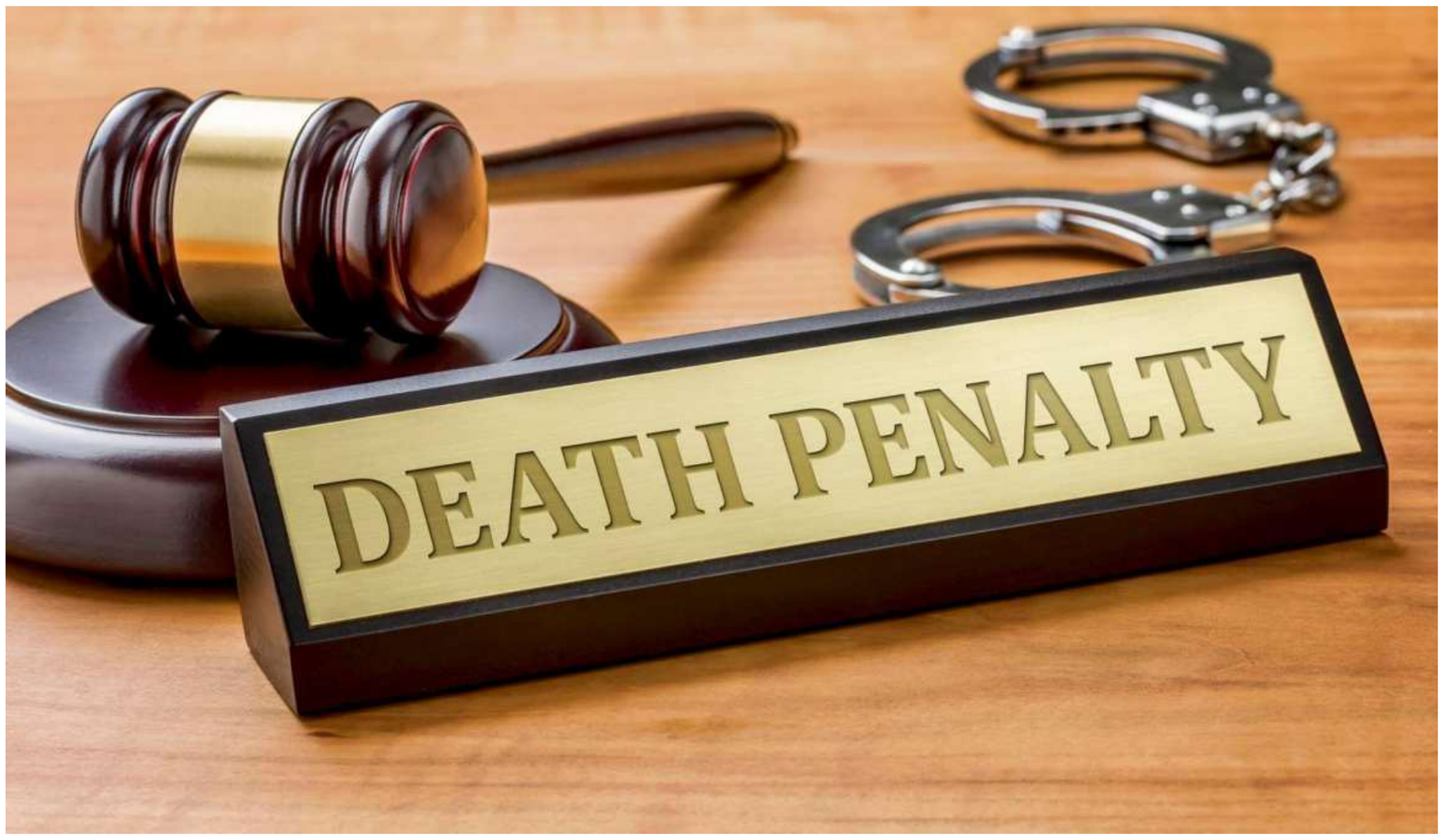
THE GIST

The 2027 Census will classify a settlement as urban if it is either notified as a statutory town or meets three census town criteria. This means the Census will measure urban India using a yardstick that the country's own economic and fiscal institutions have begun to move beyond

Around 94% of India's urban settlements are small towns, while about 60% of its urban population lives in Class I cities. The classification lumps together megacities with non-metropolitan cities, obscuring their radically different needs and capacities

Grounded in subsidiarity, a National Urbanisation Policy could establish shared principles to build coherence across existing institutions

LETTER & SPIRIT



The Day Against the Death Penalty offered a fitting moment to look back at how the top court's safeguards, laid down when it upheld capital punishment, have fared over the past four decades. GETTY IMAGES

How the Supreme Court shaped due process in death penalty cases

In *Bachan Singh*, the apex court upheld the death penalty but laid down guidelines for judicial discretion; in *Manoj v. State of Madhya Pradesh*, it prescribed 'practical guidelines', including the submission of mental health evaluations and custody conduct reports of the accused

L. Nageswara Rao

The Day Against the Death Penalty, observed on October 10, offered a fitting moment to look back on how the Supreme Court's 1980 safeguards, laid down when it upheld capital punishment, have fared over the past four decades.

In *Bachan Singh v. State of Punjab* (1980), the Constitution Bench upheld the death penalty, but imposed specific conditions in the shape of guidelines for the exercise of judicial discretion. Following the legislative scheme of Section 354(3) of the CrPC, now Section 393(3) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023, life imprisonment was to be the norm, and death sentence could be imposed only for "special reasons". Courts were to weigh the circumstances of the crime alongside those of the accused, and impose death only where life imprisonment was "unquestionably foreclosed".

The exceptionality principle

This idea of exceptionality of the death sentence in *Bachan Singh* is not quantitative regarding an offence's rarity but rests on "a real and abiding concern for the dignity of human life". The methodology adopted by the Court to ensure that the promise of human dignity is fulfilled is individualised sentencing. It is the idea that the death penalty, while being proportionate, must be imposed after properly considering the individual circumstances of the accused. This allows courts to assess how social, structural and psychological factors shape moral blameworthiness, and whether reformation is truly foreclosed. And it is for the state to prove, by evidence, that the probability of reformation does not exist.

Regrettably, this dignity-oriented jurisprudence was soon made precarious. *Machhi Singh v. State of Punjab* (1983), as the Court later acknowledged in *Sangeet v. State of Haryana* (2013), shifted the inquiry towards the crime, in effect asking whether there were reasons to impose life imprisonment rather than special reasons to impose death. In December 1995, a two-judge Bench went further. *Ravji v. State of Rajasthan* held that the nature and gravity of the offence, not the circumstances of the criminal, was what mattered in deciding punishment. Ravji was hanged in May 1996; Surja Ram, in April 1997. Two men were sent to the gallows on a principle the Supreme Court would later declare contrary to binding law.

A decade later, in *Santosh Kumar Bariyar v. State of Maharashtra* (2009), the Court held that *Ravji* had been decided in ignorance of *Bachan Singh*, and noted that it had been followed in at least six other cases in which the death sentence was awarded. *Bariyar* also clarified that life imprisonment is "unquestionably foreclosed" only when the sentencing aim of reformation is unachievable. In 2012, 14 retired judges called the two executions "the gravest known miscarriage of justice" in independent India.

A focus on reformation

Since then, including in the 262nd Law Commission Report in 2015, reformation has been championed as an important goal in death penalty cases. Yet sentencing, particularly in trial courts, looked much the same. A nationwide study of 306 death sentences imposed between 2018 and 2020 found that 36.1% were pronounced on the same day as conviction, and another 18.4% on the following day. In most cases, the defence neither argued nor presented evidence on mitigation.

It is against this record of crime-centric practice that the Supreme Court has, in recent years, turned to the fairness of the sentencing procedure itself. In *Manoj v. State of Madhya Pradesh* (2022), it prescribed 'practical guidelines' to operationalise the collection of information on the accused, requiring the state to produce mental health evaluations, reports on conduct in custody, and a probation officer's report. In a *suo motu* Writ Petition, since referred to a Constitution Bench, the court insisted that the defence must have a real and meaningful opportunity to present material on sentence. And in *Vasanta Sampat Dupare v. Union of India* (2025), it held that a sentencing hearing which is compliant to *Manoj* flows from Articles 14 and 21. A death sentence imposed without one is unconstitutional and can be reopened even after it has attained finality.

More recently, in *Waris v. State of Madhya Pradesh* (September 2026), the Court upheld a conviction for the rape and murder of a child but commuted the death sentence, because the State had led no evidence to exclude the possibility of reformation. The gravity of the crime, however extreme, could not by itself establish that life imprisonment was unquestionably foreclosed.

The promise, however, remains unfulfilled where it matters most. In 2025, trial courts sentenced 128 people to death. In 95.18% of the cases where compliance could be assessed, the procedure prescribed in *Manoj* was not followed.

A troubling record

However, the greater worry lies not with the question of sentence but elsewhere. Over the past decade, nearly a third of the death sentences decided by the High Courts and the Supreme Court have ended in acquittals. In 2025 alone, the Supreme Court acquitted the accused in 10 of the 19 death penalty cases it decided, repeatedly noting seriously flawed investigations and prosecutions. In *Dupare*, it acknowledged that investigations often rest on "confessions extracted in opacity" and forensic material "of doubtful rigour". A system so prone to error cannot safely decide an irreversible punishment on the crime alone. *Bachan Singh* left us a warning: "Judges should never be bloodthirsty."

The anguish that brutal crimes provoke is real, and no one is insulated from it. But *Ravji* stands as a stark reminder of what follows when that anguish overwhelms legal reasoning. The safeguards developed from *Bachan Singh* to *Dupare* are not obstacles to justice; they are the conditions on which the constitutionality of the death penalty rests. Fidelity to that process is not mercy. It is what the Constitution mandates.

(The author is a former judge of the Supreme Court of India. Views expressed are personal.)

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

A quiz on UNESCO on the 80th anniversary of the international organisation's Constitution coming into force

V.V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1
Expand the acronym UNESCO.

QUESTION 2
UNESCO has a distinctive logo based on what type of edifice? And how many members does it have?

QUESTION 3
In 1960, UNESCO launched the 'Nubian Campaign' for what specific purpose?

QUESTION 4
The resolution to establish one of the world's largest and most respected centres for scientific research was adopted in 1954. Name the establishment located in Europe.

QUESTION 5
Thanks to UNESCO making a request in the 1960s, scholars have completed nine volumes of which continent's history from their own perspective?

QUESTION 6
Name the organisation's magazine that has brought local perspectives on global issues since 1948.



Visual question: This image shows Pope Leo XIV watering an olive tree alongside UNESCO Director-General Khaled El-Enany at the UNESCO HQ. Where is it located? AP

Questions and answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. Sputnik 2 was launched on this date. **Ans: November 3, 1957**
2. The country which launched Sputnik 2, and its significance in the history of space exploration. **Ans: The Soviet Union. It was the second artificial satellite to orbit Earth and the first to carry an animal into orbit**
3. Sputnik 2 developed in such a short period after Sputnik 1 due to this. **Ans: Soviet leader Nikita Khrushchev wanted another satellite launched in time for the 40th anniversary of the Bolshevik Revolution in early November 1957. Engineers had only about three weeks to prepare it.**
4. This rocket was used to launch Sputnik 2. **Ans: The modified R-7 rocket, designated 8K71PS**
5. The dogs were trained to adapt to the conditions inside Sputnik 2 in this manner. **Ans: They were progressively confined to smaller cages for 15 to 20 days at a time. They were also placed in centrifuges simulating rocket acceleration and machines reproducing spacecraft noise**
Visual: The cause of Laika's death. **Ans: Around 5-7 hours after launch. In 2002, Russian scientist Dmitry Malashenkov reported that Laika had died from overheating inside the spacecraft.**
Early birds: KN Viswanathan| Prem Nath Tiwari| Haridas Pal| Aryan Wari| Dodo Jayaditya



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

"What is are you doing here? I thought you and your sister were leaving for Mumbai today."

"We had to cancel our tickets. There is a crisis in Mumbai. My uncle rang up last night saying that he had lost his job."

"Good grief! Your uncle got his walking papers! That's too bad."

"I didn't say anything about my uncle getting his walking papers. All I said was that he had lost his job."

"That's what the expression 'get your walking papers' means. When your boss gives you your walking papers, he/she is asking you to leave."

"In other words, he/she is giving you the sack."

"That's right. The situation is really bad these days."

"After Anu got her walking papers, she started her own company. I understand she is doing really well."

"As soon as she took over, Prema gave the manager his walking papers. Later, without telling anyone, she hired her own son to do the job."

"That sounds like Prema. A very practical person. Have you heard the latest about Sujatha's father?"

"Has the poor man been given his walking papers too?"

"No, no. Nothing like that. He has bought a new house."

"Oh, that! Yes, Ramesh told me. He has been living rather high off the hog lately."

"Living high off the hog? I've never heard that expression before!"

"Well, when you say that someone has been 'living high off the hog' what it means is that the individual is leading a very comfortable life. He has a lot of money and is in a position to eat all the good things."

"I see."

"It is also possible to say 'live high on the hog'. Shekar has been living high on the hog ever since he got his promotion."

"I see."

"My next door neighbour lost his job several months ago. How he still manages to live high on the hog is beyond me."

"Maybe he has a lot of money saved up. By the way, what is the connection between a 'hog' and living comfortably?"

"Good question. Do you know what a hog is?"

"Of course, I do. It's a pig."

"Yes, that's right. I understand that the best cuts of meat in a hog are located high up on the hog's side. These choice cuts of meat are pretty expensive."

"And if you are able to buy these choice cuts of meat every day, you must have a lot of money. You must be fairly well to do."

"Exactly."

"So, did you go to your friend's house to watch the opening match of the World Cup?"

"Unfortunately, I did. I should have just watched the game at home."

"Why do you say that?"

"Well, he had invited a whole bunch of people whom I didn't know. And these guys were more interested in liquoring up than in anything."

"Liquoring up? Does it mean to drink in excess?"

"Exactly."

"In our movies, the hero always liquors up whenever he loses the girl."

"That's true. Why he just doesn't look for another girl is beyond me."

"True."

Published in The Hindu on June 6, 2002

Word of the day

Entourage:
the group following and attending to some important person

Synonyms: cortege, retinue, suite

Usage: *The actor was surrounded by a large entourage of assistants and security personnel.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/entourage

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ˈɒn.tʊ.rɑːʒ/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

INBRIEF



PM Surya Ghar will add 1 lakh rooftop solar every 5 days soon

The PM Surya Ghar Yojana is currently adding one lakh rooftop solar installations every six days, with the government expecting to accelerate the pace to the same number in four to five days within the next two to three weeks, Union Minister for New and Renewable Energy Pralhad Joshi said. "Today every six days we are completing 1 lakh solar rooftop installations, and I am hopeful that in another 2-3 weeks to come, it would be [done in] 4-5 days. So, that is the speed and the scale," Mr. Joshi told *The Hindu* during a media interaction on the sidelines of the Bharat Renewable Energy Summit & Expo 2026. He expressed confidence that the scheme would achieve its target of installing one crore rooftop solar systems by March 31, 2027.

NMDC's iron ore output rises 18%, sales dip on rain impact

State-owned NMDC reported October iron ore production rose 18% year-on-year (YoY) to 5.04 million tonnes, while sales declined more than 11% to 3.44 MT. For the seven months ended October, production stood at 32.32 MT (26.47 MT) and sales 25.67 MT (26.12 MT). The company said dispatches were temporarily impacted by disruptions to the Kottavalasa-Kirandul (KK) railway line after sections of the route were washed away due to heavy monsoon rains in September and October. The disruption affected evacuation from NMDC's Bailadila mines in Chhattisgarh for nearly a month. With rail connectivity restored and supplies resumed, it expects the dispatches and sales to improve in the coming months, NMDC said. "The 18% growth in iron ore production in October reflects the sustained efforts of the teams. With the rail connectivity restored and supplies resumed, we expect dispatches and sales to improve in the coming months," CMD Amitava Mukherjee said.

Tata-Iveco €3.8-bn deal turns global ambition into reality

The road ahead is to move forward with a shared ambition of Tata Motors and Iveco Group NV to create a stronger, more innovative and more resilient commercial mobility enterprise

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI



Tata Motors Chairman N. Chandrasekaran with MD & CEO Girish Wagh and Olof Persson, CEO, Iveco Group. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Tata Motors will leverage its newly acquired global scale to expand its commercial vehicle (CV) business across markets, with Iveco products set to enter India and Tata-branded vehicles to be introduced in markets where the Italian truck and bus maker has a strong presence.

The road ahead will focus on cross-market opportunities, technology sharing and accelerated innovation as the two companies embark on a joint growth strategy following the completion of the €3.8-billion acquisition of Iveco Group NV.

"The ambition to become a global company has become reality today," Tata Sons Chairman N. Chandrasekaran said at a press conference in Turin, Italy, marking the completion of the transaction.

Mr. Chandrasekaran, who is also the Chairman of Tata Motors, has taken over as the Chairman of Iveco Group.

Describing the completion of the transaction in 15 months as a significant achievement, he said the complementary product portfolios and geographic strengths of the two companies had created a "truly global enterprise".

The combined entity, ranked fourth globally among commercial vehicle manufacturers, has presence in over 130 countries across Europe, India, South America, Asia, West Asia and Africa. It is expected to generate revenues exceeding €21 billion (around ₹2.28 lakh crore).

Tata Motors MD and CEO Girish Wagh said the complementary portfolios, capabilities and geographic strengths offered a strong foundation for growth while ensuring continuity for customers, dealers and partners.

Iveco CEO Olof Persson said the partnership brought together strong brands, industrial heritage and capabilities, backed by a shared long-term commitment to sustainable transport.

Iveco will retain its headquarters in Turin.

Tata Motors will support Iveco's existing strategy and investment plans while exploring opportunities to leverage synergies.

SBI Q2 net profit rises 14.3% to ₹23,038 crore; eyes NIM above 3%

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI


C.S. Setty

State Bank of India (SBI) reported a 14.28% year-on-year (YoY) increase in net profit to ₹23,038 crore for the quarter ended September 30, 2026, aided by lower loan-loss provisions and improved asset quality.

Net interest income (NII) rose 14.69% to ₹49,143 crore, while net interest margin (NIM) improved three basis points to 3.11% from 3.08% a year ago.

Loan-loss provisions declined 33.23% YoY to ₹2,759 crore. Gross non-performing assets (GNPA) fell 4.87% to ₹72,529 crore.

The GNPA ratio improved 34 basis points to 1.39%. Net NPA, however, edged up 0.47% to ₹18,546 crore, although the NNPA ratio declined six basis points to 0.36%.

Gross advances grew 17.84% YoY to ₹52.08 lakh crore. Domestic corporate advances increased 16.12% to ₹14.39 lakh crore and domestic retail personal loans by 14.54% to ₹18.25 lakh crore. Home loans accounted for ₹9.86 lakh crore, a 11.94% growth.

Deposits grew 12.27% to ₹62.78 lakh crore.

Addressing a press conference, SBI Chairman C.S. Setty said, "The Indian economy continues to offer strong growth opportunities and SBI is well positioned to participate in this journey. Our performance in this quarter reflects the strength and resilience of the franchise."

Air India eyes more widebodies, cost cuts

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

Air India is seeking to expand its widebody fleet while cutting costs and working toward profitability "as soon as possible," the airline's CEO Tewolde Gebremariam said.

"We want to increase our widebody order. Our network and strategy demand more widebodies," he said at the Aviation India Summit 2026. He did not specify how many additional widebodies Air India was seeking. Alongside its long-term growth plans, the airline is focused on cutting costs and achieving profitability in the near term. "Efficiency, efficiency, efficiency," he said of the approach to costs.

Shift to Navi Mumbai or stop flying to Mumbai: Adani Airports CEO tells international airlines

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

Adani Airport Holdings Ltd. (AAHL) CEO Arun Bansal on Tuesday said international airlines unwilling to shift their operations to the upcoming Navi Mumbai International Airport (NMIA) could stop flying to Mumbai.

The disagreement comes as Adani-owned Mumbai International Airport Ltd. (MIAL) prepares to undertake redevelopment work at Terminal 1, necessitating the relocation of a portion of flight operations currently handled at Terminal 2 to Navi Mumbai. The proposed shift has faced resistance from international airlines, which have raised concerns over the lack of adequate consultation, the impact on passengers and the operational implications of splitting their Mumbai operations between two airports. Mr. Bansal said airlines had been given notice to vacate the existing facilities from April, adding that where they chose to operate subsequently was their decision.

"I gave an example... my landlord says vacate the house. He can tell me to vacate the house, after that what I do is my choice. Similarly, we are telling airlines, from April you have to vacate [the slots at Mumbai airport], after that where you go is your choice," he told reporters on the sidelines of the Aviation India Summit 2026.

Rice exporters warn on west Asia cargoes

M. Soundariya Preetha
COIMBATORE


Current rice exports to west Asia are 10% of pre-war levels.

Following reports of attacks on vessels in the Strait of Hormuz, the Indian Rice Exporters Federation (IREF) issued an advisory to its members to exercise 'maximum caution' while finalising contracts with new vessels and charter parties and committing delivery schedules to the buyers.

The IREF said current rice exports from India to west Asian countries were about 70-80 tonne a month or 10% of the shipments before the Iran war.

"Any attack on the vessels with Indian cargo will affect trade and getting ships will become difficult," said Prem Garg, president of the Federation.

The Strait of Hormuz is an 'extremely high-risk maritime passage.' Some commercial vessel movements continue and vessels entering or leaving the Persian Gulf face security risks. War-risk insurance premiums, freight rates, vessel availability, and voyage schedules may be adversely affected, it said.

Stir over roof


Follow-up action: Employees remove tents and other debris after police evicted protesters and dismantled a sprawling camp which spearheaded protests over Spain's housing crisis in the emblematic Puerta del Sol square in central Madrid on Tuesday. AFP

'4-layer cover for new car, bike from Dec. 15'

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD

Cover will comprise mandatory, optional components with additional premium for optional cover

Insurance regulator IRDAI set a December 15 deadline for all general insurers to offer owners of new private cars and two-wheelers a four-layer motor policy covering third-party liability, legal liability to occupants, personal accident and own damage.

The cover will comprise both mandatory and optional components with the optional covers available on payment of an additional premium. Third party cover, as is currently the case, and the personal accident cover for the owner will be mandatory.

The optional components will be cover for legal liability towards occupants or pillion riders, including employees of the insured; personal accident cover for occupants or pillion riders, including any driver other than the owner-driver; and the own damage cover.

In a circular to general insurers, which follows the Supreme Court directions in a case, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) said the policy structure, uniform wordings along with the option form will come into force from December 15.

Anthropic warns AI could outpace human control in successor models

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI



New abilities: Anthropic logo at Moscone Center at Dreamforce 2026 technology summit in San Francisco, California. REUTERS

Artificial intelligence (AI) could soon begin accelerating the development of increasingly powerful AI systems at a pace that outstrips the ability of firms to put adequate safety safeguards in place, Anthropic has warned.

In a statement filed with the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC), the firm said internal estimates point to the imminent possibility of "dramatically-accelerated progress attributable to AI".

The warning relates to recursive self-improvement (RSI), a process in which AI systems help design and develop more capable successors. Anthropic said its Claude models already contribute to several stages of developing subsequent generations, including research experiments and coding.

Describing it as "closing the loop," the firm said over 90% of its contributions to codebase in September were written by Claude.

Claude's performance on Anthropic's internal benchmarks also improved sharply. Its success rate in challenging open-ended engineering problems touched about 90% in September, up almost 50 percentage points in nine months.

With Claude Code increasingly capable of writing and executing code and handling complex, multi-step assignments autonomously, engineers are shifting from writing code to directing and reviewing AI-generated work. However, Anthropic clarified its assessment of dramatically-hastened progress concerns future models. None of the existing models has been designated as having crossed that threshold.

NSE September quarter profit rises 23%, but sequential earnings dip 17%

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI



On the upswing: For the first half of FY27, NSE's consolidated total income rose 9% YoY to ₹9,807 crore. REUTERS

The National Stock Exchange (NSE) reported a 23% year-on-year (YoY) rise in consolidated net profit to ₹2,577 crore for the quarter ended September. However, profit declined 17.4% sequentially, in its first quarterly results since its market debut.

For the first half of FY27, consolidated total income rose 9% YoY to ₹9,807 crore. Sequentially, performance remained under pressure, with earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation (EBITDA) falling 13.3% to ₹3,079 crore from ₹3,551 crore in the April-June quarter. EBITDA margin also narrowed to 75.7% from 77.9%.

The bottomline was supported by higher trading activity. Average daily traded volume (ADTV) in the cash market rose 24% YoY to ₹1,18,377 crore in Q2FY27. The equity options segment recorded an ADTV of ₹1,24,574 crore.

Total income for the quarter increased to ₹4,554 crore from ₹4,160 crore a year ago, but declined 13% sequentially. Total expenses fell 51% YoY to ₹1,161 crore.

NSE also expanded its product portfolio, securing regulatory approvals and introducing derivatives on the Nifty India FPI 150 Index and Corporate Bond Index Futures.

NSE Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer Ashishkumar Chauhan said, "The listing milestone marked an important phase in our evolution, reflecting our continued commitment to the highest standards of governance, transparency and value creation; as we continue to drive innovation and deepen India's capital market ecosystem."

Big AI bets could break already fragile global markets



AI surge: So far, the multitrillion-dollar spending splurge on AI has boosted global stock markets.

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
LONDON

Financial markets are struggling under the weight of wars, soaring sovereign debt and trade tensions, with signs of trouble showing across the world –from the selloff in Japanese and French bonds to plunging emerging-market currencies. Now, the one trade that helped investors remain optimistic is starting to show cracks as well.

So far, the multitrillion-dollar spending splurge on artificial intelligence, aided by Washington's light-touch approach to business, has propelled stock markets to record highs and raised expectations for the global economy to grow a healthy 3% this year.

Investors turn nervous

But investors are getting nervous about market resiliency. U.S. President Donald Trump's erratic trade policies and the Iran war's energy shock have revived inflation worldwide, putting pressure on central banks to raise interest rates. That, along with AI's capital-investment surge and highly indebted governments, is driving up borrowing costs to multi-decade highs.

With U.S. midterm elections, volatile geopolitics and central bank policy promising further uncertainty in the final stretch of the year, some investors and economists say risks to the global economy are mounting.

"Rising rates always seem to sniff out and expose the most vulnerable time after time," said Jim O'Neill, former Goldman Sachs chief economist and former British Treasury minister. Countries and businesses too exposed suffer the most." He said if inflation did not ease, the risks stemming from the vast amount of debt-financed investment flowing into the AI sector would grow. The U.S. central bank has missed its inflation target for more than half a decade; euro-area inflation at 3.8% is also above its 2% target.

"In some ways, it's surprising to me there haven't been more bumps in the AI trade already," O'Neill said.

Things breaking?

Market jitters showed up abruptly in October, when investors rushed out of AI stocks and into safe-haven bonds. More than $2 trillion in market value was wiped from the tech-heavy Nasdaq 100 last month, as Big Tech's earnings intensified investor scrutiny of whether the cash invested can generate returns quickly enough. The cost of insuring bonds of some tech companies surged, some proposed data centre projects struggled to raise money, and technology stocks from South Korea and China to the U.S. tumbled.

Investors flocked to bonds. Yields fell from multi-decade highs, with the benchmark 10-year Treasury, which guides borrowing costs globally, falling almost 20 basis points on October 22, its biggest daily fall since early 2023.

The 10-year yield is still hovering around 5%, a threshold some investors see as a risk to broader financial stability. Strains were already showing up in parts of the world where the AI buildout has been less of a driving force.

In France, bond yields soared to levels last seen during the 2012 euro zone debt crisis, leaving the government with little room to address demands from protesters who have taken to the streets in the worst civil unrest in years. In Japan, whose economy is dependent on energy imports, bond yields recently hit 30-year peaks. Authorities are under pressure to raise rates faster, undermining Tokyo's policy goals that called for additional spending and possibly upending global capital flows.

"There are some signs of things breaking," said Mike Riddell, a lead portfolio manager at Fidelity International, which manages over $1 trillion worth of assets, pointing to troubles in France and Australia, where the housing market is in the throes of the worst downturn in decades.

German bonds, also considered a safe haven, have become more attractive, Riddell added.

U.S. economist Paul Krugman said persistently elevated inflation that prompts significant rate increases, rising government bond yields and cracks in the AI boom are major concerns for the U.S. economy. "There are troubling aspects of the current economy that could potentially be harbingers of the crisis to come," Krugman wrote in a column on online newsletter platform Substack. White House spokesperson Matthew Middleton said the Trump administration is committed to maintaining U.S. leadership in AI, fueling revenue growth and driving productivity.

Digital pathogen: why cyber hygiene is no longer considered as an option

In cyberspace, neglecting basic hygiene can be as deadly as ignoring an epidemic, the opportunity cost of which is not merely in money lost, but disrupted businesses, compromised identities, regulatory liabilities and above all eroded public trust; average cost of a data breach in India is ₹25.5 cr.

EXPLAINER

Santosh V. Perumal

Even as the stains of Covid-19 has yet to recede entirely in the physical world, the pathogen in the digital age – poor cyber hygiene – has found foothold across sectors that it has not even spared the authenticating agency.

The term cyber hygiene, the first line of defence against cybercrime, increasingly got into the vocabulary after financial institutions and public bodies suffered serious security scares.

In cyberspace, neglecting basic hygiene can be as deadly as ignoring an epidemic, the opportunity cost of which is not merely in money lost, but disrupted businesses, compromised identities, regulatory liabilities and above all eroded public trust.

Digital trust, like public health, depends upon a simple principle: prevention is invariably cheaper than the cure. It was Internet pioneer Vinton Cerf, who coined the term cyber hygiene in 2000, when he used it in his testimony before the U.S. Congress' Joint Economic Committee.

"Good cyber hygiene is essential for staying safe in today's digital world. Simple and responsible online practices can go a long way in protecting your personal and financial information," says a mail from a nationalised bank to a customer. Global average cost of a data breach slid to $4.44 million, down 9% year-on-year (YoY) while it rose in India, an IBM 2025 report said.



Equally vulnerable: Cyber risks do not discriminate sectors. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

The IBM's 2026, report, released in August, puts average cost of a data breach in India at ₹25.5 crore, up 15.9% YoY. The breach compromised 39,500 records against 38,200 in the previous year. The financial services sector faced an even higher average cost of ₹40.9 crore/breach.

The IBM report measures the average total organisational cost of a breach, including detection, investigation, recovery, business disruption and reputational damage.

> The term cyber hygiene, the first line of defence against cybercrime, increasingly got into the vocabulary after financial institutions and public bodies suffered serious security scares

Banking vulnerable

The data assumes importance especially in the country's systemically important banking sector, as compromised information can lead to identity theft, financial fraud and further attacks on customers.

Against this backdrop, reported or suspected data exposures involving State Bank of India and HDFC Bank highlight India's rising and sophisticated cybersecurity challenge.

Cyber risks do not discriminate sectors as seen from reported issues involving in the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) and digital-certification company eMudhra.

Banks hold financial and identity data, sovereign bodies manage sensitive public records and certification bodies underpin digital trust. Hence, vulnerability in any of these could lead to far-reaching consequences. Security must therefore extend across the entire technology supply chain.

In a reply to Parliament, the Union Home Ministry reported increasing financial cyber-fraud losses from ₹551 crore in 2021 to ₹2,290 crore in 2022, ₹7,465 crore in 2023, ₹22,848 crore in 2024 and marginally dipping to ₹22,495 crore in 2025.

As per Reserve Bank of India (RBI) data, in FY2023-24, banks reported 36,075 fraud cases involving ₹13,930 crore. Of these, 29,082 cases related to cards or internet banking, which accounted for ₹1,457 crore.

Actual losses

However, the central bank data comes with a caveat that the amount involved in reported frauds is not equivalent to actual loss incurred. Recoveries may reduce the loss and frauds reported in one financial year may have occurred years earlier.

Notable international historical cases such as Equifax (2017) and Capital One (2019) illustrate the potential financial consequences in terms of settlements and judicial costs.

Even as India's rapid digital transformation has widened and deepened the reach of the banking industry, it has exposed the sector more to cyber risks.

The integrated financial ecosystem – comprising UPI, mobile banking, internet banking and digital lending – complicated the complex architecture that the vulnerabilities at one point can have dire consequences far beyond it.

The National Payments Corporation of India data suggest that UPI processed around 186 billion transactions during 2024-25, illustrating the scale of digital payments infrastructure.

Indispensable practice

This growth makes cyber hygiene – the routine practices to keep digital systems, devices and data secure – indispensable for all stakeholders alike – banks, customers, technology vendors, payment intermediaries and regulators.

In view of this, campaigns have already been strengthened on the need for effective cyber hygiene action at various levels.

Individual level cyber hygiene calls for employing unique, strong passwords/password managers, enabling multifactor authentication, installing software updates and avoid clicking suspicious links.

Corporate level measures suggest embedding security into operations with timely patching, encryption, secure software, phishing simulations, independent penetration testing and regular incident-response exercises.

And finally...

Just as the pace of transactions is important, the integrity of systems and institutions behind it is integral to the credibility of digital finance.

Elon Musk's pay package under a SpaceX-Tesla merger: voting control, but no $1 trillion payday

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters

Elon Musk's recent supersized pay packages at SpaceX and Tesla were centered on some eye-popping goals: creating a 1 million-person human colony on Mars, putting a million robotaxis on the road and selling a million humanoid robots.

A merger combining Musk's trillion-dollar rocket and electric vehicle firms would mean he might not ever need to meet those lofty targets to achieve his ultimate goal: control over his corporate empire.

Musk said on a SpaceX earnings call last month that both companies' boards had formed special committees to discuss a potential merger. A deal could give him the voting control at Tesla that he has said he wants, without his having to hit any of the milestones in his pay plan.

As for Musk's compensation, a merger initially would likely award him only a sliver of the $1 trillion in stock from last year's widely discussed Tesla pay package, according to a *Reuters* review of the plan and six executive-compensation experts. SpaceX's board could also restructure his compensation plan after a potential Tesla deal, the experts said.

An examination of Musk's compensation packages at both companies shows that the structure of SpaceX's plan, which gives Musk voting power upfront before earning the stock, helps provide a shortcut to gaining control of Tesla.



Inside Musk's mind: A silhouette of Elon Musk and the SpaceX logo are seen in this illustration. REUTERS

That makes the provocative, futuristic Mars and humanoid robot goals more of an afterthought, according to the experts who reviewed the plans for *Reuters*.

"It's irrelevant," said Charles Elson, founding director of the Weinberg Center for Corporate Governance at the University of Delaware. "This package is a distraction from the real story, which is complete control."

'Ambitious stuff'

The $1 trillion Tesla compensation plan that shareholders approved for Musk last year required him to hit a series of market-capitalisation and operational milestones in order to collect more stock and amass more voting control.

Leading up to SpaceX's IPO this summer, the company's board granted Musk stock awards tied to boosting the company's market cap, getting a million people to Mars and building massive spaced ata centres. Unless Musk achieved the Mars and data-centre goals, he could not pocket the shares, according to the agreements.

Importantly, though, Musk immediately got all the voting power associated with those shares, just not the economic rights. That got him to 85% control over SpaceX without needing to hit any goals. Musk already had significant ownership in SpaceX before being awarded those additional voting rights. Matthew Bloomfield, an associate professor of accounting at the University of Pennsylvania's Wharton School, said he viewed the SpaceX plan, crafted so close to the IPO, as "just a marketing document."

"You put a bunch of ambitious stuff in there and a lot of people say, 'Look at this big bet Elon Musk is putting on himself,'" he said. In reality, the plan is mostly about "getting a bunch of people hyped," he said. Musk, Tesla and SpaceX did not respond to requests for comment.

The story at Tesla is the opposite. A flashy compensation package that awarded Musk up to $1 trillion in Tesla stock last year was designed to give him more control over the firm but only as he meets operational and market-cap goals over time.

Even Musk were to hit all of the goals, including increasing the company's market cap nearly eightfold, he would have only about 29% of the voting power at Tesla, according to documents the board presented last year.

As Tesla's board was shopping the plan to investors last year, Musk himself said that gaining more control over Tesla was the goal, highlighting the risks of building AI-powered robots.

"My fundamental concern with regard to how much voting control I have in Tesla is: If I go ahead and build this enormous robot army, can I just be ousted at some point in the future?" he said on an October 2025 Tesla earnings call.

Shortcut to control

A merger offers a far quicker path to getting that control. Barclays analysts estimated in a recent investor note that at the current size of each company, if SpaceX were to acquire Tesla, then Musk would own about 37% of the new conglomerate but have 56% of the voting power. That is because many of his SpaceX shares are in a special class that carries 10 times the voting rights of the typical shareholder.

There is no such class of shares at Tesla. Musk's SpaceX and Tesla compensation plans contemplate what would happen in the event of a merger.

For Tesla, the language in the agreement is straightforward. In a "change in control" event such as an acquisition by SpaceX, Musk could receive stock payouts for meeting market-cap goals without the added requirement of an operational goal like having 1 million robotaxis in operation.

The market cap would be calculated based on the stock price immediately before the merger or the value that Tesla shareholders receive from the transaction, whichever is greater. Tesla's current market capitalisation is about $1.6 trillion. That would need to grow to $2 trillion in connection with the merger for Musk to receive any stock awards under the plan. (Meeting that goal would issue him $20 billion in Tesla shares at a $2 trillion valuation, though it would be worth less because the plan only compensates Musk for stock growth after his pay plan was announced, in September 2025.)

Musk could receive more if the market capitalisation grew to $2.5 trillion, $3 trillion or higher after a deal, though the six compensation experts said such a premium would be unlikely.

Board revision of plan

The SpaceX compensation plan is less specific about what happens in the event of a merger, and compensation experts said the board could significantly adjust Musk's plan after a transaction.

Musk's plan at SpaceX is divided into two parts: a series of market-cap goals, paired with a goal of setting up a colony on Mars with a million people; and another set of market-cap goals, alongside a target of building space data centers capable of "delivering 100 terawatts of compute per year." Musk said on X earlier this year that 100 terawatts per year would be "200 times the current electricity output of Earth," and would require manufacturing satellites on the moon that would be "shot into deep space."

Musk is already able to vote all the shares awarded to him in the SpaceX plan, but he cannot get any value out of them unless he achieves those goals.

So even if he more than triples the value of SpaceX, and gets 5,00,000 people to Mars, he would not earn any of the shares, according to the plan. The shares in Musk's plan would be worth $719 billion at the highest market cap target, based on SpaceX's current shares outstanding, research firm Equilar said.

Kevin Murphy, a finance professor at USC's Marshall School of Business and an expert witness for Tesla in defending Musk's 2018 pay package, said he thinks the board and Musk are likely to keep all the plans in place. They could simply increase the market-cap and earnings goals, and adjust the share awards, to account for the larger combined company, he said. SpaceX did something similar earlier this year when it acquired xAI and assumed Musk's compensation plan from that firm.

Though Musk's SpaceX plan has incredibly difficult goals, four of the compensation experts said the board could likely amend the plan however it wants.

With Musk already owning nearly half of SpaceX, whether he ultimately gets a million people to Mars and pockets the additional stock from his compensation plan is less important than the control, the compensation experts said.

Murphy acknowledged goals like the Mars colony are "pretty pie-in-the-sky," but said Musk may not want an easy payday upfront. "He's an all-or-nothing kind of guy. He doesn't want a couple cookies. He wants the whole bag."

RIYADH

Saudi forces 'intercept' drone as Houthis say 17 killed in two days



AFP

The Saudi-led coalition fighting Yemen's Houthis said on Tuesday it had intercepted a drone in the region of Mecca, as the Houthis reported 17 people killed in Yemen over two days. Separately, Houthi military spokesperson Yahya Saree denied that they had carried out any attacks on Saudi territory on Tuesday. AFP

PESHAWAR

Two police officers guarding polio team killed in attack in Pakistan

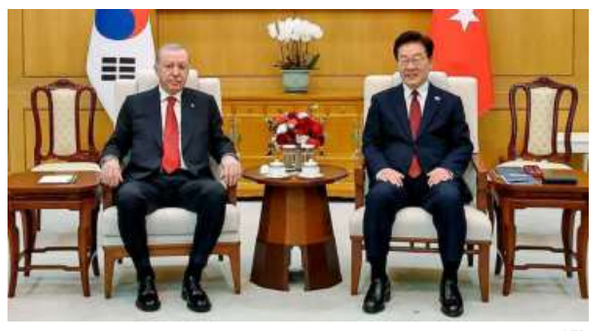


AP

Two police personnel guarding an anti-polio vaccination team were killed, while another sustained injuries in an attack by unidentified gunmen in northwest Pakistan on Tuesday, an official said. No one has claimed responsibility for the attack. However, the banned TTP has previously targeted polio vaccination teams. PTI

SEOUL

South Korea, Turkiye to deepen nuclear energy, defence relations



AFP

South Korea and Turkiye agreed to deepen cooperation in nuclear energy and defence, during a summit between their leaders on Tuesday in Seoul. Turkiye's visiting President Recep Tayyip Erdogan told a joint news conference that the documents signed on nuclear energy "will take the cooperation even further". AFP

KATHMANDU

Indian killed as helicopters collide near Everest Base Camp in Nepal



PTI

A 47-year-old Indian national, Vasanth Kumar Balaramaramadu, was killed and another passenger injured when two helicopters collided while attempting to land near Nepal's Everest Base Camp on Tuesday, police said. The helicopters, operated by Fishtail Air and Air Dynasty, collided at around 8.11 a.m. local time. PTI

Iran President says return to war benefits 'no one' after U.S. strikes

The Qeshm attack comes just hours after Trump signalled a deal with Iran 'could happen'; Tehran's Deputy Foreign Minister Gharibabadi says Iran retained the right to 'legitimate self-defence'; Qatar says it remained hopeful of an interim deal in war

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN



Iranians wave flags during a gathering in front of an anti-U.S. billboard in Tehran's Enghelab Square on Tuesday. AFP

Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian said on Tuesday that a return to war would benefit "no one", hours after reported U.S. strikes on an Iranian island in the Strait of Hormuz.

It came as U.S. voters prepared to cast their ballots in midterm elections that threaten President Donald Trump's grip on power.

Iran's chief negotiator in talks with the U.S., Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, said the Islamic republic was "ready for battle with its finger on the trigger", while Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi said Iran retained the right to "legitimate self-defence" after the strikes.

But Mr. Pezeshkian said his government was still trying to resolve the crisis "through dialogue", adding that "no one will benefit from this war" if it reignited, and emphasising that the country's Supreme Leader had recently granted the government new powers to negotiate issues previously "off-limits".

'Defensive strikes'

The U.S. strikes, reported by *The Wall Street Journal*, *CNN*, *The New York Times* and other outlets, hit Qeshm island in the Hormuz waterway, a key flashpoint of the West Asia war that has upended global markets.

Unnamed U.S. officials cited by the outlets described the attacks as defensive in nature.

Asked if Israel was involved in the latest reported strikes, an Israeli military spokesperson told *AFP*, "No".

The reported Qeshm attack came just hours after Mr. Trump signalled a deal with Iran "could happen".

"Iran wants a settlement, as soon as possible," Mr. Trump posted on his Truth Social platform.

Iranian state news agency *IRNA* reported five explosions in rapid succession on Qeshm island, and that some residents reported seeing two aircraft flying in its skies.

Qatar, a mediator in protracted indirect negotiations between the U.S. and Iran, said it remained hopeful of an interim deal in the war.

Bangladesh accuses Hasina of fuelling labour unrest

Press Trust of India
DHAKA



Police officers stand next to a damaged vehicle following a clash with protesting garment workers in Gazipur, Bangladesh. REUTERS

The Bangladesh government on Tuesday accused deposed Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina of fuelling labour unrest as violent garment workers' protests over higher wages entered the fourth day, forcing hundreds of factories to suspend operations and prompting authorities to deploy additional paramilitary forces.

According to the Bangladesh Garments Manufacturers and Exporters Association (BGMEA), new violence forced another 300 factories to shut down, taking the number of affected units to nearly 1,000 since the latest wave of protests began on October 31.

The unrest has spread across Dhaka and its industrial outskirts, including Gazipur, Ashulia, Mirpur and Narayanganj, and Mymensingh district with workers clashing with police, blocking roads and disrupting production.

The workers are demanding a minimum monthly wage of 30,000 taka (₹23,000), more than double the existing 12,500 taka, citing rising prices of food, housing, transport and healthcare that have eroded their purchasing power.

The remarks marked a shift from Rahman's earlier assertion that Ms. Hasina and her disbanded Awami League were politically irrelevant in Bangladesh.

Toll rises to 31 after Russian strike on Ukrainian aid site

Associated Press
KYIV

Rescuers in southern Ukraine continued an intense search on Tuesday for survivors at a bombed-out aid facility and shelter where at least 31 people were killed and dozens were still missing.

Teams of emergency workers and volunteers picked through debris at the cratered blast site in Komyshuvakha, a village in Ukraine's southern Zaporizhzhia region where bodies were pulled from the rubble and carried away in white plastic sheeting. More than 45 residents are still missing.

"The scale of the tragedy is terrifying," Mykhailo Semikin, acting head of the region's military administration, wrote in an online post. "This is one of the worst tragedies in terms of the number of civilian victims in our region since the start of the full-scale war."

Russia launched 289 attack drones, 17 ballistic missiles and 59 cruise missiles across nine regions, triggering emergency power cuts, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said in an online post.

Three days of mourning were declared in Zaporizhzhia, where Russian bunker-busting bombs, some filled with nearly 1.5 tonnes of explosives, were used in Monday's attack.

Sliver of hope



Moments of relief: Palestinian men play football at a field against the backdrop of destroyed buildings in Nuseirat, Gaza Strip. AFP

Ex-Maldives Foreign Minister arrested on sexual abuse charges

Meera Srinivasan



Abdulla Shahid

Former Maldivian Foreign Minister Abdulla Shahid was arrested late on Monday over allegations of sexually abusing a minor, the Maldives Police said.

Mr. Shahid has denied the charges, local media said. He was arrested around 10 p.m. local time following a court order.

The arrest assumes significance as Mr. Shahid is among the prominent presidential aspirants within the main Opposition Maldivian Democratic Party (MDP) for the island nation's 2028 elections.

Mr. Shahid, who was in New Delhi recently, criticised President Mohamed Muizzu's visit to Pakistan in media interviews, accusing him of steering the Maldives in an "anti-India" direction.

In 2021, Mr. Shahid was conferred the Order of the Distinguished Rule of Izzuddin, the Maldives' highest state honour.

(With PTI inputs)

U.S. will stop $4 billion annual security assistance to Israel, announces Trump

Associated Press
WASHINGTON



> You can consider it barter. You can consider military aid or cash... Look, we give them $4 billion of things and money, and they don't need it
>
> **DONALD TRUMP**

The United States will stop providing $4 billion in aid each year to Israel in 2027 but will sell arms to its closest ally in the West Asia, President Donald Trump said on Tuesday.

The Republican President told *Fox News* channel during a phone call on Election Day for the midterms that Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu had approached him about the idea and that they have been talking about it for a couple of years.

Mr. Trump said Israel doesn't need the aid and it is a lot of money for the U.S. to spend. But Mr. Trump also said that U.S. aid to Israel has become a Democratic talking point for candidates such as Michigan U.S. Senate candidate Abdul El-Sayed, a vocal critic of Israel.

Even far-right conservatives, who have supported Mr. Trump in the past, have taken issue with U.S. support for Israel, with prominent commentators like Tucker Carlson openly questioning the value of the relationship.

Military hardware

"You can consider it barter. You can consider military aid or cash," Mr. Trump said. "Look, we give them $4 billion of things and money, and they don't need it. And I was approached by Bibi Netanyahu, and we've been talking about it for a couple of years because it's a lot of money."

But if Mr. Trump intended the announcement to make a last-ditch effort to sway midterm votes, analysts said it likely would not work.

In 2016, President Barack Obama, a Democrat, signed an unprecedented security agreement with Israel to give its military $38 billion over 10 years, amounting to $3.8 billion a year. Under the agreement, Israel's ability to spend part of the funds on Israeli military products was to be phased out and eventually all of the money would be spent on American military industries.

Students blockade dozens of high schools, universities across France

Agence France-Presse
PARIS



Police officers stand in front of protestors holding banners during a demonstration by high school students in Paris on Tuesday. AFP

Students blockaded dozens of high schools and universities across France on Tuesday to maintain pressure on the government over education reforms as trade unions prepared for a nationwide strike.

After returning from a two-week autumn break, some students resumed their protest campaign on Monday, calling on the authorities to renovate dilapidated schools, reduce class sizes and create more university places.

Authorities said on Tuesday that 48 out of France's 3,700 high schools were blocked amid tight security, including in Paris, Rennes and Lyon. The USL student union said 500 schools were blocked.

Fifty-one higher education institutions out of 184 were also disrupted, officials said.

The USL union denounced what it called heavy-handed tactics, with "young people pinned against walls and riot police units deployed" outside schools.

A union representative said the authorities appeared to want to blunt a new day of blockades on Thursday when trade unions have called a nationwide strike.

"We don't even have the right to vote, we can't do anything, so this is our only way of expressing ourselves," a high school student in northwestern Paris said.

Thousands of students also marched in Paris and several other cities.

Education Minister Edouard Geffray spoke out against the action, saying students needed to study and prepare for exams.

"Preventing them from entering their school deprives them of a fundamental right: the right to an education," he said.



A photo shows a mummy-shaped coffin attributed to 2,000-year-old remains of Giupra, a young girl. AFP

Egyptian mummy portraits to come alive in Rome show

Agence France-Presse
ROME

An elegant woman gazes out from her portrait with expressive eyes, a gilded wreath worn in her hair and a gentle, questioning look on her face.

She is one of the 2,000-year-old "Faces of Fayum", startlingly realistic funerary - or mummy - portraits painted after Egypt became part of the Roman empire.

The fragile portraits dating from the first to third centuries AD – painted on thin wooden panels and designed to be placed over the face of mummies – will go on display in Rome in what organisers hail as a "milestone" collaboration between Italy and Egypt.

"Egypt and Rome, the Faces of Fayum", opening on Wednesday at Rome's Ara Pacis museum, also includes mummies, masks, shrouds, jewellery, marble busts, and statuary. The majority of the artefacts come from Egypt, with some allowed to leave the country for the first time.

Such is the case of the "Tondo of the Two Brothers" from Cairo's Egyptian Museum, a freshly restored double portrait from the time of Emperor Hadrian that depicts two curly-haired young men, possibly brothers, with soulful eyes.

Rome's top official for cultural heritage, Claudio Parisi Presicce, called the work an "absolute masterpiece, perhaps the most important pictorial work to have survived from antiquity".

"These are simple wooden panels, often just a few millimetres thick, made of wood... and they were used to depict, through extremely naturalistic painting, the faces of the individuals who were being buried," Mr. Parisi Presicce said.

Rooted in the tradition of Hellenistic painting, the portraits placed over the head of the mummy and secured into its wrappings come from a relatively brief period between the first and third centuries AD, after Egypt became a province of Rome.

In a fusion of two great civilisations - Egyptian and Roman - the men, women and children portrayed often bear Egyptian features, but wear Roman dress. The exhibition runs until May 2.

Poland plunges into crisis over fight for control of constitutional tribunal

Ruling bloc led by PM Tusk and Opposition-backed President Nawrocki are at loggerheads over appointments made to the tribunal by each side; judges to tribunal are appointed by lower house of parliament; many, including those in ruling camp, call for 'constitutional reset' with amendments

NEWS ANALYSIS

Franciszek Snarski

Shortly after 6 p.m. on Friday (October 30), Poland's Constitutional Tribunal announced that the Tribunal's president Bogdan Święczkowski and vice-president Bartłomiej Sochański had been suspended for a month. The order was signed by judge Anna Korwin-Piotrowska, one of five Sejm(lower house of the Parliament)-elected judges whose oaths President Karol Nawrocki has refused to accept. Police cordoned off the Tribunal building as a mass of protesters tried to force their way through, and Mr. Nawrocki turned his Senegal-bound plane back to Warsaw. Just before 1 a.m., he walked into the Tribunal and addressed the present members of the judicial body, "You are not Constitutional Tribunal judges". A decade-long legal dispute had moved into the building itself.

The Tribunal has 15 judges, each elected by the Sejm for nine years. It can strike down laws and review bills the President sends for referral to it before his decision to sign or veto.

In October 2020, it ruled abortion for foetal defects unconstitutional; such cases accounted for 1,074 of the 1,110 legal abortions in 2019. In 2021, it issued two rulings declaring parts of the founding EU Treaties incompatible with Poland's Constitution; in December 2025, the Court of Justice of the EU ruled that the Tribunal "does not meet the requirements of an independent and impartial tribunal established by law".

Poland's directly elected President holds the right to veto laws passed by its parliament. A President and a Tribunal aligned against a government can each stop its legislation.

A three-way veto

In 2015, then President Andrzej Duda refused the oaths of five judges elected by the outgoing PO (Civic Platform) party majority; the incoming PiS (Law and Justice) party majority elected replacements. In October 2023, PiS came first with 35.4% of the vote, but Civic Coalition (rebranded PO), Third Way, and the Left formed a 248-seat majority in the 460-seat Sejm, pledging to restore the rule of law. In October 2024, Mr. Duda referred Sejm's two Tribunal reform laws to the Tribunal itself. Mr. Nawrocki, backed by PiS, won the presidency in June 2025 with 50.89% of the vote, and by June 2026 had issued a record 37 vetoes, fact-checker Demagog found.

An override of the Presidential veto needs three-fifths of Sejm votes cast, or 276 if all deputies vote; the current coalition's Tribunal candidates in March 2026 received 236 or 237 votes, *Polskie Radio* reported. Three former Tribunal presidents - Marek Safjan, Jerzy Stępień, and Andrzej Zoll - warned in July that "the state no longer has safeguards".

The European Commission closed its Article 7 rule-of-law procedure against Poland in May 2024, and frozen EU recovery funds were released. But on July 12, 2024, the Sejm rejected a bill decriminalising abortion up to 12 weeks, with deputies from the coalition's own Polish People's Party (PSL) among those voting against.



Police stand guard during a protest outside the premises of Poland's Constitutional Tribunal after the suspension of its president and vice-president in Warsaw on October 31. REUTERS

In 2026, the Sejm elected eight judges; Mr. Nawrocki swore in three.

On May 12, a Tribunal panel ruled that the law does not oblige the President to swear in Sejm-elected judges, a ruling the government does not recognise. The coalition's own choices drew criticism too: on September 4, it elected Maciej Berek, a serving Minister, who Prime Minister Donald Tusk had called his "right-hand man", despite pledging to "depoliticise" the court, *Notes from Poland* reported.

Ms. Korwin-Piotrowska's order accuses Mr. Święczkowski of barring the five judges, ignoring a May 2026 interim measure of the European Court of Human Rights ordering them admitted, and failing to convene the General Assembly of judges to adopt the 2027 budget.

She cited Article 130 of the Common Courts Act, which allows a judge's suspension for up to a month, amid a "state of higher constitutional necessity", *Rzeczpospolita* reported. The State Protection Service, which answers to the Interior Ministry, escorted seven of this year's eight judges into the building. Justice Minister Waldemar Żurek filed five motions to lift the immunity of Mr. Święczkowski and Mr. Sochański. On October 31, Mr. Tusk said reform had been "blocked by the President and PiS" and that "on certain matters there can be no compromise".

In a statement read by his chief of staff, Mr. Nawrocki called the events "a forceful takeover of a constitutional body"; the Tribunal's X account spoke of "the crime of a coup d'état".

'Tribunal can't be saved'

The government coalition has itself split: on October 31, PSL leader Władysław Kosiniak-Kamysz and Szymon Hołownia of Poland 2050 attended Mr. Nawrocki's consultations. They were joined by PiS, far-right Confederation and far-left Razem Opposition parties; KO and the Left stayed away, *TVN24* reported.

Mr. Hołownia said the Tribunal in its current form "cannot be saved". Several participants backed a "constitutional reset" ending all current judges' terms with Constitutional amendments.

Former Prime Minister Mateusz Morawiecki, previously a PiS member, announced a no-confidence motion. European Commissioner Michael McGrath cited the Venice Commission's view that appointing judges falls within "the competence of the Sejm", without endorsing the suspension. An IBRiS poll for *Rzeczpospolita* on October 16-17 found 32% backed Mr. Nawrocki on the oath dispute, 27.8% Mr. Tusk, and 32.7% neither.

Marcin Matczak, a University of Warsaw law professor and critic of PiS's 2015-2023 judicial changes, called the legal basis "non-existent for a million reasons", arguing that Article 130 gives the power to suspend to the Justice Minister, who does not oversee the Tribunal.

Ombudsman Sylwia Gregorczyk-Abram called "constitutional necessity" an "extra-legal view".

Supreme Court judge Włodzimierz Wróbel noted that Article 130 has been previously applied to Supreme Court judges, and that a disciplinary court must decide whether the order was justified "or is a usurpation".

The General Assembly Ms. Korwin-Piotrowska called for November 3 needs 10 of 15 judges present, two more than currently in office.

The Helsinki Foundation for Human Rights, which saw "no clear legal basis" for the order, looked further ahead: a future Sejm, it warned, could elect a long-serving judge who would take over the Tribunal the same way.

(Franciszek Snarski is a Master's student in European Affairs at Sciences Po Paris)

Israeli Opposition bloc gathers to strategise how to oust Netanyahu

Agence France-Presse
HERZLIYA

The Israeli Opposition bloc led by Gadi Eisenkot gathered on Tuesday for the first time since elections as they strategise how to oust Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, with divisions on whether to ally with Arab lawmakers.

Opposition party heads gathered in Herzliya, the tech industry hub north of Tel Aviv where former military chief Eisenkot lives, a week after the election produced an inconclusive result.

Yair Lapid, a centrist former Prime Minister who headed the Opposition in the outgoing parliament, said, as he entered, that Mr. Netanyahu was backing an "extreme and dangerous attempt to invalidate the elections".



Demonstrators rally outside Gadi Eisenkot's residence to protest against the formation of a Jewish-Arab government on Sunday. AP

"What we need to do now is go and form a government, because the conduct of recent days is just a reminder that we must remove Netanyahu and his people from the Prime Minister's Office," Mr. Lapid told reporters.

No side won a majority. Mr. Eisenkot's diverse Opposition bloc won 48 seats while Mr. Netanyahu's camp secured 53, of which 27 are from his Likud party.

Arab parties, which won historic19 seats in the 120-member parliament, could bring Mr. Eisenkot to a majority but the opposition is divided on whether to ally with them, and Arab politicians did not join the talks in Herzliya.

Retreat by the sea



Beating blues: Women relax on a beach at sunset in Dubai, the United Arab Emirates, on Tuesday. AP

As strikes on ships continue, war widens in Black Sea in a test of NATO red lines

Reuters
LONDON/BUCHAREST

After seven strikes on cargo ships near NATO members Romania and Bulgaria last month, the U.S.-led military alliance said it would deploy maritime patrol aircraft, radars, and drones to bolster its eastern flank in the Black Sea.

Three days later, on October 23, another ship was struck just outside Romanian waters. And last week a Greek container ship was sunk by naval drones in Bulgaria's exclusive economic zone.

Unabating attacks show how the escalating maritime war between Russia and Ukraine is expanding into a major challenge for NATO in the Black Sea that has left littoral member states such as Romania and Bulgaria exposed.

Military analysts said they had little doubt that these were Russian attacks. A naval drone seen on video of the last strike resembled a Russian variant, according to shipping security firm Ambrey.

"I think it's undeniably an escalation," said Sidharth Kaushal, a senior fellow at the London-based RUSI think-tank.

Russia denies targeting Ukraine's neighbours with drones and says that European governments are the ones escalating the war in Ukraine by supplying military aid. Russia's Defence Ministry did not respond to a request for comment for this article.

'Russia testing red lines'

Many of the ships hit in October were anchored near or sailing to or from a key Romanian canal used by Ukraine for exports. One was in Romanian territorial waters, while the other eight were in its or Bulgaria's exclusive economic zone.

Iulia Joja, director of the Black Sea programme for the Washington-based Middle East Institute think-tank, said Russia's attacks were taking into account the West's aversion to escalation.

"This is about testing these red lines, with full awareness that we will do everything possible to take the most minimal measures," Ms. Joja said, drawing a comparison with Russian drone incursions into NATO airspace in recent years.

A NATO official said Russian actions aimed at dissuading NATO allies from supporting Ukraine were a serious security threat and that the alliance's commitment to defending all its members, including those on the Black Sea, was "ironclad".

The official said there was a clear need for cost-effective counter-drone capabilities, but that the alliance had already committed to investing more than $40 billion in counter-drone capabilities in the next five years.

For Romania, the Black Sea is a crucial waterway for trade and home to its offshore Neptun Deep project that will make it the European Union's largest gas producer next year. Neptun Deep was approached by a naval drone in August.

Bucharest has accused Russia of "systematic" strikes on civilian ships but stopped short of attributing individual attacks, citing the need for forensic evidence. Sofia has not blamed Russia, but said some of the attacks seem to benefit it.

The strikes come at a time when Washington is reassessing its military presence in Europe as it focuses on China. The U.S. withdrew 1,000 troops from Romania last year.

"It's a moment in the transatlantic relationship that Putin likely wants to use," said a senior Romanian official. "The EU and NATO's attention is important and their forces are currently focusing towards the north and the Baltics."

While NATO has reinforced its "enhanced forward presence" for the Baltics and Poland, Ms. Joja said it had not done the same in Romania despite Bucharest's requests. "Brussels and Washington still don't seem to have decided whether the Black Sea is fully part of the NATO commitment," she said.

The Romanian official highlighted Romania's pressing need for surface-to-air interceptors and radar systems to counter threats.

Ms. Joja said the limited availability of cheap interceptor weapons, exacerbated by the war in Iran, was a central problem for the West.

400 vessels hit in a year

The surge in strikes on shipping in the Black Sea has strangled a major conduit for exports of grain and oil, which is used by both Russia and Ukraine.

The two sides hit 317 merchant and other vessels in the Black Sea and Sea of Azov between May and October, a more than four-fold rise from the 74 vessels they struck in the previous half-year, according to Tomas Alexa, a senior analyst at Ambrey Analytics.

The tempo of attacks has fluctuated ahead of the fifth anniversary of Russia's full-scale invasion in February.

Ukraine carried out 137 attacks on ships compared with 92 Russian ones in the third quarter, while in October, Russia hit 38 compared with 5 Ukrainian strikes, Ambrey said.

A FILLIP

Prasidh fit for New Zealand Tests, to play India-A match: sources



FILE PHOTO: K. MURALI KUMAR

India pacer Prasidh Krishna was on Tuesday declared fit for the two-match Test series against New Zealand starting on November 19, according to sources. The pacer is also expected to play the third 'Test' between India-A and New Zealand-A from November 7 to 10 at Lincoln.

BLISTERING KNOCK

Uttarakhand's Prema smashes fastest fifty in women's T20s



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

India all-rounder Prema Rawat slammed an unbeaten 14-ball half-century to register the fastest fifty in women's T20 cricket. The Uttarakhand player achieved the feat against Hyderabad in a senior Women's T20 Trophy match at Pune on Monday. She hit six boundaries and four sixes to set up the 89-run win.

YOUTH OLYMPICS

Judoka Khushbu strikes silver, swimmer Dhinidhi bags bronze



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Judoka Khushbu Rajakbhai won silver in women's 63kg category, losing to Germany's Jolina Reinhold in the final, while Dhinidhi Desinghu claimed bronze in the women's 100m freestyle in 56.27s behind Croatia's Ana Bobanovic (55.89s) and New Zealand's Alyssa Lawson (56.13s) at the Youth Olympic Games in Dakar on Monday.

ANOTHER CROWN

Velavan Senthilkumar claims Czech Open squash title



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Indian squash player Velavan Senthilkumar clinched the second PSA Copper-level title of his career by winning the $35,000 Czech Open in Brno. The fourth-seeded 28-year-old defeated top seed Greg Lobban of Scotland 13-11, 11-5, 8-11, 11-7 for his 12th PSA Tour crown.

Pradosh, Ajith Ram pile more misery on Chandigarh

The former hits a double ton while the latter brings up his maiden First Class hundred as the visitor declares its first innings at 571 for seven before reducing the host to 49 for three at close on day two

RANJI TROPHY

Sports Bureau
CHANDIGARH

If Monday's opening day was one of prayers being answered, Tuesday turned into a day of gifts for Tamil Nadu as Pradosh Ranjan Paul helped himself to a second First Class double hundred (208, 335b, 14x4), while Ajith Ram brought up his maiden First Class century (115 n.o., 219b, 10x4).

The duo piled on the agony for the host as the visitor declared its first innings at a mammoth 571 for seven on the second day of the Ranji Trophy Elite Group D clash against Chandigarh at the Sector-16 Ground here.

The day began with overnight batter G. Ajitesh departing in just the second over of the morning as medium-pacer Rohit Dhanda breached his defence.

Thereafter, Pradosh and Ajith Ram took charge.

The two initially took their time to settle down, showing patience and wearing down the bowlers before gradually opening up. Once they found their rhythm, the runs began to flow. There were delightful square drives, crisp drives through the covers and pulls whenever the bowlers dropped short as the pair made the most of the scoring opportunities.



Pure joy: It was a memorable day for Pradosh and Ajith Ram. R.V. MOORTHY

Pradosh reached his double hundred with a flick off a fuller-length delivery towards square-leg, letting out a roar before he was eventually castled by Chiragvir Dhindsa.

Ajith Ram then cut loose alongside skipper Sai Kishore, taking on the spinners and finding the boundaries with greater freedom.

He brought up his maiden three-figure mark with a boundary and yelled in delight, while Sai Kishore's cameo (36 n.o., 35b, 2x4, 3x6) added to Chandigarh's misery before TN declared.

In reply, Chandigarh lost three wickets to finish the day at 49 for three in 20 overs, trailing by 522 runs.

The scores: Tamil Nadu — 1st innings: Vimal Khumar c Arjit b Nikhil 11, N. Jagadeesan b Bhagmender 52, Pradosh Ranjan Paul b Chiragvir 208, B. Indrajith c & b Nishunk 51, Andre Siddarth c & b Bhagmender 13, G. Ajitesh b Rohit 34, Ajith Ram (not out) 115, Sonu Yadav lbw b Chiragvir 27, Sai Kishore (not out) 36; Extras (b-8, lb-7, w-5, nb-4): 24; Total (for seven wkts. decl. in 154 overs): 571.

Fall of wickets: 1-38, 2-92, 3-231, 4-254, 5-322, 6-448, 7-504.

Chandigarh bowling: Jagjit 21-5-61-0, Nikhil 15-1-42-1, Rohit 26-3-97-1, Nishunk 29-1-122-1, Bhagmender 28-2-102-2, Chiragvir 30-0-112-2, Arjun 5-0-20-0.

RANJI TROPHY SCORES — ROUND FOUR, DAY TWO

Elite: Group A: At Kanpur: Baroda 355 in 115.3 overs (Dhruv Patel 124, Shashwat Rawat 47, Mitesh Patel 49, Manan Solanki 50, Kartik Yadav 5/104) vs. Uttar Pradesh 196/0 in 55 overs (Adarsh Singh 96 batting, Madhav Kaushik 90 batting).

At Panaji: Goa 397 in 119.4 overs (Abhinav Tejrana 73, Snehal Kauthankar 178 n.o., Darshan Misal 53, Suraj Kashyap 5/90) vs. Bihar 107 in 26.1 overs & 63/3 in 22 overs (Ayush Loharuka 47).

At Nagpur: Madhya Pradesh 209 & 19/1 in six overs vs. Vidarbha 334 in 103.3 overs (Akshay Wadkar 100 retd. hurt, Nachiket Bhute 97).

At Srinagar: Pondicherry 385 in 93.2 overs (Neyan Shyam Kangayan 70, Mohit Kale 73, Ankit Sharma 45, Sagar Trivedi 65, Sunil Kumar 6/98) vs. Jammu & Kashmir 149/0 in 50.3 overs (Qamran Iqbal 68 batting, Shubham Khajuria 80 batting).

Group B: At Guwahati: Assam 135 vs. Karnataka 496/5 in 117 overs (Rohan Patil 89, Mayank Agarwal 72, K.V. Aneesh 142 batting, Aneeshwar Gautam 83, Manvanth Kumar 53 batting).

At Agartala: Tripura 268 in 92 overs (Sridam Paul 86, Sentu Sarkar 46, Manisankar Murasingh 42, Bikramjit Debnath 61 n.o., Parth Bhut 5/65) & 54/4 in 22 overs vs. Saurashtra 118 in 45.5 overs (Parvez Sultan 5/25, Sandip Sarkar 4/48).

At Hyderabad: Chhattisgarh 284 in 90.1 overs (Anuj Tiwary 72, Vikalp Tiwari 69) vs. Hyderabad 275/9 in 83 overs (Rahul Radesh 72, K. Himateja 46, Dharmendrasinh Jadeja 5/84).

At New Chandigarh: Punjab 592/9 decl. in 156 overs (Salil Arora 144, Sanvir Singh 205, Emanjot Chahal 122) vs. Andhra Pradesh 20/0 in nine overs.

Group C: At Bhubaneswar: Jharkhand 258/5 in 108 overs (Aditya Singh 94 batting, Anukul Roy 89) vs. Odisha.

At Kolkata: Bengal 143 vs. Maharashtra 207/9 in 79 overs (Tanay Sanghvi 57 batting).

At Ahmedabad: Gujarat 534/9 decl. in 144.2 overs (Abhishek Desai 42, Aarya Desai 95, Urvil Patel 210 n.o., Vishal Jayswal 77) vs. Kerala 74/3 in 23 overs.

At New Delhi: Services 266 vs. Delhi 299/6 in 90 overs (Priyansh Arya 58, Ayush Doseja 78, Sumit Mathur 80 batting).

Group D: At Dehradun: Haryana 153 vs. Uttarakhand 296/7 in 122 overs (Aarav Mahajan 51, Dega Nischal 148 batting, Kunal Chandela 56, Kanishk Chouhan 4/55).

At Mumbai: Mumbai 396 in 123.3 overs (Angkrish Raghuvanshi 78, Siddhesh Lad 47, Sarfaraz Khan 55, Akash Anand 52, Shams Mulani 71, Himanshu Sangwan 4/88) vs. Railways 116/2 in 35 overs.

At Chandigarh: Tamil Nadu 571/7 decl. in 154 overs (N. Jagadeesan 52, Pradosh Ranjan Paul 208, B. Indrajith 51, Ajith Ram 115 n.o.) vs. Chandigarh 49/3 in 20 overs.

At Dharamshala: Rajasthan 78 & 297/4 in 87 overs (Rohan Rajbar 140, Mahipal Lomror 97) vs. Himachal Pradesh 153.

Plate: At Anand: Arunachal Pradesh 285 vs. Mizoram 366/3 in 101 overs (Lalhruaizela 69, Chinmay Sutar 135 batting, Manender Singh 73).

At Ahmedabad: Sikkim 432 in 133.3 overs (Nilesh Lamichaney 40, Ashish Thapa 107, Parth Palawat 86, Gurinder Singh 42, Kranthi Kumar 66, Satyajeet Bachhav 41) vs. Manipur 126/4 in 44 overs.

At Shillong: Nagaland 254 in 69.5 overs (Rongsen Jonathan 69, Nagaho Chishi 68, Akash Choudhary 4/66, Manish Sharma 4/67) & 73/3 in 25 overs vs. Meghalaya 144 in 46.4 overs (Anil Gupta 4/50).

Chandigarh — 1st innings: Nehal Pajni b Gurjapneet 8, Arjun Azad lbw b Sai Kishore 21, Manan Vohra b Sai Kishore 15, Arjit Pannu (batting) 3, Akshit Rana (batting) 1; Extras (lb-1): 1; Total (for three wkts. in 20 overs): 49.

Fall of wickets: 1-28, 2-34, 3-48.

Tamil Nadu bowling: Gurjapneet 7-2-16-1, Saravana Kumar 3-0-14-0, Sai Kishore 7-3-14-2, Ajith Ram 3-1-4-0.

PBKS likely to secure Hardik in exchange for Arshdeep and Vishnu

IPL

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI



Hardik.
FILE PHOTO: EMMANUAL YOGINI

Punjab Kings (PBKS) is understood to be closing in on a deal to acquire Mumbai Indians all-rounder Hardik Pandya in a surprise trade ahead of the Indian Premier League (IPL) 2027 season. The Ricky Ponting-coached franchise has reached an advanced stage of negotiations with MI. India pacer Arshdeep Singh and wicketkeeper-batter Vishnu Vinod are likely to move in the opposite direction.

The Hindu understands that the senior managements of the two franchises have all but agreed on the proposed exchange, with the documentation expected to be processed by the IPL executives. An official announcement is likely later this week ahead of the retention deadline of November 17.

PBKS' interest in acquiring a match-winning all-rounder, even at the cost of a key fast bowler, is understood to have followed an initial approach from a senior MI official.

Once PBKS agreed to the possibility of bringing Hardik on board, discussions centred on Arshdeep and Vishnu as the players to be released. Mumbai, meanwhile, had explored the possibility of trading Hardik with at least three other franchises. Besides Punjab, Kolkata Knight Riders was the only other team whose discussions with MI progressed to the next stage, with a potential multi-player deal being considered.

With Hardik seemingly headed to PBKS, it remains to be seen whether KKR will pursue another high-profile player from the MI stable.

Arshdeep's likely departure could also trigger another deal for PBKS. The franchise may approach Lucknow Super Giants for a swap involving left-arm pacer Mohsin Khan and Australia all-rounder Marcus Stoinis.

Vaishnavi stuns Burrage, posts maiden win on Tour



Showing character: Vaishnavi dug deep to take out the experienced Burrage. R. RAGU

WTA CHENNAI OPEN

Nihit Sachdeva
CHENNAI

Vaishnavi Adkar added another highlight to her breakout season as the Indian wild card upset Britain's Jodie Burrage 3-6, 6-3, 7-5 in a thriller to record her maiden Tour-level win at the WTA Chennai Open on Tuesday.

The 21-year-old from Maharashtra, who began the year as World No. 681, has nearly halved her ranking and entered this week's WTA 250 event as the host nation's best player.

Despite a nervous start, Vaishnavi secured an incredible come-from-behind victory against Burrage in two hours and 46 minutes on a pleasant evening at the SDAT Stadium in Nungambakkam.

Former World No. 85 Burrage put the pressure straight away on Vaishnavi with a love hold, featuring two aces, in the opening game. Vaishnavi immediately dropped her serve and fell further behind.

Perhaps, to get rid of that nervousness, she needed a bit of luck and it finally came when a perfectly fine backhand from the Brit clipped the tape and went wide.

Vaishnavi reeled off three games in a row. Even though that advantage didn't last long, she was no more overwhelmed by the occasion.

During a lengthy deuce game at 1-1 in the second set, Vaishnavi produced winning lobs from both wings to hold serve, even forcing Burrage to applaud. Vaishnavi managed to force a third set and even ran to a 3-1 lead in the decider before her rival launched a barrage of forehand winners.

Burrage earned herself the chance to serve for the match at 5-3. However, Vaishnavi refused to budge and ultimately outlasted her much experienced opponent.

Top results (first round): Vaishnavi Adkar bt Jodie Burrage (GBr) 3-6, 6-3, 7-5; Janice Tjen (Ina) bt Katherine Hui (USA) 6-1, 6-2; Polina Kudermetova (Uzb) bt Viktoria Morvayova (Svk) 6-3, 4-6, 6-1; Anastasia Zakharova (Rus) bt Polina Iatcenko (Rus) 7-6(3), 6-1; Robin Montgomery (USA) bt Panna Udvardy (Hun) 6-4, 1-6, 6-1.

Bhullar in joint lead with three others

K. Keerthivasan
VISAKHAPATNAM

The moment Gaganjeet Bhullar landed in this coastal city and walked around the East Point Golf Course, with its swaying palm trees and verdant hills, he was reminded of Damai Golf & Country Club in Sarawak, Malaysia. It was one of a kind in India, he felt, and immediately fell in love with the course.

Making his debut here, Bhullar carded a three-under 69 to share the lead with Deepak Yadav, who had played here twice before, Ravi Kumar and Kanav Chauhan, on the opening day of the Green Fuels Maritime Invitational 2026, part of the AM Green Indian Golf Premier League Tour.

Starting on the fourth, Bhullar, made five successive pars before his first birdie on the ninth.

After parring the next five, he picked up three consecutive birdies from the 15th before dropping a shot on the 18th, to finish with a 69.

Deepak produced a bogey-free round, Ravi had four birdies and one bogey while Chauhan fired three birdies in a row from the 15th hole to go on top.

(The writer is in Visakhapatnam at the invitation of Indian Golf Premier League).

India faces Korea again for spot in final



Dominant: Harmanpreet's India has been on a roll. HOCKEYINDIA

ACT

Uthra Ganesan
MOHALI

Different city, same opponent. India blanked Korea 8-0 in its final league match of the Asian Champions Trophy on Monday and come Wednesday, the two teams will face off again, this time for a spot in the final.

Monday was the last day of action at the Olympian Surjit hockey stadium in Jalandhar. Wednesday will be the first day of action in the competition at the Olympian Balbir Singh stadium in Mohali.

From the city of one legend of the game to the other, it will also be the return of international hockey to Chandigarh after 17 years.

A lot has changed since then, the extinction of the erstwhile Indian Hockey Federation and the birth of Hockey India being one of them. If Jalandhar was the nursery that never saw international action before, the present stadium in Mohali didn't even exist back then.

The land it stands on was the de facto parking area for the bigger, more popular cricket stadium across the road. It featured some games during the first iteration of the Hockey India League but Wednesday would be the first time the current venue will host a national team.

Barely tested

India has barely been tested so far in its title defence, scoring 34 goals and conceding only five. The fast, green turf in Jalandhar suited the team's play.

The semifinal in Mohali will return to familiar blue surface but barring a disaster, India will be the favourite to advance. Malaysia will take on Japan in the other semifinal.

Impending Test series cloud hangs over immediate ODIs

With spearhead Bumrah being rested for the five-match series, India will have to make do with an inexperienced bowling attack; New Zealand, on the other hand, comes in with an ageing squad

INDIA IN NZ

Press Trust of India
AUCKLAND

The irrepressible Rohit Sharma and the indomitable Virat Kohli are predictably the focus of attention on their last tour of New Zealand but India's thin-on-experience bowling attack gives the host the upper-hand in the five-match ODI series starting on Wednesday.

With Jasprit Bumrah being preserved for Test matches and the duo of Prasidh Krishna and Harshit Rana still some weeks away from an international return, workhorse Mohammed Siraj will have to shoulder additional burden during the series.

The four other specialist fast bowlers – Arshdeep Singh (18), Gurnoor Brar (nine), Anshul Kamboj and Auqib Nabi (one each) – have a cumulative experience of 29 ODIs.

India won't be at full strength due to the World Test Championship games scheduled shortly after the final ODI. The series winds up on November 15 and the first Test starts in Wellington on November 19.

The Kiwis are dealing with their own set of issues as the average age of the ODI squad is between 34 and 35.

The teams (from):
New Zealand: Mitchell Santner (Capt.), Tim Seifert (wk), Henry Nicholls, Tom Latham (wk), Will Young, Glenn Phillips, Daryl Mitchell, Michael Bracewell, Jacob Duffy, Kyle Jamieson, Matthew Fisher, Matt Henry, Blair Tickner, and Nathan Smith.

India: Shubman Gill (Capt.), Shreyas Iyer (Vice-capt.), Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli, K.L. Rahul (wk), Ruturaj Gaikwad, Nitish Kumar, Axar Patel, Anshul Kamboj, Auqib Nabi, Gurnoor Brar, Mohammed Siraj, Arshdeep Singh, Ishan Kishan (wk), Kuldeep Yadav, and Naman Dhir.

Match starts at 7.30 a.m. IST.



Captains' corner: Santner and Gill during their pre-series photoshoot duties. X@BCCI

India-New Zealand H2H in ODIs

	M	India	New Zealand	Tied	NR
Overall	123	63	52	1	7
In New Zealand	45	14	26	1	4

Bracewell expects even contests in one-dayers

S. Dipak Ragav

New Zealand all-rounder Michael Bracewell felt that the rule change introduced last year, which lets teams choose one ball for the last 16 overs of the game, has also helped spinners in ODIs.

While two new balls are used from each end from the start to the 34th over, after that, one ball will be used for the rest of the match. This was done primarily to help bowlers get some reverse swing with a slightly older ball.

"I think the ball gets a little bit softer. So perhaps spinners are bowling more in the last 10 overs. And I guess when that ball does get soft, it becomes a little bit harder to hit out to the boundary. So it can be a positive for a spin bowler to be bowling at the back end," said Bracewell.

When asked about how spinners need to evolve to succeed in ODI cricket where the deck is loaded against them, he highlighted the importance of being unpredictable.

"There's not much that you can change in terms of your line and length. So you've got to try and get the ball to behave slightly differently off the surface through variation in pace or the way that you hold the ball to get it to just react slightly differently off the surface," he added.



Kuldeep. X@BCCI

Looking ahead to the ODI series, the 35-year-old expected a tight contest. "It's two evenly matched teams. We had a great series in India at the start of the year, winning it 2-1, and I think India will will want to right some wrongs".

(Watch New Zealand vs. India 1st ODI live and exclusive on Sony Sports Network and Sony LIV on Wednesday from 7 a.m. IST).



In focus: Jaiswal smashed an unbeaten 155. FILE PHOTO: R.V. MOORTHY

Jaiswal back to his best

Press Trust of India
CHRISTCHURCH

Opener Yashasvi Jaiswal announced a timely return to form with a fluent unbeaten century after a recent dip as India-A drew the second 'Test' against New Zealand-A here on Tuesday.

On the fourth and final day, Jaiswal hammered the New Zealand-A attack to score an unbeaten 155 off just 162 balls.

Yash Rathod also struck an unbeaten 100 as India-A reached 282 for two before the two captains decided to shake hands. Rathod hit nine boundaries in his 122-ball knock.

This was after the home side made 424 in reply to the visitor's first-innings score of 346.

The pitch at the Hagley Oval flattened out considerably, making it very easy for the batters to play their shots, which was evident from India-A's brisk run-rate of 5.35 in the second innings.

The scores:
India-A 346 and 282/2 in 52.4 overs (Jaiswal 155 n.o., Yash Rathod 100 n.o.) drew with New Zealand-A 424.

LIVE TELECAST

New Zealand vs India: First ODI, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 7.30 a.m.
Ranji Trophy: JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.
Champions League: Sony Sports Ten 1, 2, 5 & LIV, 11.15 p.m. & 1.30 a.m. (Thursday)

'Hardik's return will solve the problem around No. 7 position'

Press Trust of India
AUCKLAND

Hardik Pandya's prolonged injury-forced absence has affected the balance of India's ODI side and skipper Shubman Gill believes his lower middle-order will be "sorted" once the flamboyant all-rounder returns to international cricket.

"If Hardik Pandya comes into the team, then our number seven and number eight positions will also be sorted. We will look like a much more balanced team in terms of batting," Gill said on the eve of the first ODI against New Zealand here.

Great player
"Firstly, I think he (Hardik) is a great player. The qualities he brings to the team are possessed by very few players in the world. Having a fast-bowling all-rounder who can bowl in every phase of the game, with the new ball, in the middle overs and at the death, along with the kind of batting he offers, is extremely valuable.

"It has been very unfortunate that he hasn't been able to play since the IPL."

Gill said that he is in touch with the 32-year-old and expects him to play a few domestic games before donning the India blues again.



Step by step: Gill says he expects Hardik to play a few domestic games before donning the India blues again. FILE PHOTO: K.R. DEEPAK

They're still playing very well: Santner on Rohit and Kohli

Press Trust of India
AUCKLAND

Wary of the threat posed by Indian batting stalwarts Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli, New Zealand captain Mitchell Santner wants his bowlers to be very disciplined when they attempt to execute surface-specific strategies against the two veterans in the five-match ODI series beginning on Wednesday.

"They're getting on, but they're still playing very well. We saw it in the last series against the West Indies. I've seen it for a long time. I've seen Rohit in the IPL as well," Santner said at the pre-match press conference.

Cynosure of all eyes
He acknowledged the considerable attention surrounding the two Indian stars. "It draws the crowd. We've had some really good crowd throughout the T20 series, and I expect they'll be the same with Rohit and Virat being here," he said.

"Their role is to go pretty hard at the top and then set up a good score in the middle and let their power come in at the end," Santner said.

Everton beats Newcastle to pile pressure on manager Jaissle

Agence France-Presse
NEWCASTLE

Everton increased the pressure on under-fire Newcastle boss Matthias Jaissle as Thierno Barry, *in pic*, sealed a 1-0 win at St. James' Park on Monday.

The results: Premier League: Newcastle 0 lost to Everton 1 (Barry 49). **LaLiga:** Deportivo La Coruna 2 (Soriano 64, Nsongo 87) bt Osasuna 1 (Budimir 32). **Serie A:** Sassuolo 2 (Lauriente 25, 65) lost to Fiorentina 4 (Pellegrino 45+2, Njie 50, Mastantuono 79, Valdepenas 90+3); Atalanta 0 lost to Parma 3 (Fabbian 41, Zappacosta 47-og, Lontani 58).



Barry. REUTERS

Sindhu, Mirabai elected unopposed as IOA Athletes Commission members

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Olympic medallists P.V. Sindhu and Mirabai Chanu were among the 10 sportspersons declared elected unopposed as members of the Athletes' Commission of the Indian Olympic Association (IOA), on Tuesday. With former track and field athlete Sudha Singh pulling out of the race late on Monday, there was no need to conduct the polls as just 10 candidates were left in the fray for the same number of seats. Returning Officer Sanjay K. Srivastava, on Tuesday, declared all the 10 candidates – five male and five female – to have been elected unopposed.

Earlier on Monday, shuttler K. Srikanth withdrew his candidature.

The chairperson and vice-chairperson – one male and one female in either of the two – of the Athletes' Commission shall be made members of the IOA Executive Council.

Two members – one male and one female – of the Athletes' Commission will become members of the IOA General Body with voting rights. They will take part in the IOA Executive Council elections on December 5 as Athletes' Commission representatives.

The elections for the chairperson and vice-chairperson of the Athletes' Commission, as well as the two representatives for the IOA General Body, will be held later.

IOA Athletes' Commission members: P.V. Sindhu, Mirabai Chanu, Harmanpreet Singh, Salima Tete, Swapnil Kusale, Bhavani Devi, Tajinderpal Singh Toor, Bombayla Devi, Sajan Prakash and Manjeet Singh.



A quip: Allen felt that having a "goldfish memory" would serve him well. FILE PHOTO

Opener Allen will take flight in middle-order for the first time

S. Shrivathsan

New Zealand's Finn Allen is preparing for a test he has never taken before in his international career.

Allen, who has opened the batting in each of his 21 ODI innings thus far, will drop down to the middle-order as an experiment in the run-up to the 2027 World Cup.

An already stern examination could get tougher when he takes strike in the fourth and fifth game against India: the 27-year-old will experience the demands of 50-over cricket in a New Zealand shirt for the first time since 2023.

"It (batting in the middle-order) is a role I have not explored for a long time, so I am excited for the challenge. I have to learn that on the fly. It will be an opportunity to add another string to my bow," Allen said during a virtual interaction.

"I feel that my game is in a good place technically. I need to keep my method and tempo under control, but having the same intent and (aggressive) approach is really important for me. I must feel that I am at a place where I can push or change the game... trying to have impact against spin or in the latter half of an innings."

Allen felt that having a "goldfish memory" would serve him well, especially in a series where he could be under intense scrutiny. "I should go into each game feeling refreshed," he added. The attack-minded batter acknowledged the threat which the India top three of Rohit Sharma, skipper Shubman Gill and Virat Kohli carries.

"They have posed a lot of challenges. They have their methods figured out pretty well. All three of them have the ability to flick a switch and go on the sixth gear when they need to," Allen said. But, can the 'Flying Finn' soar higher than them?

(Watch New Zealand vs. India 1st ODI live and exclusive on Sony Sports Network and Sony LIV on Wednesday from 7 a.m. IST).

Ravinder, Saurabh and Amanpreet clinch team gold in 50m pistol event

SHOOTING

Press Trust of India
DOHA

The Indian troika of Ravinder Singh, Saurabh Chaudhary and Amanpreet Singh clinched the team gold in the men's 50m pistol competition of the ongoing ISSF World Championships here on Tuesday.

Double delight
Ravinder also won the silver medal in the individual competition of the event that is not on the Olympic roster. He was India's top scorer with 559 points, including 11 inner 10s.

Saurabh, a multiple-time World Cup gold-medallist, scored 551, while Amanpreet added 549 to the tally the Indian combined score of 1659.

China gets silver
China's Zhang Bingchen, Lyu Junyi and Feng Linlang totalled 1648 for the silver medal, five points clear of the bronze-winning Korean combination of Hong Suhyeon, Choe Boram and So Seung Seob.

In the individual event, the gold went to Russia's Anton Aristarkhov, who shot 561. Roumania' Luca Joldea claimed the bronze with a score of 558. Rakesh Mane, Himanshu Dhillon, and Paarth Makhija failed to reach the team and individual finals of the men's 10m air rifle event.

Top of the table
India is currently top of the table with a gold and silver.



Huge relief: The Hylo Open triumph was Lakshya's first title of the year. BWF/BADMINTONPHOTO

Just want to play freely and give my best, says Lakshya

Anirudh Velamuri

Lakshya Sen ended his title drought at the Hylo Open in Saarbrucken where he beat Indonesia's Jonatan Christie 21-17, 21-10 in Sunday's final.

It was Lakshya's first trophy of 2026, his second at the event, and his first since the Australian Open last November. The scoreline flatters the story. Lakshya led 18-10 in the opening game before Christie ripped off seven straight points. Doubt, he insists, never entered the room.

"I had to be very patient against Christie and wait for the right chances. He also has a very good attack, so I had to not give him easy chances to finish the rally," Lakshya said in a virtual interaction facilitated by the BAI.

So he took to the net, slowed the tempo, and refused to hand over easy finishes. Their head-to-head is now level (4-4).

The road to the title was rough. A first-round exit at the Denmark Open was followed by a withdrawal from the French Open due to pain in the shoulder.

"I was still a bit rusty in the shot selection," he admitted, arriving in Germany without much rhythm.

It's been a less-than-ideal season fitness-wise for Lakshya, where niggles have not ruled him out of events, but annoyed him enough to disrupt flow.

By the semifinal in Saarbrucken against France's Toma Junior Popov, the touch was back, for which Lakshya credits volume: five matches in a week sharpened him for the business end.

As India's leading men's singles player, he feels the weight too. "There is a lot of pressure. I just want to play freely and give my best every time I play for my country."

Men's singles, in his view, has no clear favourite right now. "Anyone can beat anyone on a given day," he said of the top 15 to 30, and titles, not rankings, are his priority.

A litmus test for India's depleted attack









The Men in Blue will have to contend with limited pace-bowling resources and hope that the quality and depth of their batting do the job, as it did during the early part of the T20I series before running out of steam in the last two encounters



R. Kaushik
AUCKLAND

For cricket followers of this vintage, it might be hard to comprehend that there was an era when Indian cricket wasn't accorded the same respect and reverence it enjoys today. India then wasn't the financial hub of the sport, even though cricket always received excellent patronage. There wasn't such a massive clamour for the Indian team to come calling, the Indian diaspora overseas was laid-back and self-involved, almost to the extent of being timid, and chants of 'India Indiaaaa' at Lord's or the MCG or Basin Reserve or Newlands were few and far between.

Today, of course, all this is *de rigueur*. India is unquestionably the cricket capital of the world, the land that props up the sport globally. Close to eighty percent of the cricketing revenue is generated from there, through sponsorships and through media rights. India's cricketers are the cynosure of all eyes, their presence imperative for TV ratings to shoot up and for sponsors' purse strings to be loosened when they showcase their wares in Australia and Zimbabwe, New Zealand and Nisshin. Over the last three-and-a-half decades, India have thrown up an assembly line of superstars – mainly batting, of course – with the poster boys at different ends of that time-frame spectrum answering to the names of Sachin Tendulkar and Virat Kohli respectively.

Happy confluence

The emergence of Tendulkar and the advent of satellite television coincided with the vision of globalisation espoused by Dr. Manmohan Singh, later to be the Prime Minister, and Montek Singh Ahluwalia in the early 1990s when P.V. Narasimha Rao was the Indian PM. This happy confluence drove the Indian economy forward, and India's cricketing economy grew more than exponentially. As these off-field developments found resonance in on-field displays culminating in two World Cup victories split by four years (2007, T20 World Cup and 2011, 50-over World Cup) which sandwiched India's climb to the top of the Test rankings for the first time in December 2009, the stock of Indian cricket skyrocketed.

The landscape of the sport was inexorably altered when the Indian Premier League took shape in 2007 and came to a fruition the following year with the first edition. Apprehensions about how the tournament would be received were laid to rest on the very first evening when Brendon McCullum ripped the Royal Challengers Bangalore bowling to shreds in the opening match of the tournament to set up a massive win for Kolkata Knight Riders. Suffice to say that cricket hasn't been the same since.

The Black Caps won't be at full strength against an Indian side also missing almost its entire first-choice fast-bowling group for one reason or the other

Because of the pulling power of the Indian team, because of the rapidly climbing sponsorship deals and because the team itself is ranked near the top in the two white-ball formats and has only recently started to slip below the top two slots in the five-day game, Indian cricket is now viewed and treated differently from when it was seen as a necessary evil, no more.

No additional passes

A perceived slight when India were denied additional passes for the 1983 World Cup despite being one of the two finalists was the catalyst for the one-day World Cup moving out of England in 1987, and returning there only twice in the next 32 years as India battened down the hatches. This meteoric rise of the last two and a half decades hasn't come about owing to spite or the need to make a point. It has been organic and seamless, which is why it is understandable if Indian cricket fans aren't entirely familiar with Dunedin.

Dunedin is a port city on New Zealand's south-eastern coast and holds the reputation of being the southernmost venue in the world to hold Test cricket. Carisbrook held that distinction until cricket moved to the University Oval at Logan Park for the 2015 World Cup. When the Otago sun drifted behind the clouds, the extreme cold was impossible to negotiate for the subcontinental teams in particular. They often opened a tour of New Zealand in Dunedin, and within three days, most of them had one eye on the flight back home, such was the depressing mix of the Dunedin weather and the partisan university students rooting unabashedly for the home team.

India have played three, and lost two, of their international fixtures in Carisbrook. The lone victory was India's first overseas Test win, under Tiger Pataudi in February 1968, but the last of their country vs country outings at that ground was back in March 1992, at the World Cup. Since then, in deference to India's superpower status, on the cricket field and on cricket's financial barometer, successive sides have been spared the Dunedin initiation, and it's no different this time around.

India's first all-format tour of New Zealand since just before the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic has already wound up its first-leg, the visitors completing a 3-2 victory in the five-match T20 International face-off. Next up, over the two weeks ahead, is a five-match ODI showdown, seguing into a two-Test series beginning in Wellington on November 19. Understandably, Dunedin is off the radar, though India began their journey in the South Island city of Christchurch with back-to-back T20s, and will wind up their tour with the second Test, also at the Hagley Oval, from November 27.

Back to Eden Park

Having already plied their wares at the Hnry Stadium in Wellington, Eden Park in Auckland and Seddon Park in Hamilton during the 20-over bash, India return to Eden Park for the first of the ODIs on Wednesday. It's a venue that triggers mixed feelings for Indian cricket. It was here that, in the aforementioned 1967-68 Test series, Pataudi's men completed a 272-run triumph in March 1968 to complete an epochal 3-1 victory, their first overseas Test series win.

Since then, though, success has been sporadic, especially in 50-over cricket. India have won just three and lost six – with one game tied – of the 10 ODIs between the teams, the last of those victories coming way back in January 2003. It is this windmill that Shubman Gill and his lads will tilt against on Wednesday in a series that, even before its start, has claimed numerous casualties through injury.

The latest in that list is Devon Conway, the left-handed opener who was ruled out of Wednesday's hostilities with concussion following a collision with Matt Henry during training on Tuesday afternoon. This comes on the heels of Mark Chapman and Rachin Ravindra being rendered *hors de combat* for the entire series with a left hamstring and right shoulder injury respectively, which means that the Black Caps won't be at full strength against an Indian side also missing almost its entire first-choice fast-bowling group for one reason or the other.

Interesting case

While Jasprit Bumrah is being managed so that he is in mint condition for the Test series, to start with, Prasidh Krishna hasn't recovered sufficiently from the hamstring injury sustained last month against West Indies, leaving Mohammed Siraj to shoulder the bulk of the burden. Siraj's is an interesting case - he hasn't been an automatic starter in recent times and only linked up with the ODI side after playing for India-A in the second of three unofficial 'Tests' against their Kiwi counterparts which ended in Christchurch on Tuesday. Even assuming that Siraj is picked in Wednesday's playing XI, his comrades will be from the grouping of Gurnoor Brar, Arshdeep Singh, Auqib Nabi and Anshul Kamboj who, between them, have 29 ODI appearances.

Seam-bowling all-rounder Nitish Kumar is also in the mix but he will part ways with the ODI team after game one, linking up for the final 'A' Test match in preparation for the Test series, which means India will have to do with limited pace-bowling resources and hope that the quality and depth of their batting comes to their rescue, as it did during the early part of the T20I series before running out of steam in the last two encounters.

The quality in the Indian 50-over batting unit starts right at the top, with Gill forming one half of one of the most feared opening combines in the world alongside his predecessor, Rohit Sharma. Between them, the two right-handers have amassed 2972 runs as a pair in just 45 innings at a breathtaking average of 67.54, facilitated by nine century stands and 15 other alliances of between 50 and 99. Their average is comfortably the highest of all the 22 opening pairs to have put on more than 2000 runs in tandem, though their impact extends beyond averages and century stands.

Neither batter is an innings-builder in the old-fashioned sense of the word, and even though some might point out that Rohit is a little more risk-averse than he was when he was the captain, he has lost neither shock value nor his intimidation quotient. Gill, of course, is the consummate master, and in September became the second batter after Rohit - surprise, surprise - to score more than one ODI double hundred. His average after 69 innings is a phenomenal 64.01 and he strikes at 103.31 per 100 balls faced, a 50-over behemoth if ever there was one.

Fact is, Gill is surrounded by two other 50-over behemoths in Rohit and Kohli. The former has three ODI double centuries and the highest ODI score of all-time, a gargantuan 264 against Sri Lanka. No one has more ODI three-figure knocks than Kohli (55), who has now assumed even more dangerous proportions after a gentle tweak in mindset that has opened up the sluice gates and allowed his attacking juices to flow unchecked.

There is a lot more to India's ODI batting than just this handsome top three, who feasted on the West Indian bowling in the three-match series at home less than a month back. But it is to this troika that India will look for guidance and momentum. Vice-captain Shreyas Iyer, who will take over the reins for the final two games in Mount Maunganui when Gill begins his preparations for the Test series, has settled down nicely into his No. 4 role while K.L. Rahul, the Test vice-captain, relishes batting down the order, often in the role of the finisher, and has left no stone unprepared in his preparation and therefore his match-scenario execution.

New Zealand will offer unique challenges, with matches starting at 3 p.m. local time to facilitate optimal prime-time television viewership back in India. Under lights, when the temperature suddenly dips and an uncomfortable cold takes over, it will be anything but straightforward. But that is precisely the beauty of cricket in New Zealand - take anything for granted, and you will be punished without mercy. A crazy, gripping ride lies ahead.

THE GIST

Over the last three-and-a-half decades, India have thrown up an assembly line of superstars — mainly batting, of course — with the poster boys at different ends of that timeframe spectrum answering to the names of Sachin Tendulkar and Virat Kohli respectively

Having already plied their wares at the Hnry Stadium in Wellington, Eden Park in Auckland and Seddon Park in Hamilton during the 20-over bash, India return to Eden Park for the first of the ODIs on Wednesday

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